

MONTAFON MOONLIGHT

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English-language manuscript

JEONG CHANJU

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CHAPTER 1

Vienna-Bound Plane

Morning, July 28, 2025

Author Jeong, his temples streaked with gray, stepped out of the taxi with his wife, Mrs. Park, immediately upon reaching the third floor of Incheon International Airport's Terminal 2. Shortly afterward, they went to Counter D to check their luggage and then cleared the departure formalities together. At last, with some time to spare, they had a simple breakfast and waited to board their flight to Vienna. The well-cooled international departure lounge was a world apart from the scorching 35°C heat outside. Passengers sat in groups of two or three, waiting impassively for boarding time. Beyond the gate, the Vienna-bound aircraft had already pulled up and stood waiting. On the arrow-straight runway stretching like an expressway, aircraft continuously landed and took off in succession. In the soundproofed lounge, not a single noise from the aircraft reached them. Perhaps because of this, the worlds inside and outside the glass seemed utterly divorced from each other. Beyond the runway, the sky appeared deliberately calm, removed from the bustling scenery below.

In the sky, cumulus clouds like eternal snow hung like snowy mountain peaks, and even these looked unreal. Earth and sky seemed strangely segregated, as if the beginningless, endless sky had stealthily descended from some alien realm. Normally, clouds of various shapes might stir personal emotions, but the cumulus clouds seen through the airport glass seemed indifferent, as if it hardly mattered whether they were there at all, as if they had idly drifted down for a moment from some other sky.

Before long, an announcement for passengers on the Vienna flight came over the speakers. In stark contrast to the apathetic scenery beyond the windows came this profoundly mundane sound: boarding would soon begin at Gate 13. Even before the announcement, passengers had already begun milling around the gate. Westerners outnumbered Koreans. Among them were backpack-toting middle-aged couples, though most looked like college students or young people in light clothing, seemingly traveling on summer break. Author Jeong, seated beside his wife, hoisted his backpack. His wife,

perhaps from nerves, made one final restroom visit. Jeong felt the same urge but held off, since it wasn't urgent.

This was Jeong's third trip to Vienna, and each time his wife, a ceramic artist, accompanied him with a clear purpose. Mrs. Park was also his meticulous manager. She logged local geography and weather information in her notebooks, recorded and later transcribed his interviews, among other support tasks. She always carried a full pharmacopoeia of emergency medicines, cold remedies, digestive aids, antidiarrheals, and *cheongsim-hwan*, herbal calming pills, and monitored his health like a nurse, keeping him in top condition. An avid traveler herself, Mrs. Park considered this no burden; indeed, she secretly anticipated Author Jeong's next research destination.

After presenting his ticket to an airport attendant, Jeong waited for Mrs. Park in the jetway to the Vienna-bound flight. This transitional jetway, merely a temporary connector, nevertheless evoked peculiar sensations. Was this a bridge through clouds? A celestial thoroughfare? Yet it also carried an early pang of separation, the sense that in a few moments they would be cut off from Incheon Airport in both time and space. At the aircraft door, two stewardesses rechecked tickets before guiding passengers down the aisle. Jeong let Mrs. Park, with her superior head for numbers, lead the way. She glanced around once and quickly found their seats, window-side, as always preferred.

"Window seats with wing views."

A smile spread across Mrs. Park's face. But it was too soon to relax. If a woman ended up in the seat beside Jeong, he would have to take the window. Like one magnet's north pole pushing away another's, Mrs. Park would not have her husband sitting next to a woman he didn't know. Jeong also found it uncomfortable to sit beside a female stranger for twelve hours while his wife was on the other side. Fortunately, the passenger beside him turned out to be a man, so there was no need to switch.

Securing his seatbelt, Jeong drew a measured breath. During taxiing, a stewardess demonstrated seatbelt fastening and oxygen mask deployment per the safety briefing. Once on the runway, the plane began to pick up speed, ready for takeoff.

"Sweetheart, it's been seven years."

"Indeed. Our first trip to Austria was in 2015 and the second was in 2018."

Hearing Mrs. Park recall the years of their earlier visits made the time that had passed feel suddenly real. Especially after enduring the COVID-19 crisis for three years and four months, their previous trips to Austria felt like a distant past. A spark of curiosity flared: how would this journey connect

with those memories? He would not know until they landed at Vienna Airport. After all, nothing worldly persists unchanged.

As the plane climbed higher, Mrs. Park took a packet of cheongsim-hwan from her handbag, a pill that calms the heart. She placed half a pill in her mouth and chewed slowly. It was a traditional herbal medicine she would take during takeoff and landing when the external pressure made her ears feel clogged and she grew tense. For her, it was a kind of essential travel medicine. A moment later, perhaps feeling mentally calmer, she spoke briefly.

“I can see the sea.”

“It looks like we haven’t left Korea yet.”

In what appeared to be the West Sea, islands large and small were visible, but they too would soon vanish from view. Suddenly, Mrs. Park summoned up the memory of Jeong in 2015.

“Back then, you were very hesitant about going to Austria. You seemed like you didn’t want to go.”

“That was because of my serialized novel. I was worried the trip would break my writing rhythm. It felt like a burden.”

What Author Jeong said was true. At that time, he was in the midst of serializing on the Jeollanam-do provincial government website a seven-volume historical epic featuring Yi Sun-sin, supreme commander of the Joseon navy, who, during Japan’s 16th-century invasion of Korea known as the Seven Years’ War, had won 23 out of 23 naval battles. He had prepared for a decade and was freshly into his three-year contract with the province, and the weight of expectation pressed heavily. In the decade before serialization began, he had visited the seas where Admiral Yi had won his victories, checking water depths to understand why the battles had been fought there, why the ironclad *geobukseon* (turtle ship) had been built, and how the main warship, the *panokseon*, was constructed to be more resistant to cannon fire than Japanese vessels. This serialized novel was therefore a major work summing up Jeong’s literary career and he was understandably tense about it.

Now the plane was climbing toward 30,000 feet to pick up speed. It cruised leisurely above the glacier-like white clouds, as though approaching the boundary between the troposphere and the stratosphere. The uniform cloudscape created an illusion of stationary hovering rather than forward motion, while flight attendants rested in their jumpseats.

“Dear, are you sleeping?”

“No, I was thinking about Chairwoman Kwon.”

“I was thinking of her just now too.”

Had Kwon Suk-nyeo (Sonja Steindl-Kwon), the Austrian-Korean chairwoman of IMK, not visited Jeong's home, which they called Ibuljae, their 2015 trip to Austria would never have happened. While traveling between Korea and Austria, she had bought Jeong's novels at the bookstore inside Incheon Airport, and that *inyeon*, a karmic connection, eventually brought her to Ibuljae. Originally one of the first cohort of Korean nurses dispatched to Germany, she had made her way to Austria, changed careers, and in 1992 founded IMK, a classical music concert planning company. It was a self-made success story, all the more remarkable given that she had known nothing about classical music before. A devout Catholic, she was even responsible for flower arrangements at her parish. That such a person would be captivated by Jeong's Buddhist-themed writing and travel all the way to Ibuljae was nothing short of surprising. When she once showed him her notebook, an entire page filled with the titles of his books, he recognized her sincerity immediately.

It would be no exaggeration to say that the Jeong couple's trip to Austria could not have happened without Chairwoman Kwon's encouragement or invitation.

CHAPTER 2

Three Phone Calls

The reason Chairwoman Kwon invited Author Jeong was rather peculiar. At least, that was how Author Jeong interpreted it. It was because Chairwoman Kwon wanted to introduce Austrian composer Herbert Willi, with whom she had a deep musical connection, to Author Jeong. But Author Jeong had no connection to Mr. Willi and couldn't fathom why they had to meet. So, the idea of Author Jeong meeting Mr. Willi was entirely Chairwoman Kwon's one-sided plan. *Even if I go to Austria, do I really have to meet Mr. Willi?* Author Jeong knew nothing about Mr. Willi's life or music, and since he wasn't well-versed in classical music, he hesitated even more. But Chairwoman Kwon was a highly focused businesswoman with exceptional resourcefulness. She pursued her goals patiently and tirelessly, and never once gave up. Her founding of IMK, a classical music concert planning company, and its growth into Austria's premier performance agency alone testified to her determination and passion.

Chairwoman Kwon first visited Ibuljae, the mountain retreat where Author Jeong lived, in late February 2013. At winter's end, several days of spring-like weather caused the buds of green, white, and red plum blossoms along Ibuljae's yard to swell. In a few days, the frogs seemed likely to awaken from hibernation. When the plum blossoms began to bloom, the frogs would rouse from their winter sleep and answer with their croaking.

It was rare for an Austrian expatriate to visit Ibuljae as a reader of Author Jeong's work. A Korean-American who had read his novel *Dasan's Love* in San Francisco had once visited, but such occurrences were far from common. More recently, Professor Matty Wegehaupt from Lawrence University in Wisconsin had proofread the English translation of *Gwangju Arirang*, a novel about the Gwangju Uprising, and visited Ibuljae twice, but his purpose was clearly different from Chairwoman Kwon's.

Professor Matty, a scholar of East Asian history, had been deeply moved by the May 1980 Gwangju Uprising and even lived in Gwangju for three years.

Chairwoman Kwon stayed for three nights and four days at Ssangbong-sa, a thousand-year-old temple below Ibuljae. She slept at the temple at night and came up to Ibuljae during the day to chat.

Gradually, Author Jeong and his wife, Mrs. Park, came to understand her better. She explained that she was from Yecheon and belonged to the Andong Kwon clan. Her father had run a velvet fabric factory but went bankrupt, so due to the family's financial hardship she graduated from the tuition-free National Medical Center Nursing School. Later, she came to Europe as part of the first cohort of nurses dispatched to Germany and, together with two other nurses, found work at a hospital in Germany. One of them, unable to adjust to German food and weeping whenever she felt homesick, eventually returned to Korea. Unlike that nurse, she enjoyed German food immensely. After meeting her Austrian doctor husband, she laughed, saying that the moment she stepped off the plane at Vienna Airport, she felt as comfortable as if she had come home.

Of all her stories, what struck Author Jeong most was what she said upon leaving Ibuljae: "I slept so peacefully at Ssangbong-sa. I had thought only churches suited me, but a temple felt like well-tailored clothing." At the time, Author Jeong had his own guess as to why she said this, perhaps her mother had frequented temples, or she herself had gone on childhood outings to them. He took her words to mean that she had rediscovered her identity at Ssangbong-sa, and they came back to him from time to time afterward.

In any case, she returned to Austria and, a few months later, phoned with news. She had told Herbert Willi about Author Jeong's Buddhist-themed novels and meditative essays, and he had shown interest, asking if any had been translated into English. Perhaps, after finding Author Jeong's work fascinating, she had mentioned it thinking that Mr. Willi, who liked Koreans, would also take an interest. She then encouraged Author Jeong to come to Austria anytime. Rather than curtly refusing, he answered that he would consider it: "I'm currently serializing the novel *The Moon Reflected in a Thousand Rivers* on the online platform Media Buddha, so I'd need to check my schedule." As he was immersed in the serialization, he could not give a definite answer.

The Moon Reflected in a Thousand Rivers was a distinctive historical novel. Set in the Joseon era, when Koreans used borrowed Chinese characters to express themselves, it portrayed how the virtuous King Sejong, wishing to create and promote an alphabet easier than Chinese characters for his people, secretly collaborated with the eminent monk Shinmi to devise Hangeul, concealing the project from the mainstream scholars who revered China. Therefore, without solid historical verification, the story would lose

persuasiveness. For Author Jeong, *The Moon Reflected in a Thousand Rivers* was several times harder to write than his other novels, so deciding to travel abroad was not something he could take lightly.

Although Author Jeong had not given a definite yes, it was clear that Chairwoman Kwon had misunderstood him as saying he would come to Austria when the opportunity arose. In Korea, saying "I'll consider it" tends to imply postponement, but in Austria it seemed to be understood as "I will make an effort to do it." This was evident because a few months later Chairwoman Kwon again called Author Jeong from overseas.

"When will you be coming?"

"I'll let you know once I finish the serial novel I'm working on now. Since I'll also be writing a serial next year, I can't give you a definite answer right away."

"I told Mr. Willi about you, and he is very eager to meet you. He is such a remarkable person that, if an unfinished Mozart score were discovered, they would ask him to complete it."

Chairwoman Kwon appeared to hold Mr. Willi in great respect, affection, and even love. Mozart was born in 1756 and Mr. Willi in 1956, meaning there was a two-hundred-year gap between them, yet Chairwoman Kwon even regarded Mr. Willi as Mozart's reincarnation.

Chairwoman Kwon's third call came in January 2015, a year later. Author Jeong had just finished serializing *The Moon Reflected in a Thousand Rivers* and was about to begin another serial novel. Just then, the head of the Jeollanam-do Provincial Office's Arts Bureau visited Ibuljae, saying it was under the instructions of the newly appointed governor, and proposed serializing Admiral Yi Sun-sin's patriotic determination to save the nation and his steadfast loyalty on the provincial website. The governor was a politician who knew what work Author Jeong was preparing. He had visited Ibuljae when he was a National Assembly member. During their conversation, he had said, "They call Jeolla the 'Land of Righteousness,' but I can't quite grasp that concept." Author Jeong replied, "There isn't a single spot along Jeolla's coast that isn't imbued with Admiral Yi Sun-sin's spirit," adding that he had done field research and studies on Yi Sun-sin for over ten years, and signed a copy of his novel *Dasan's Love*. This further developed their relationship. Later, he visited Ibuljae again and said, "Perhaps because I'm a former journalist, I like writers whose sentences are precise," expressing once more his trust in Author Jeong.

In any case, Chairwoman Kwon's third call was extremely provocative. She may have been somewhat disappointed that, despite calling twice internationally, Author Jeong's replies were unsatisfactory. "I think it's time

to show you a red card. Mr. Willi says to bring you over even if he has to kidnap you. What should I do?"

Chairwoman Kwon's tone was half-demanding, half-pleading.

Author Jeong felt it was now time to make a firm decision about going to Austria. Chairwoman Kwon's mention of a "red card" brought the words "faith and loyalty" to mind and he felt a pang of conscience. No matter how important his serial novel was, he did not want to break faith with her. Moreover, hearing that Mr. Willi, a man he had never met, had said to bring him over even by kidnapping, made him curious about what kind of person he was. His curiosity was piqued not because Mr. Willi was Austria's top composer, but because, as a writer, he wondered what sort of conversation Willi wished to have.

As if under a spell, Author Jeong found himself making a promise to Chairwoman Kwon. "Chairwoman Kwon, my wife and I will come this autumn."

"I've already arranged accommodations in Vienna. All you have to do is come."

But instead of feeling relieved, he became deeply burdened. His epic novel *Yi Sun-sin's Seven Years*, which he had agreed to serialize for three years on the Jeollanam-do provincial website, had not even begun.

Determination

It had been twenty-five years since Author Jeong ended his Seoul life and moved down to the deep southern mountains, where he built the retreat Ibuljae. Suddenly, he recalled monks he had met in Seoul. Two came first to mind. One was his teacher, the Venerable Beopjeong. Whenever Beopjeong came up from Bulil-am in Suncheon to Seoul, he would summon Jeong, as if silently urging him to someday record his words and deeds. At Beomnyeonsa, the Seoul propagation temple of Songgwang-sa, Venerable Beopjeong once again called for him.

From Jeong's workplace at Saemteo publishing company to Beomnyeonsa was only about a 15-minute drive. Beomnyeonsa stood right next to Gyeongbok Palace, former residence of Joseon kings. Jeong entered the room where Venerable Beopjeong was staying. Venerable Hyeonho, abbot of Beomnyeonsa, treated Beopjeong like an elder brother in the secular world. Though Beopjeong had never once slept there, he always had a room at Beomnyeonsa thanks to Venerable Hyeonho's hospitality. Inside, two guests had already arrived, visitors Venerable Hyeonho meant to introduce to Beopjeong: one a middle-aged woman, the other a man who seemed to be her secretary. Venerable Beopjeong was chatting with them.

The woman spoke: "While visiting European cathedrals last year, I thought it would be nice if there were a temple in Paris. I wanted to create a refuge for Korean expatriates and students living there, because many Koreans unaccustomed to cathedrals seemed to be adrift in Paris."

She added: "If you build a temple in Paris, I will help with everything, from the first brick to its completion. Please allow me to do so."

When the middle-aged woman spoke, the man with her took out a notebook to write it down, but Venerable Beopjeong stopped him:

"There's no need to write it. I didn't bring up the temple to seek help. I was just sharing the thought that came to me in Paris." Seeing the woman's embarrassment, Venerable Beopjeong said: "Thank you for your kind words. But temples must be built from the small offerings of many people. Only

then does each person come to feel a sense of ownership: ‘this is my temple.’”

The woman replied: “You are right. My thinking was short-sighted. But please give me some chance to help, even in a small way.”

Venerable Beopjeong responded: “Thank you. If you want to help me, please help Beomnyeon-sa. For it to truly serve as a propagation center, it needs a cultural hall.”

“Master, that is what I will do.”

Venerable Beopjeong declined the middle-aged woman’s proposal for a Paris temple, instead asking her to support Beomnyeon-sa. He believed cultural facilities were necessary for it to function as a propagation temple. He also shared an anecdote: when the Dalai Lama visited Europe, a priest asked him, “What is Buddhist compassion?” He replied, “Kindness.” Beopjeong remarked that most monks at Korean temples were unkind, a judgment that they lacked compassion. He noted that Europeans were drawn to Buddhism as a way of self-salvation without reliance on God, and expressed his wish to build a temple of kindness in Paris. Later, Jeong heard from Venerable Hyeonho that this woman was the wife of the chairman of the D Group conglomerate.

Another monk was a young man who had come after reading Jeong’s essay collection *The Road to the Hermitage* and was spreading Buddhism among the British. He was very calm, radiating serenity. When he visited Jeong at Saemteo around lunchtime and Jeong offered to treat him to a meal, he declined with a smile, saying he had just eaten, on a bench in a nearby park, the lunch he had packed at the temple. While talking with him in the company cafe, Jeong came to understand the state of churches in Britain: many stood empty, and he had rented one of them inexpensively, hung out a temple signboard, and was spreading Buddhism there.

“Empty churches in England? That surprises me.”

“Not only in England. My dharma brother in Germany has also obtained an empty church to spread Buddhism. There are more Westerners attracted to Buddhism than you might think.”

It was true that the two monks had inspired Jeong in his resolve to leave for Austria on September 10. If he could give a lecture to Europeans newly interested in Buddhism on “What Buddhism means to Koreans,” his trip would be even more meaningful. Since Jeong was not a Buddhist scholar, he thought it would be easier and less burdensome to introduce the consciousness of Koreans, who had encountered Buddhism since ancient times, rather than lecture on doctrine or history.

Jeong immediately emailed Chairwoman Kwon, asking if he could give a lecture to Austrians and Korean expatriates. A few days later, he received a

reply: a lecture had been scheduled at Vienna's Kardinal König Haus, where no Korean had ever lectured before, and they asked for his topic. The venue was comparable to the cultural center of Myeongdong Cathedral in Korea. Jeong then replied, explaining in two points why he had chosen it as his lecture theme.

His reasons were two: first, explaining the emotional outlook of Koreans would be helpful to Austrians; second, introducing Buddhism, which was gaining heightened interest among Westerners, would also be meaningful. Jeong then discussed the travel schedule with his wife, Mrs. Park.

"More than two weeks would be hard because of the serialized novel."

"Since we're leaving September 10, we can return on the 25th."

"I was only thinking about my lecture. How about you hold a ceramics exhibition as well?"

"I'd like that."

Mrs. Park readily accepted Jeong's proposal to hold a ceramics exhibition in Vienna. Moreover, since she already had works fired in her wood kiln from the previous autumn, it would not be difficult to stage an exhibition right away. Of course, if a gallery were set, there would still be issues of transporting the works to Vienna and producing a catalog, but those were only secondary matters.

Jeong sent Chairwoman Kwon a text message about the travel dates and Mrs. Park's ceramics exhibition. A few days later, a reply came: Jeong's lecture at the Kardinal König Haus (KKH) was scheduled for September 20; Mrs. Park's ceramics exhibition could be held as an invitational show at Galerie Am Park in central Vienna, which happened to be planning an international exhibition, from September 14 to 18; and on the 20th, at KKH, she could also hold a two-person show with Austrian ceramicist Sabine Bauer.

However, Chairwoman Kwon insisted that on September 15, the day after the opening at Galerie Am Park, they go to Montafon to meet Mr. Willi. She had arranged lodging next to his studio and proposed staying for at least three nights and four days. The drive from Vienna to Montafon would take eight hours, with her husband, physician Dr. Werner Stockinger, driving. Since this was the very reason she had invited Jeong, other plans were postponed.

Chairwoman Kwon also requested that the couple remain until September 26 to attend IMK's annual concert at Vienna's Musikverein Golden Hall. This charity event invited elderly Austrians who had never had the chance to experience classical music; the guests, who came from every Austrian province, would experience Korea's culture of filial piety through music. This year's performers

included Chinese pianist Shiran Wang (王詩然) and a young Korean violinist. Mrs. Park, a classical music enthusiast, said they must extend their trip to attend the IMK concert.

“When else will we ever hear music in the Golden Hall?”

“We only need to delay our return by three days, so let’s do it.”

In the end, the Austria trip was extended to eighteen days. Jeong began drafting his lecture in spare moments, while Mrs. Park set to work on the exhibition catalog. Fortunately, Jeollanam-do had a program supporting artists’ overseas exhibitions, which provided funding for the catalog. She chose the theme “Beauty of Korea” for her show, and hired a photographer to capture her ceramics not only at her traditional wood-fired kiln but also against the scenic backdrops of Hwasun’s Jeokbyeok cliffs, Unju-sa, Ssangbong-sa, and Boseong’s Yulpo Beach and tea fields. The intent was to present to the Austrian audience, set within Korea’s beautiful landscapes, ceramics that modernized traditional white porcelain.

Before long, Jeong’s trip to Austria had taken on three purposes: meeting Mr. Willi at Chairwoman Kwon’s urging, giving his lecture, and holding Mrs. Park’s ceramics exhibition.

Cheonmaneyo

As the plane maintained an altitude of around 8,000 meters, Mrs. Park seemed to recover her usual mood, finishing her in-flight meal and even drinking a cup of coffee. Author Jeong chose orange juice instead of coffee. Mrs. Park gazed out the window with a smile. The plane had been flying above the white clouds for several hours since departing Incheon Airport. It seemed to be flying safely in the calm zone between the troposphere and the stratosphere. Because there had not been a single abrupt change of air current, it hardly felt like they were on a plane at all. Author Jeong spoke.

“Should I try and guess what you’re thinking about?”

“I was thinking of that young couple we saw at Gallery Am Park.”

Author Jeong immediately recalled the young couple: a pair from Vienna, Austria, who had been so absorbed in the ceramics exhibition that they remained from the opening hour all the way through the reception. They drew attention when they said, “We are poor and cannot afford the ceramics. Might you at least sell us just the catalog?” Touched, Mrs. Park signed the catalog and gave it to them for free.

Mrs. Park was a ceramic artist who created works guided solely by the sense of her hands, never using an electric wheel, and fired them in a traditional kiln fueled exclusively with pine. Her jars in particular gained attention: she applied white porcelain glaze only to the interior, while the exterior took on an ochre tone colored by the kiln's wood fire. She reimagined the Korean white porcelain tradition in a modern way, shaping the mouths of jars like double layers of petals or lotus leaves. Mrs. Park’s invitational exhibition came to fruition when Director Luise Buisman of Gallery Am Park, who had been introduced to Mrs. Park’s work through Chairwoman Kwon and had received her catalog, planned an international ceramics exchange.

At the reception, Director Buisman surprised Author Jeong and his wife. A former curator and designer, she appeared in a hanbok she had bought over thirty years earlier during a visit to Korea, heightening the festive mood. There was even a comic moment when Mrs. Park had to retie the

ribbon of Buisman's *jeogori*, which Buisman had knotted like a bow tie, but the exotic striped jacket captivated the audience, including the president of the Austria–Korea Friendship Association, the head of IMK, renowned Austrian ceramicists, art critics, journalists, and others.

“I remember that time I adjusted the ribbon of the director's *jeogori*.”

“I think she wore the hanbok as a way to welcome me, since I had come from Korea.”

“She's a very thoughtful person.”

“Ah, that reminds me of someone else. It was when you held a two-person exhibition with the Austrian ceramicist Sabine at the Cardinal Cultural Center, where you gave a lecture. I mean the middle-aged woman of aristocratic background.”

“She bought one of your works at Gallery Am Park, so of course I remember her.”

Author Jeong recalled the aristocratic woman vividly, even her way of speaking. The two-person exhibition with the Austrian ceramicist Sabine at the Cardinal Cultural Center had been in the nature of an encore show. The woman came and said, “This work is so spiritual that I still haven't found a place for it in my home.” Her cherishing of the piece carried a purity like that of a teenage girl.

“One of Sabine's works was unusual too, an orb engraved with the words of the Dalai Lama. Though it's a Catholic country, there seems to be an atmosphere of respect for the Dalai Lama.”

What especially impressed Author Jeong and his wife was how Austrian art critics, along with the aristocratic woman, kept describing Mrs. Park's entirely handmade ceramics as “spiritual” and “soulful.” In Catholic Austria, they understood that “spiritual” in this context referred to the sacred vitality and divinity of nature.

Mrs. Park closed her eyes, perhaps from post-meal drowsiness. Author Jeong suddenly cried out inwardly, “Ah!,” because another unforgettable person had come to mind: Dr. Werner, a physician and the husband of Chairwoman Kwon. Before the Gallery Am Park ceramics exhibition opened, he had come early to help the Jeong couple display twelve works, titled “Joy, Memory, Heart, Blessing,” with his keen artistic eye. Now it saddened Jeong that he could no longer meet Dr. Werner. After living cheerfully for several years following a kidney transplant, he had passed away. Jeong missed him all the more because Werner, though a doctor, painted well enough to hang his works in his living room, which made Jeong, once an aspiring painter himself, feel a sense of camaraderie.

A smile spread unconsciously across Author Jeong's face. He recalled how he had nicknamed Dr. Werner “Bae Hoon-a,” a whimsical play on the

name of the singer Na Hoon-a whom Werner liked, and called him “Dr. Bae.” Werner would then reply in Korean he had learned from his wife, Chairwoman Kwon:

“*Cheonmaneyo*.” (“You’re welcome.”)

“I am simply grateful for your warm hospitality.”

“*Cheonmaneyo*.”

“Next time my wife and I come to Austria, you should hold an exhibition. Your impressionistic paintings will surely be well received.”

“*Cheonmaneyo*.”

“Hahaha.”

Author Jeong had never seen a foreigner use “*Cheonmaneyo*” with such deadpan comic flair. Once, knowing the couple’s eating habits, Dr. Werner went shopping himself. Since Jeong avoided four-legged animals such as beef and pork, and Mrs. Park was not fond of two-legged animals like chicken or duck, he bought turkey meat and joked:

“This isn’t from a four-legged animal.”

“I’ve never eaten turkey before, but it looks delicious. Thank you for even cooking it yourself.”

“*Cheonmaneyo*.”

What impressed Jeong most was that Dr. Werner never wore a watch. Jeong had never seen the doctor, whether at home or outside, with one on his wrist. Unable to contain his curiosity, he asked:

“Dr. Bae, do you never wear a wristwatch?”

“It’s a habit. Living as a public physician, I found I no longer needed a watch.”

“But as a doctor, wouldn’t you need a watch even more?”

Since his mid-forties, Jeong had been receiving regular twice-yearly checkups at Seoul’s H General Hospital, and had never once been examined for more than five minutes. So he could not understand a doctor who did not wear a watch.

“When a Korean doctor gives me even five minutes, that’s already generous. They know I’m a novelist. At big general hospitals with so many patients, the average person gets three minutes.”

“At first, I wore a watch too. But I came to feel uneasy about fixing a set time for each patient. So I stopped wearing one, and even after retiring as a public physician, when I put on a watch my wrist feels uncomfortable.”

At that, Author Jeong exclaimed inwardly, “He truly is a bodhisattva!” Of course, Dr. Werner had probably never heard the Buddhist word bodhisattva, nor Vimalakīrti’s saying, “Because living beings suffer, I too suffer.” Yet Jeong believed Werner truly was one. After Dr. Werner passing, Jeong wished to visit his grave and, though late, pray for his repose.

It was September 15, 2015, the day after Mrs. Park's invitational ceramics exhibition opened at Gallery Am Park. After a brief stop at his house on the banks of the Danube in Krems, Dr. Werner drove them for eight long hours to St. Anton village in the Montafon Valley, where Herbert Willi's studio was located. The Jeong couple never forgot the profound gratitude they felt toward him.

Absolute Silence

Dr. Werner, who was driving, was the tallest of the group. At about 180 centimeters, he was a head taller than the others, who were around 160 centimeters. Chairwoman Kwon sat in the front passenger seat, while Author Jeong and his wife, Mrs. Park, sat in the back. Since Dr. Werner had a long torso, the crown of his head nearly touched the roof of the car.

As the car left the outskirts of Vienna and drove toward the city of Krems, the Danube River appeared. The river was not especially wide, but its waters were abundant and seemed deep. The Danube's expression differed from afar and up close. From a distance it looked pastoral and peaceful, but through the car window as it sped along the bank, the water licked at the grasses and flowed eastward with force. Further west, toward Innsbruck, the upper valley waters grew shallower and sparkled a jade hue. Staring at the distant mountains, Chairwoman Kwon let the breeze from the half-open window wash over her and began to talk about Mr. Willi.

"Author Jeong, Innsbruck is not far now. Mr. Willi was born in the state of Vorarlberg, in the village of St. Anton in the Montafon Valley. His father was a carpenter who could also play the piano and violin. Willi's grandfather was a carpenter as well. By making furniture such as wardrobes, his father supported the family, but to Willi, he also served as a music tutor."

It was as if the wind blowing down from the Alpine valleys had summoned Willi, since he lived in the rustic village of St. Anton in Montafon. Dr. Werner kept silent, driving without showing any interest in Willi. It did not seem so much disinterest as a deliberate attitude of not interfering in his wife's affairs, out of respect. For Westerners steeped in individualism, that might have been the natural way. Yet Author Jeong and his wife could not help but listen intently to the story of Willi, whom they longed to meet even by kidnapping if necessary.

"Willi is like the reincarnation of Mozart. Once, a nobleman even asked him to complete one of Mozart's unfinished manuscripts."

The musical achievements of composer Willi, as recounted by Chairwoman Kwon, were dazzling. Willi was undoubtedly one of the

world's foremost composers. His works included the orchestral piece *Vitality*, the opera *The War of the Frogs and Mice*, the *Reminiscence of Tarkovsky: Spaces (Räume)*, the opera *Brother of Sleep (Schlafes Bruder)* based on Robert Schneider's novel and written for Austria's millennium celebration, *Encounter (Begegnung)* for the Vienna Philharmonic's 150th anniversary, *Rondino for Orchestra*, the trumpet concertos *Irene* and *Considerable Time*, and the symphony *Affection (情 Dsong)*, conceived with the Austrian noble Francesca in mind. His list of honors was equally distinguished: he received the Austrian government's "Young Composer's Prize," the "Opera Composition Prize," and the "Decoration of Honor in Gold for Science and Art." He also served as composer-in-residence for the Camerata Academica Salzburg, the Salzburg Festival, the Vienna Musikverein, and the Vienna Konzerthaus Society, patrons of the Vienna Philharmonic. Moreover, Willi's works were performed at Carnegie Hall in New York, the Royal Albert Hall in London, Vienna's Musikverein and Konzerthaus, by ensembles such as the Berlin Philharmonic, Vienna Philharmonic, Cleveland Orchestra, and New Japan Philharmonic, with premieres conducted by Claudio Abbado, Seiji Ozawa, and Christoph von Dohnányi.

"Willi's works are acclaimed all across Europe, and many orchestras are desperate to commission new pieces from him."

But what intrigued Author Jeong more than Willi's dazzling musical achievements was the inner world and spirit from which they sprang. As someone largely unfamiliar with classical music, Jeong was more drawn to Willi's mental world, his artistic spirit.

"Where does Mr. Willi find inspiration when composing?"

"Willi visited Korea with me once, in 2004. In Tokyo, the New Japan Philharmonic premiered his trumpet concerto *Irene*, and on the return trip we stopped in Korea. On September 22, he gave a special lecture at the Korea National University of Arts. I served as his interpreter, so whenever students or journalists asked questions, I translated for him, which is why I can still remember most of his answers. Willi said that he draws his inspiration for composition from absolute silence."

"Absolute silence?"

Jeong's interest was immediately piqued. Back in his student days, while practicing writing fiction, he had once entered into samadhi, sitting at his desk all day without leaving even once. He hadn't noticed day and night passing, nor heard the noises of the outside world. Later, when he asked his teacher Beopjeong Seunim about it, he learned that it was a state of meditative concentration and that very state was absolute silence, absolute stillness itself.

“When a journalist asked, Willi answered like this: The most important thing in my life and in my composition is absolute silence. When I spend days, months, even years walking through the forests of the Alps in search of that silence and stillness, there comes a moment when music begins to sound from deep within me. In that moment, rational judgment and analysis disappear, and an infinite universe beyond the self opens up. Inspiration arises of its own accord. That is when I compose.”

Jeong now became intensely curious about Willi. Willi had once told Chairwoman Kwon that he would kidnap Jeong if necessary to meet him, but now the roles were reversed. Jeong himself felt like pleading with Chairwoman Kwon to arrange a meeting with Willi. Willi seemed at once like a medieval Western mystic and a reclusive Eastern Seon [note: Seon is the Korean pronunciation of what is known more widely in the West as Zen] master. Clearly, he was a composer whose temperament aligned less with Western rationalism and distinctions, and more with Eastern intuition and insight.

“And to another question from a music magazine journalist, he answered this way: I wait for months to hear the inner sound and then I encounter silence. I discover the stillness within the soul. At first the music is like a tiny dot, which gradually grows larger. The dot becomes a great sphere and unites with the universe. That sphere reveals itself in every kind of color. Those colors turn into sound. Music becomes not a beginning or an end, but the whole. Thus music is not something created. It is the power of music that leads the composer.”

As a writer specializing in Buddhism, Jeong could not help but be drawn into the essence of Willi’s music. Though Willi himself did not know Buddhism well, what he said was almost Buddhist in essence. The fact that Chairwoman Kwon had served as Willi’s interpreter was also of great help to Jeong in understanding him.

“I understand now why Willi’s way of thinking is described as Eastern and Buddhist. He even strikes me as a Seon master.”

“In fact, Willi eats only one meal a day and is a vegetarian. The only exception is Korean food, which he finds too delicious to resist. He strongly dislikes killing. Above all, like an Eastern Seon master, he says, ‘Human beings and the universe are one.’ That’s something Westerners cannot easily understand.”

“Chairwoman Kwon, you mentioned that in September 2004 you visited Haein-sa with Willi. Was there a particular reason for going to Haein-sa?”

“Mountain temples are quiet, you know. I thought Willi would like it. For me, it was my second visit. When Seongcheol Seunim passed away at Haein-sa, I had visited Bongam-sa, and there I happened to meet a monk

who led me on to Haein-sa. In any case, Willi said that the Korean autumn was as clear as the weather in Montafon, and he enjoyed it as if he were at home in Montafon.”

“I imagine Willi must have felt the autumn tranquility of the mountain temple.”

“While the rest of us were looking around, Willi remained completely still in the main hall, the Daejeokgwangjeon (Hall of Great Silence and Light), gazing only at the murals.”

“If it was the murals on the Daejeokgwangjeon, they must have been the *Palsangdo* (Eight Scenes of the Buddha’s Life).”

“Chairwoman Kwon, when Willi looked at the colors of the murals, do you think he might have heard their content as sound?”

“I don’t know. If you ever meet Willi, be sure to ask him yourself.”

Palsangdo refers to paintings that divide the Buddha’s life into eight stages. Jeong had once published an essay collection titled *The Eight Great Episodes in the Buddha’s Life*, based on the stories depicted in the *Palsangdo*. In it, he rendered the Buddha’s life in stages such as: “Where shall we meet again and in what form?”, “What were you before you were born?”, “Even the blooming and withering of the lotus is suffering,” “Receiving the morning sunlight as an offering on the Tilaurakot forest path,” “I cannot stop in the face of your teaching,” “Ah, Siddhartha’s life has already come to its end,” “When he sat cross-legged beneath the bodhi tree, faith surged forth,” “Hearing the truth, one will awaken to it,” “O, Buddha, who dwelt with the suffering and the foolish,” “Open your eyes, and you will see the light,” and “Rely on yourself as a lamp, rely on the Dharma as a lamp.”

CHAPTER 6

Jeong

The distant Alpine peaks appeared green. It was clear the Montafon Valley was drawing near. Dr. Werner suggested taking a break at the rest stop. Deep shadows had already settled over the valley below. Yet the forests on the ridges, still fully bathed in the afternoon sun, remained bright. Dr. Werner and Chairwoman Kwon ordered espresso served in small cups, while Author Jeong and Mrs. Park ordered orange juice. Mrs. Park gazed at the red-roofed cottages near the rest stop and remarked,

“In Austria, the country houses are more beautiful than those in the city. The flowers on the verandas look straight out of a fairy tale.”

“The clear weather probably makes them look even more beautiful. The weather here rivals Korea’s autumn days. It rained continuously just a few days ago. When the weather clears like this, Austrians say it is ‘a day when angels go on an outing.’”

Chairwoman Kwon, who had been in charge of flower arrangements at her church, said,

“In Austrian villages, they sometimes select and award prizes to people who beautify their homes with flowers. I suppose it is because they have the leisure to do so. Austria is a country where rural villagers earn higher incomes than city office workers.”

Author Jeong responded to Dr. Werner’s words.

“An ideal country is one where those who labor and sweat can live well. Sweat is sacred, after all. Thank you for driving; you have worked hard.”

“*Cheonmaneyo*” (“You’re welcome.”)

“Hahaha.”

Author Jeong laughed out loud at Dr. Werner’s “*cheonmaneyo*” because it sounded like he was talking about the driving fee: “That will be ten million won.” The sedan kept driving along the well-paved, zigzagging mountain road. Soon, Chairwoman Kwon spoke up, saying she still had something left to say about Willi.

“After visiting Haein-sa, we went to Ihwajang, where Mrs. Francesca Donner lived. She was from Inzersdorf, near Vienna. Willi listened to the story of Mrs. Francesca’s life and was captivated.”

“What aspect of her did Willi find so captivating?”

“The caretaker of Ihwajang began with the story of Dr. Syngman Rhee’s first meeting with Mrs. Francesca.”

Chairwoman Kwon remembered it precisely because she had interpreted for Mr. Willi. The time and place of Dr. Rhee and Francesca’s first meeting was Geneva, Switzerland, in 1933. Dr. Rhee was attending the League of Nations conference, appealing to representatives and journalists about the plight of Koreans suffering under Japanese oppression. He pleaded that “Korea must be granted independence for peace in the Far East to be maintained.” Meanwhile, Francesca was traveling through Switzerland with her mother, having passed through Paris.

At that time, in the restaurant of a hotel on Lake Geneva, the mother and daughter were seated with Dr. Rhee, a 58-year-old independence activist from Korea, after the manager asked for their understanding. The restaurant was packed with guests that day. The next day, Francesca cut out an article from a newspaper interview with Dr. Rhee and gave it to him, and this became the catalyst for their deepening connection. Francesca, then 33, held an international certification as an English interpreter and specialized in shorthand and typing. Hearing of Dr. Rhee’s difficult circumstances, she decided to volunteer her services pro bono. She resolved to type for him and serve as his secretary.

Eventually, feelings of love blossomed between them. Overcoming various obstacles and opposition, they held their wedding ceremony on October 8, 1934, in a special room at the Montclair Hotel in New York. Francesca’s mother vehemently opposed the marriage. Moreover, the views of those around Dr. Rhee were not favorable either, since an independence activist had married a foreign woman. However, Mrs. Francesca’s fluent English and German skills provided immense help to Dr. Rhee during his life in exile.

Ten years after their marriage, Korea gained independence on August 15, 1945. Dr. Rhee returned first on October 16 and stayed at Donamjang. It had been 33 years since he left his homeland. Following Dr. Rhee, Mrs. Francesca also returned to Korea.

From this point on, Mrs. Francesca resolved to live as a Korean. She wore hanbok and learned how to cook Korean food. The couple moved to Ihwajang in 1947, and when Dr. Rhee became president, they moved into Gyeongmudae. Then, when President Rhee resigned in April 1960 at the demand of the Korean people, they returned to Ihwajang. A month later, Dr.

Rhee went into exile in Hawaii. In July 1965, his remains were returned to Korea, resting one last time at Ihwajang before being laid to rest in the National Cemetery. After Dr. Rhee went into exile in Hawaii, Mrs. Francesca returned to Austria, her homeland. Longing for hanbok and Korean food, she returned to Ihwajang on May 16, 1970, and lived with her adopted son Rhee In-su, Cho Hye-ja, and their family. She passed away on March 19, 1992, at the age of 92, wearing a blue hanbok.

Her final will had the following statements: “Please make sure to put in the dentures I used for 22 years. I must meet Dr. Rhee with my dentures in.” “When I die, do not use flowers. Helping those in need is far better than wasting money on unnecessary things.” “Place the Taegeukgi, the Bible, and the hymn book that Dr. Rhee used during his independence movement days into the coffin.” “On the coffin lid, write ‘National Reunification (南北統一)’ in the calligraphy Dr. Rhee loved to use.”

“At that time, I told Mr. Willi that Mrs. Francesca must have returned to Korea because of the Korean sentiment of *jeong*.”

“What was Mr. Willi’s reaction?”

He seemed to understand a bit. After Mr. Willi’s lecture at the Korea National University of Arts, during the open discussion, I said that his passion and love for music felt like the Korean concept of *jeong*. Mr. Willi then asked the students what *jeong* meant, and their consensus was something like “a gift of the heart, given and received.”

Chairwoman Kwon added,

“It seemed that Mr. Willi was gradually coming to understand the Korean concept of *jeong* in his own way. He said it might be described with words like solidarity, compassion, love, affection, and empathy. And it seems he enjoyed visiting Haein-sa. On the day he was returning to Austria after his visit to Korea, he wanted to go to a temple again. So we went to the Yeongsanjeon Hall at Bongun-sa in Gangnam, Seoul.”

“I think he was drawn to the Buddha’s image, as if it reflected the stillness within himself. And perhaps Mr. Willi, who dislikes noise, was attracted to the uniquely quiet atmosphere of a mountain temple.”

“I’m not sure. Anyway, at the Yeongsanjeon in Bongun-sa, Mr. Willi knelt before the Buddha statue and prayed for quite a while. He looked like a devout Buddhist.”

While conversing with Chairwoman Kwon, Author Jeong briefly indulged in a fanciful thought: perhaps Mr. Willi had been a monk practicing at a Korean temple in a past life. The way he had stood transfixed, staring at the murals in the main hall of Haein-sa as if hypnotized, and the way he prayed like a devout Buddhist at the Yeongsanjeon in Bongun-sa, gave

wings to this imagination. Moreover, Bongeun-sa was the temple Mr. Willi himself had wished to visit.

Perhaps it was because he was reluctant to part with something he had long yearned for.

In any case, on the way to Incheon Airport, Willi surprised Chairwoman Kwon once more. He had kept his eyes closed since leaving Bongeun-sa, but opened them as they crossed the Incheon Bridge over the sea. Chairwoman Kwon thought Willi had been sleeping from exhaustion, but that was not the case.

“Sonya, I have fully conceived the third movement of the orchestral piece *Jeong* (정). I finished it all on the way to the airport. I also felt *jeong* from Mrs. Francesca.”

Before they knew it, the car carrying the group was entering the Montafon Valley, surrounded by mountains. After passing through two long tunnels, villages and red-roofed houses came into view. The houses were clustered in small basins on the mountain slopes about 600 meters above sea level. Dr. Werner cheerfully interjected, as if he had been waiting for Chairwoman Kwon to finish speaking.

“We will soon arrive at St. Anton, where Mr. Willi, the composer of *Jeong*, lives. We should hear more from Author Jeong about what *jeong* means to Koreans.”

Dr. Werner, who had been silent throughout the drive, had clearly been listening to the group’s conversation. He, too, loved Korea and cherished its people.

First Encounter

Mr. Herbert Willi's home was situated slightly higher than the area with shops and hotels in the Montafon basin. As we climbed the uphill mountain road at the entrance to the Montafon Valley, Mr. Willi's home came into view. It was a two-story house with a small garden attached. The lodging for my wife and me was located further up the mountain road, across from and overlooking Mr. Willi's house. Both houses seemed to be at about 700 meters above sea level. Chairwoman Kwon said,

"I deliberately arranged a guesthouse close to Mr. Willi's home. It's where you'll stay for three nights and four days. Since only you and Mrs. Park will be there, it should be comfortable."

"So Mr. Willi arranged it in advance."

"That's right. There are hotels, but he thought it would be better for you to stay nearby."

"I'm also glad to be staying near Mr. Willi's house."

The group first got out in front of Mr. Willi's house. Across the road, among the broad meadows on the distant hillside, stood houses with red roofs and white walls. Austrian rural and mountain homes were uniformly neat and modest, blending with the green fields like flocks of sheep. Perhaps because red and green are complementary colors, the meadows and houses stood out while still maintaining harmony.

After receiving Chairwoman Kwon's call, Mr. Willi came down the stairs from the second floor. For a Westerner, he was slender and short. He wore a gray jumper and jeans. Mr. Willi first approached Author Jeong and his wife, extending his hand, then lightly embraced Chairwoman Kwon and her husband. His first impression was gentle like a woman's and pure like a boy's. At the same time, his silver hair reflecting the sunset seemed like an aura of his spirit. Perhaps because of this, his whole presence gave the impression of transparent crystal. Chairwoman Kwon interpreted Mr. Willi's words.

"Author Jeong, Mr. Willi says he will host dinner tonight at a Thai restaurant. He asks that you first go to your lodgings, unpack, and wait there."

"Please convey my thanks to Mr. Willi."

Author Jeong once again said "Thank you" directly to Mr. Willi in Korean. Mr. Willi responded with a radiant smile and a Buddhist-style gesture of joined palms. As they walked up to the guesthouse above Mr. Willi's home, Chairwoman Kwon said,

"It seems he reserved the Thai restaurant out of consideration for you and your wife, Author Jeong."

"Thank you and by the way, Mr. Willi's first impression is very appealing. I had imagined him like a charismatic conductor, but he is not. He is as clear as the stream flowing through the Montafon Valley, and unlike the Viennese, his appearance is very simple, fitting for this mountain village. Yet his presence is transparent like crystal and dazzling like his silver hair."

"As expected of an author, your expression is truly distinctive. Unlike the dashing Viennese gentlemen, Mr. Willi seems rather plain. But he is Montafon's treasure. Even now, musicians in Austria, let alone Europe, hardly know him, because Mr. Willi has chosen to live in seclusion in Montafon."

"That's similar to me living in Ibuljae, deep in the mountains of South Jeolla Province in Korea. Hahaha."

"I see. You both are alike in being deep in the mountains. When I first visited Ibuljae, my impression was that it, too, was a remote mountain setting like Montafon."

"That said, Mr. Willi may feel lonely, but he will not feel isolated, since he meets many people through his works."

Mrs. Park, who was beside him, said.

"Artists seem to like solitude."

"This is the first time I've told you this, Chairwoman Kwon, but most guests from Seoul who visit Ibuljae ask me the same thing. Seeing me live in the mountains, they ask whether I feel lonely, whether I feel solitude. I tell them that loneliness is the power that sustains life in the mountains. If there were no solitude here, what joy would there be? If solitude has a degree of purity, it must be absolute solitude. When I say that perhaps people in the city drink and go to karaoke bars because they fear loneliness, only then do they nod. I think that may be why Mr. Willi never leaves the Montafon Valley."

Mrs. Park seemed to understand, having once exchanged such words with Author Jeong at Ibuljae. But Chairwoman Kwon, not grasping it right away, asked again.

“Is Mr. Willi’s reason for never leaving Montafon really absolute solitude?”

“Mr. Willi once said that his music begins in the absolute stillness, the absolute silence of Montafon. Isn’t that absolute stillness nature itself, the ancient silence of the Montafon Alps? The primordial, absolute stillness of the beginning of time.”

Indeed, the primeval forests on the slopes of Montafon or the glaciers at the Alpine summits must hold an absolute silence free of human noise. That same absolute silence, with identical purity and fullness, must surely exist now just as it did hundreds of millions of years ago. In an interview with a Korean music magazine, Mr. Willi said that in order to encounter such silence, he would walk for months through the Alpine peaks or along the slopes of Montafon.

“I interpreted Mr. Willi’s words about absolute silence, but to be honest, I don’t fully understand what they mean.”

“I too would like to visit a place where absolute silence exists, since that is said to be where Mr. Willi’s music begins.”

“I’ll ask Mr. Willi. It would be wonderful if we could go as soon as tomorrow.”

From the outside, the guesthouse looked smaller than Mr. Willi’s home. A hostess who appeared to be in her sixties greeted the group at the door. The room where Author Jeong and his wife would stay for three nights and four days was on the first floor near the dining room. The hostess probably moved upstairs out of consideration for her guests. Her expression was kindly, befitting a countrywoman of the Montafon Valley. In welcoming Author Jeong and his wife, she showed no airs of ownership; on the contrary, she seemed shy in front of them. As she moved about the living room speaking with Chairwoman Kwon, Author Jeong asked Chairwoman Kwon whether there was some problem with the guesthouse.

“Was the reservation made incorrectly?”

“Mr. Willi made the reservation, so that isn’t the issue. The hostess just seems very pure-hearted.”

“Then why is the hostess so flustered?”

“Yes, she seems worried about properly hosting Author Jeong and his wife from Korea. She says it’s a big problem because she doesn’t speak Korean—nor even English.”

Author Jeong was instantly moved by the hostess’s attitude toward receiving guests. Perhaps it was out of carefulness at Mr. Willi’s request, but surely it sprang from her kind nature. Chairwoman Kwon spoke to Author Jeong as if asking for his understanding.

“My wife and I can stay at Mr. Willi’s house. Whenever we came to Montafon, the first-floor room in his home was always mine. It was the room his parents had used when they were alive.”

Before long, the hostess brought out precious black tea on the living room table. Usually, the villagers drank lemon tea among themselves. When Chairwoman Kwon tried to leave, she took her hand and urged her to stay for tea. Chairwoman Kwon and her husband, together with Author Jeong and his wife, sat on the gray sofa and drank the black tea. In the glass cups it glowed an unusually deep red, like the sunset in the western Montafon sky. Seeing the position of the sunset, Dr. Werner explained the surrounding terrain to Author Jeong.

“The mountains facing north outside the window all rise above 2,000 meters; beyond them lies Germany. To the west, where the sunset glows, just over the mountains is Switzerland. The distant southern peaks visible from the doorway of this house also exceed 2,000 meters, and beyond them is Italy. So beyond the mountains surrounding Montafon lie Switzerland, Germany, and Italy. At the hotel restaurants here, Romani from Italy sometimes come in, sing with guitar accompaniment, and then walk around with hats for tips. They come because it is geographically close.”

Author Jeong and his wife soon parted from Chairwoman Kwon and her husband. Outside the window, night had fallen suddenly. Lights flickered in the village opposite. It seemed as if the earthly lights would soon rise to become the moon and stars of the Montafon sky. The stars had not yet appeared. After washing their hands, Author Jeong and his wife waited for Mr. Willi and Chairwoman Kwon with her husband, preparing to go to the Thai restaurant to which Mr. Willi had invited them.

Deep Conversations Part 1 - The World Unseen

5 a.m.

Moonlight streamed through the guesthouse window, brightening the room. It shimmered across the bed, the white cover dazzling to the eyes. Rising from bed, Author Jeong went straight to the window. Too exhausted the night before, he had fallen asleep without drawing the curtains. He thought of closing them for Mrs. Park but let it be; dawn would break in half an hour. Unlike Author Jeong, who woke easily at dawn, Mrs. Park still lay with her face buried in the large pillow.

The moon hung in the sky to the left of the window. Like a yellow mango, it looked ready to roll down from the peaks rising over 2,000 meters. In the pitch-dark Montafon Valley, the moon alone shone with lofty dignity, as though it were master of all.

Author Jeong suddenly thought: if the Montafon Valley had a true master, might it not be Mr. Willi? For just as moonlight reached into every corner, Willi's music, born of Montafon's inspiration, was performed in Europe, America, and Asia. At this moment, Jeong might have been the only one looking at the Montafon moon. If so, that moon belonged to the one who now saw and felt it. What meaning had it for those not facing it? The message carried in moonlight was for whomever received it, like Jeong himself. Mrs. Park spoke, as if dazzled.

"Honey, what time is it, you're up already?"

"It's like a gift to see the moon from Montafon. You should take a look too."

Mrs. Park came to the window wearing a long robe.

"Maybe because the mountains are so high, the moon seems small, doesn't it? It's wondrous looking at the moon, but I'm going back to sleep."

"Honey, that moon makes me think of Mr. Willi."

"Mr. Willi?"

“A moment ago, I thought Mr. Willi was like a moon lighting up Montafon.”

Mrs. Park climbed back into bed, saying she needed more sleep, pulling the blanket up to her shoulders. By then the moon had already sunk beyond the high ridges and instead, dawn was breaking over them. Lights of villages in the Montafon valley, on dark slopes and in the basin, flared back to life after a night of darkness. It was like sparks on a great lump of charcoal reigniting and spreading one by one. Yet those earthly lights soon faded with the advancing daylight, swallowed by the red of dawn. The crimson glow lingered in Montafon’s vast sky and mountain flanks.

Author Jeong pondered what to ask Mr. Willi first when they met. What he most wanted to know was by what thread of fate Willi had become a composer, and what that “absolute silence” was where his music began. With just these two questions he felt he could understand the man to some degree. The first belonged to Willi’s destiny, the second could reveal his thoughts and inner world as a composer. As at a temple, one must pass through the Iljumun with its two pillars to reach the Dharma Hall, Author Jeong thought these two questions were Willi’s Iljumun.

After breakfast at the guesthouse, the Jeong couple set off for Mr. Willi’s house a little before the appointed hour. They had agreed yesterday to meet at 9. Mrs. Park grumbled.

“Don’t show your Korean habits here.”

She was referring to Author Jeong who always hurried to be ahead of time. It was also the “*ppalli-ppalli*” (hurry, hurry) trait common to the majority of Koreans. Many of his friends, too, were nicknamed “Ten-Minutes-Early,” because they arrived ten minutes before the appointed hour. Some even came thirty minutes early, forcing others to rush into their clothes, but Jeong put more faith in these kinds of people.

Chairwoman Kwon showed her Korean ways as well, standing in front of Mr. Willi’s house about thirty minutes early. She said:

“Was your lodging comfortable?”

“Yes, not at all uncomfortable. The bread and coffee Mrs. Willi served for breakfast were very good too.”

“She is pure-hearted, as you’d expect from someone who has lived her whole life in Montafon. In Austria, Montafon is like the countryside even of the countryside.”

Chairwoman Kwon also addressed Mrs. Park.

“While Mr. Jeong is speaking with Mr. Willi, my husband says he will show you around Montafon.”

“Thank you. Won’t Dr. Werner feel troubled?”

“It was my husband who suggested it first, so it’s fine.”

At nine o'clock, Mr. Willi came down the stairs to greet Author Jeong. Chairwoman Kwon remained behind to interpret, and Mrs. Park departed in Dr. Werner's car. Author Jeong and Mr. Willi went up to the living room on the second floor. A small piano stood in the hallway leading to it, and on the opposite wall hung a painting of an orchid. Their conversation turned to the painting, titled "Orchid Fragrance Travels Ten Thousand Miles," the idea that an orchid's scent carries a great distance. Judging by its simple, unadorned frame, it had clearly been brought from Korea. In the living room, a large monitor and speakers were set up beneath the window. In front of the L-shaped sofa was a round table, with a transparent glass pitcher at its center holding slices of yellow lemon afloat in water. Everyone drank a cup of the lemon tea to refresh themselves. Soon, Chairwoman Kwon was skillfully interpreting Mr. Willi's words.

"I am so happy and grateful that you made the difficult journey here. One day, I heard about you through Sonja (Chairwoman Kwon's Austrian name). From that moment, I was certain you would come to Montafon."

"I felt the same. Though it might take twists and turns, I knew that one day I would meet you, Mr. Willi. And if the chance came, I hoped for a long talk. Today, it seems that hope is coming true."

"I believe there is a visible world and an invisible one. To people who think and live only in the visible world, such talk may sound strange. But for those who accept the invisible world, our conversation will be very interesting. I think music stands at the boundary between the two, for music shows what is invisible."

"You said that you were sure I would come to Montafon, Teacher Willi. Then our meeting is not coincidence but a deep connection (*inyeon*), a destined encounter."

"Some people do not believe me when I speak of the unseen world. Some intellectuals even consider me strange. I cannot keep long company with such intellectuals, because our mutual trust can't but be broken."

"In Korea we say, 'The arrow of fate strikes the mark even in the darkest night.' It means our deep connections (*inyeon*) are inevitable. Those who live only in the visible world think them coincidence. In that sense I understood your words, Teacher Willi."

As the conversation grew deeper, half-clear and half-obscure, Chairwoman Kwon sometimes looked troubled while interpreting.

"Since you've come all this way from Korea, ask me anything. I'll answer honestly."

"Today I will ask only two questions. One is this: in high school I read Camus and Sartre and was drawn into existentialism, that was the cause of

my becoming a writer. When and through what event did your musical life begin as destiny, Teacher Willi?"

Mr. Willi closed his eyes as though the memory was painful. Jeong felt almost apologetic, wondering if his question was excessive. At length, Mr. Willi opened his eyes, breaking the silence. His lips and jaw, delicate almost like a woman's, moved in synchronicity. His large eyes seemed moist with tears.

"From age fifteen I suffered an incurable illness, spending two months at a time between a hospital in Innsbruck and my home in Montafon. By seventeen I was waiting for death in the ward. One by one the patients in my six-bed room went out and never came back."

It was then that Willi rose from his sickbed and began walking the banks of the Inn River, far from the hospital, in despair. For half the day he walked, not knowing whether to go on living or at any moment leap into the water. At last, he came to a place where it was hard to go on and too far to turn back. Then vast black clouds covered the sky.

Deep Conversations Part 2 - The Raindrop

Hwadu

The dark clouds covering the sky did not immediately release their rain. As if giving Willi time to seek shelter, the clouds gradually thinned. Consequently, the river grew dark and then bright again, its waters flowing on, steady and unchanged. The overgrown weeds on the bank, as if frightened, remained motionless before softening their appearance. The birds, which had fled far away in fear of the clouds' menace, began to appear one by one. But they did not come close to Willi.

Willi shuddered at the moment the river and sky, the grass on the bank, and the expressions of the birds all changed. It was the moment when the pain in his body, having reached its extreme, finally began to subside. His body felt comfortable, as if the sickness had vanished, and the river was profoundly still. A warm energy enveloped him and the river was so quiet it seemed about to speak to him.

Then it happened. Willi saw a single raindrop and heard the sound of it falling into the river. Because the surroundings were so still, the sound of the raindrop was whole, unmingled with any other noise. It seemed to fill the silent space with its solitary sound. He felt a comfort as if his sickness had left his body, and it was a sound he could hear only because every being in the river was silent. To Willi, it was not merely a sound, but the discovery of a clear note, the beginning of a musical journey.

Willi could not pull himself away from the sound of the raindrop he had just heard. It seemed as if a single raindrop contained the entire secret of the world, as if it held all the music of the world within it. Willi had completely forgotten why he had walked to this very spot. It was as if the reason, why he could no longer walk forward or turn back, why he stood rooted to the riverbank, had been stolen from him by a single drop. The sound of the raindrop had plunged him into a state of selflessness. Yet he did not feel isolated or lonely. Instead, he felt connected to everything in the river. Willi felt a profound fullness, as though in losing himself, in becoming selfless, he

had instead become the whole. And though the sound of the raindrop falling vertically from the empty sky and striking the flat plane of the river seemed to spread far and sink deep, to Willi, it was something more.

The sound of the raindrop filled Willi's mind completely. The note that had begun at a single point grew steadily until it had occupied his entire head. Now, Willi felt as though he were trapped in a prison of raindrops, a prison that was whole, pure, and transparent as crystal.

"Could I bring that sound back to life?"

"If only that could happen someday, I'd be as happy as I am now."

The faint clouds had scattered, and bright daylight spread across the sky. The long-awaited midday sun finally returned, glistening on the river's surface. The sounds of the world began to break the silence of moments before. A car raced in the distance, and a flock of birds gathered over the river. A hidden wind blew, rustling the grasses along the riverbank. Even the whistle of a train racing through the Montafon Valley could be heard. All these sounds reminded Willi that he suffered from an incurable illness. He was brought back to the reality where he could think only of death.

Yet Willi felt his heart fill as if he had received a gift beyond compare. A light seemed to pierce the darkness within him, born of the conviction: 'Someday, I will be as happy as I am now.' Willi did not return to the hospital. He headed for the Innsbruck train station. He was going home to Montafon.

"I returned home and sat down at the piano. I stayed there day and night, searching for the sound of raindrops. In a way, that's when my musical life truly began. Actually, when I was about six, I went to see a music teacher living in Montafon to learn the clarinet. He had a grand piano at the time. He was an elderly man, and if I couldn't play the clarinet as he taught me, he would punish me by pulling my ears. I disliked going to his house by the stream and told my father. After that, my father personally taught me not only the clarinet, but also the piano and violin. Though he was a carpenter, my father possessed such exceptional musical talent that he composed music. In a sense, he became my music teacher."

"How did you find the raindrop notes?"

"I found them on the piano keys after several months."

"You must have felt like dancing with joy then."

"First, I recalled the stillness of the stream at the moment the raindrops fell, and my own incurable illness. I offered a prayer of gratitude."

"I understand being grateful for the incurable illness that tormented you, Mr. Willi. Eastern masters subject their bodies to harsh discipline to attain enlightenment. Through this, they discover their true nature and ultimately achieve great awakening. The Buddha himself endured six years of

asceticism to attain unsurpassed enlightenment. After torturing his body beyond our imagination, he achieved unsurpassed enlightenment. Of course, the Buddha knew asceticism was an extreme method, so he abandoned it before enlightenment and did not recommend it to his disciples. In Mr. Willi's case, it probably wasn't something he desired. In any case, Mr. Willi's incurable illness ultimately brings to mind the ascetic practices of East Asian Seon masters."

Mr. Willi just smiled. Then he gestured for them to head toward the piano in the hallway. On the desk in front of the keys, notepaper, sheet music, and pens were neatly arranged. Author Jeong sensed Mr. Willi's meticulous and tidy nature from these items. Mr. Willi sat down on the chair and immediately pressed one piano key for a long note.

"This single note couldn't express the sound of raindrops."

Author Jeong heard the 'C' note from the key Mr. Willi pressed. The low 'C' seemed to make the sound of raindrops falling into a river and sinking deep. Mr. Willi pressed another key again.

"Even with this single note, I still couldn't capture the sound of raindrops."

This time, the key Mr. Willi pressed sounded like a 'G' an octave higher. Unlike before, it seemed like the sound of raindrops spreading across a river.

"When I played the keys one at a time, I couldn't perfectly capture the sound of raindrops. Now, I'll play two keys simultaneously. Listen. This is the sound of raindrops I heard back then."

Author Jeong also understood that the sound produced by the two keys together was different from when they were played individually. It was a subtle difference, as if the sound filled the space.

Mr. Willi guided Author Jeong back to the living room. Author Jeong sat in the chair he had occupied earlier, and Chairwoman Kwon continued interpreting.

"As Author Jeong just heard, when I struck a single key, that note wasn't the sound of raindrops I heard by the river. I realized a single note couldn't convey it. It felt like the raindrop fell and bounced away, like it flowed away. When I struck another key together, it became a finished product, if you will. So a single note is nothing. It's incomplete. My conclusion was that two notes together must come together to be complete."

"So Mr. Willi's musical journey began with the enigma of a raindrop's sound. In East Asian Buddhism, practitioners call this a *hwadu*. A classic *hwadu* is the question, 'What is this?'. A *hwadu* is a question for which there is no fixed answer, because the answer to 'What is this?' is different for everyone. Furthermore, a *hwadu* is not solved through intellectual reasoning. Just as Mr. Willi sat before his piano day and night, forgetting everything in

his search for the raindrop's sound, practitioners, after receiving a *hwadu* from their master, live enveloped in this doubt for a week, months, or even years. Eventually, the doubt comes to dominate their entire mind and body. The practitioners themselves become a solid mass of questioning. It is said that at this stage, this mass of doubt never disappears, whether one is active during the day, asleep at night, or even dreaming. Yet, they say the shattering of this doubt happens in a single instant. Through some stimulus, the practitioner breaks free from the mass of doubt, and in that moment, they awaken to the secret of the *hwadu*. How utterly liberating that must be! It is said that in that instant, some practitioners dance for joy, while others weep with overwhelming emotion."

"Ah, yes. When I, a seventeen-year-old who had never formally studied music at school, discovered the sound of raindrops, I think I went through a similar process. The joy was beyond words."

"Carl Jung once said, 'God enters through the cracks in our wounds.' I find myself wondering whether the raindrop Mr. Willi encountered on the Inn while suffering from an incurable illness might have been a raindrop sent as a gift from God."

Chairwoman Kwon laughed and joined their conversation.

"Even though you two speak different languages, you understand each other's thoughts so well that I don't need to interpret."

In reality, Composer Willi didn't know Korean, and Author Jeong didn't know German. Yet, throughout their conversation, they understood each other's thoughts and empathized without disagreement. Mr. Willi shared more about his experience expressing the sounds of nature through instruments, following the sound of raindrops. For instance, he said that while playing the piano only allows him to express about 70% of his vision, other instruments can fill in the gaps. He mentioned that instruments like the cello, clarinet, and viola enable 100% expression, adding that it was a clear and definite experience.

Before they knew it, the wall clock pointed to 2 PM. This seemed to be Mr. Willi's lunchtime, as he ate only once a day. Mr. Willi got up and headed to the kitchen. Author Jeong anticipated Mr. Willi's vegetarian dish, which excluded meat. Author Jeong also avoided eating beef, a favorite among Europeans.

Deep Conversations Part 3 - The Absolute Silence Within

On the day of my second meeting with Mr. Willi, Mrs. Park joined us. She preferred hearing Mr. Willi's stories to touring Montafon with Dr. Werner. The place for our talk with Mr. Willi was the same as the day before. In the living room on the second floor of his home, Mr. Willi, Author Jeong, Chairwoman Kwon, and Mrs. Park sat around a round table. In the middle of the table, as before, there was a clear glass teapot filled with lemon tea. They began by sharing a cup of lemon tea. This time, Author Jeong spoke first.

Mr. Willi said he does not compose with his intellect but writes down the sounds of Montafon's nature, and I think I understand what he meant. Works gained by an author's will or effort are of a lower order; what writers truly seek are works that surpass effort, those born of inspiration. I often have the same experience. When fixing a novel's title or shaping its plan, no matter how hard I try at my desk, it often will not come, and then one dawn it flickers through my mind. It rises in that instant just after waking, when I sit without a thought, eyes barely open. I have often settled on the title that brushed my mind then, and I was usually satisfied. So it felt less like something I earned through effort than a gift of inspiration, as if the talents of all had converged. And I think such inspiration is not a coincidence but an inevitability that appears when a connection has fully ripened.

Resting his chin on his hand, Mr. Willi listened intently and then began to share his own experience. Since it was her second day, Chairwoman Kwon's interpreting came more quickly and naturally. Mrs. Park set down a thumb-sized recorder to record the conversation between Mr. Willi and Author Jeong.

"I agree with you, Author Jeong. I compose from a distinctive inspiration. I have written very few pieces after deciding in advance what to compose or fixing content and form beforehand. I simply meet the music that the nature of Montafon and the Alps gives and write it down as it is. My music was already there, living on those mountain slopes; I only discovered

it. Even now I could take you to several places where I heard those songs. When I was young, there was Lake Kopssee in the valleys of high mountains that people seldom visited because it was a protected area. It was so distant and the trails so dangerous that for decades few went there. Below the lake there is a primeval forest, and in that forest there was an ancient stillness. Music lived there."

"Is that primordial stillness the absolute silence you've spoken of many times?"

"Yes, that's where music resides. It's not just living things like trees and grass that exist there—music lives there too. Let me say again, Author Jeong, I can show you exactly where music lives. Even now, music dwells in that place. As long as people don't pollute it, music will live there forever. That's why I always carry colored pencils and paper in my pocket."

"Colored pencils? What connection do they have with music?"

"I do not hear the music there, I see it. That is why I draw the music I see with colored pencils. I sketch the music on paper and bring it home. Then, one day, within the stillness of my own mind, I look at the music I have drawn and complete the composition."

At this, Author Jeong was speechless. The thought of seeing sound rather than hearing it made him wonder, "Can such a thing truly be possible?" But Mr. Willi, as if to prove his words, gave an example.

"In the deep valleys of Montafon or the gorges of the Alps, places inaccessible when the weather turns, dwells a music for an orchestra of a hundred or more. Should the opportunity arise, I would like to take you there, Author Jeong. It is the very place where I once translated that music onto paper with my colored pencils. Of course, even without going to such a place, I could simply sit down for a week or several weeks and, through sheer effort, compose something of a similar nature. But in my view, the result would not be music. I believe that music conceived in the human mind and constructed through mathematical calculation is inherently artificial; it can never possess the pure space and profound depth of the music that simply *is*."

"Is that so? As I mentioned earlier, music composed with the mind is inferior; music that captures the sounds of nature is surely of a heavenly caliber."

Mr. Willi seemed to brighten as Author Jeong showed understanding. Encouraged, he began to confess his innermost thoughts without reserve.

"I never wanted to waste a single second—then or now—in my task of transcribing music. To seek it out, I left home and lived for years in a hut deep in the Montafon valleys, and for several more in singular places like Tuscany. I was waiting, you see, because in waiting, I could find the silence

of the external world. But one day, I realized that same silence existed within me. It was a moment of revelation: ‘So, there is a silence inside me, too.’ An absolute silence, one might call it. And it is within that silence that music begins. This music was never something I could summon at will. It was, in other words, entirely beyond my jurisdiction. I could neither dictate its beginning nor its end. So, you see, even if an orchestra conductor requests a piece of twenty-five or forty minutes, or even if I myself desire to create one, music cannot be conjured by technical skill alone. What I call my composition is only complete when I encounter a force greater than myself, a state of absolute stillness.”

“I understand, from a Buddhist point of view, how your music comes into being, Mr. Willi. What you call the absolute stillness or absolute silence within is what Buddhism calls *kong* (空), emptiness. Emptiness is a state that is completely void yet somehow full. We call it ‘the fullness of emptiness.’ To say that the inside is empty means that all human desires are gone. This is called *jeokmyeol* (寂滅), or *jin'gong* (眞空). Buddhism teaches that wisdom arises from this empty state. It seems that you, Mr. Willi, perceive that wisdom emerging from emptiness as sound.”

Moved by Author Jeong’s interpretation, Mr. Willi’s eyes filled with tears. Chairwoman Kwon rose, went to him, and briefly embraced him to calm him. Author Jeong thought Mr. Willi resembled an Eastern Seon master, for he was already meeting music within the absolute stillness of inner emptiness, the realm of enlightenment reached by Seon masters. Mr. Willi’s confession continued.

“There were times when I roamed the Montafon slopes and wandered the deep Alpine valleys in search of absolute stillness, absolute silence. But one day I realized that the place itself was me, and I found it within. Nature and I were one. After I discovered absolute stillness within myself, ten years passed, and then I could reach that same stillness even on the noisiest highway. Once, for example, there was a clarinet piece. I had kept for years a sheet I had sketched in colored pencil at the place where that music lived. After I met the absolute stillness within me, I completed that composition in an instant. It was a work commissioned by the Salzburg Festival.”

Perhaps the exchange between Mr. Willi and Author Jeong had grown too solemn, for Chairwoman Kwon changed the subject.

“Tourism is Montafon’s main source of income, isn’t it? That means you need many tourists. I read in the paper that you intend to open even the remotest mountain valleys to attract them, is that true?”

“There is talk of opening up even the last valleys of Montafon, of holding mountain marathons and building bicycle paths. They even asked me to help with the development. I am worried, because the music that lives

there might be driven away. So I told the city authorities not to do such things, and they all laughed at me.”

Author Jeong joined their conversation.

“Those who live only within the visible world could never understand, could they?”

“I opposed it, but a few years later they held the mountain marathon anyway. Since then, it has taken place every July. The music I once encountered has left the marathon course and now dwells deep within the mountains.”

“So the music that once lived peacefully within absolute stillness has gone into exile.”

“Yes. Even if everyone mocks me, I hold absolute faith and reverence for the music that lives in the mountains. But the places where that music dwells are growing rarer, because nature is being destroyed. Even in Montafon, the damage to nature is severe. Still, perhaps it’s a small blessing amid misfortune, there are a few places where music still lives, within fifty kilometers of the village valleys. Yet before long, we’ll have to go deeper and deeper into the gorges to find it, into places where tourists never set foot.”

“If the way isn’t too rough, I’d like to visit myself.”

“All right. Let’s go right now.”

Mr. Willi accepted Author Jeong’s suggestion at once, speaking as naturally as if he had planned it from the start. Mrs. Park switched off the small recorder and slipped it into her purple crossbody bag.

Deep Conversations Part 4 - 1,600 Meters Above Sea Level

Mr. Willi drove his sedan with the group aboard. After about ten minutes down the asphalt-paved mountain road, a stream flowing out of the Montafon Valley came into view. The stream moved swiftly enough to murmur over stones, its water a clear jade hue. After parking the car in the village lot and crossing the bridge, they found themselves on a narrow footpath. On the opposite hillside, sheep grazed peacefully. Mrs. Park, fascinated by these gray, woolly balls of fur, took photos with her phone. Chairwoman Kwon walked half a step behind Mr. Willi and Author Jeong to interpret. Soon, Mr. Willi began to speak.

"Montafon is the cradle of my music. My representative work is the *Montafon Series*, a set of concertos for orchestra and four instruments: the first for trumpet, the second for flute and oboe, the third for clarinet, and the fourth for horn."

"Judging by your having composed the *Montafon Series*, it seems, Mr. Willi, that among the people of Montafon you are the person who has received its blessings most fully, perhaps also the one most deeply loved by Montafon itself."

"In the fact that I'm so closely bound to the nature of Montafon, yes, you could say that. Montafon is the beginning and the end of my music. It's also why I can't live in cities like Salzburg or Vienna. It would be like a fish trying to live without water."

"What is the theme of the trumpet concerto?"

"It's about many people who travel to a place where music still lives, stay there for a time, and then return to where they began. The title is *Geräum Zeit*, meaning 'limited space and time.' There's a story behind that name. In our village lived a doctor whose wife loved my music dearly. One day, he called to say his wife had only a few days left to live, and asked if I could pay a visit. I sensed immediately what he meant. I myself had once suffered from an incurable illness and come close to death before

recovering. Because of that, I understood at once that the doctor's wife, too, was within a finite space and time, a realm neither here, in life, nor there, in death."

"So you titled it *Geräum Zeit* in reference to the space and time one dwells in just before death?"

"Yes, that's right."

"In Buddhism, they say that after death, a person spends forty-nine days before taking on their next life. That interval is called the *jungeum*, a kind of waystation where one waits for rebirth. Is it right to understand *Geräum Zeit* in that way?"

"That's a good interpretation. In Catholicism, they say there's purgatory between heaven and hell. Purgatory is a space where souls are purified before entering heaven. Since it is indeed a space and time akin to a waiting room before moving on, it definitely brings to mind Buddhism's *jungeum*."

Author Jeong wondered on which mountainside the music of *Geräum Zeit* might have lived.

"Where does the music of *Geräum Zeit* dwell? Does it still live there now?"

"Tourists rarely go that far, so it's probably still living there. I know with certainty exactly where that music resides. It's on Piz Buin, the highest peak in the mountains of Vorarlberg, Austria, rising 3,312 meters above sea level. It is one of the Alpine peaks along the border between Austria and Switzerland. I used to visit the summit often. It was a sheer ice wall, reachable only by crossing a glacier. Even in midsummer, the ice stayed frozen. At the summit, there was nothing to see but snow and ice, so it felt like standing atop an iceberg. After crossing several ridges, I finally reached the summit and saw, for the first time in my life, a vast ice wall. But it no longer looks as it did then, because the snow and ice are melting. It troubles me deeply. The ice wall was impossibly pure and its center glowed a deep indigo blue. When snow fell or the wind howled, it vanished from sight, yet when visible, its form was sharply defined. In that moment, a trumpet's sound rose from somewhere above me, then faded away. The middle of the ice wall looked like a window, and beyond it was an immense cliff. That's where the music lived, music dwelling in the serene, absolute silence that I encountered there."

Author Jeong fully empathized with the story Mr. Willi was telling. At first, he tried to understand it through a Buddhist framework, seeking intellectual agreement, but now his words seemed to be seeping into his heart rather than his head, naturally and without effort.

"The first sound of music that resided in the ice wall was a note that we humans could hear with our ears, one that we could perceive as the most

delicate. For example, when water freezes, it becomes hard ice, but when it is boiled, it becomes vapor. As the vapor rises, it becomes as clear as air. However, all of these are one and the same. I believe that music, having become as pure as vapor, is the supreme state. Music is the supreme state itself; there is no bottom or middle."

Mr. Willi suddenly stopped speaking. He looked at Author Jeong and Mrs. Park and smiled with childlike innocence, as if gauging their reactions to his monologue. Author Jeong asked Chairwoman Kwon to let Mr. Willi know that they were listening with genuine interest and seriousness, and that he should please continue. As they climbed further along the mountain path, a wide meadow opened before them. On one side, cows grazed leisurely, brass bells the size of fists hanging from their necks. Mr. Willi began to speak again.

"Among all instruments, the clarinet is a special one for me, because my whole family was involved when I learned it. I started playing at around four or five years old, and both my parents were deeply interested. Back then in Montafon, there were only a handful of houses, no school, and of course no music school. So I went to the home of an old man in the village to learn how to play, but he was a strict teacher. If I missed even a single note, he'd pull my ear and make me stand on a chair or desk with my hands raised. I hated going there, so I told my father I didn't want to play the clarinet anymore. The old man must have learned that way himself. When I said I didn't want to go back, my father agreed and said he would teach me himself. If he hadn't, I might have ended my journey in music right there. My father was a carpenter, but he could play all sorts of instruments, clarinet, piano, violin, flute, accordion, and more. He even composed music. Anyway, for several years, he personally taught me how to play the clarinet."

"So you inherited your musicality from your father, then?"

"Yes. My father's side was highly artistic. He was skillful, versatile, and gifted with his hands. He was also an excellent skier. Before I even started school, he used to take me up to the peak of that mountain over there and teach me to ski on the way down. If I hadn't fallen ill, I might have become a ski racer. My mother's side, by contrast, had depth of spirit. Many religious figures came from that family, and there was even a composer who lived around Schubert's time. They say some of his sheet music was found in a relative's attic about twenty years ago. Though my mother never played an instrument, she came to every premiere of my work, listened attentively, and always had something to say. 'This piece will be loved by musicians right away,' or, 'This one will need ten years before people understand it,' she'd say, and she was always right. Isn't that amazing?"

“So both your father’s and mother’s sides were musically gifted, then.”

Mr. Willi, walking ahead, stopped. The mountain path had narrowed, the slope steepened, and the air felt thinner. As Author Jeong looked up toward the summit, wondering, “Do we have to climb higher?”, Mr. Willi turned with a solemn expression and spoke.

“We’re at 1,600 meters above sea level. From here on is where the music lives.”

“This is where you capture the sounds you hear with colored pencils. Aha, it is this place that you brought me all the way here to see.”

“That’s right. Today, I brought you here so you could see for yourself the place where the music I spoke of lives.”

“Thank you very much.”

“Which instrument’s sound lives here?”

“Depending on the place, the music of every instrument lives independently. In an orchestra, the accordionist usually sits somewhere in the middle, but here, each exists alone, like a soloist standing before the orchestra. Just as trees, humans, and mice are all equal parts of nature, so too is the voice of every instrument equal. I’m sketching all of this music within nature, but there are still many parts I haven’t yet brought to life. That’s why my work never ends. I simply continue it while living here in Montafon. That’s why I don’t leave Montafon, or rather, why I can’t leave.”

We returned the way we came, heading downhill to a log cabin rest area on the side of the mountain path. Since it was past lunchtime, we decided to take a break. Mr. Willi and Chairwoman Kwon ordered bread and salad, while Author Jeong and Mrs. Park ordered spaghetti alle vongole, the Korean version of which would be like hand-made noodles with clams.

Deep Conversations Part 5 - Asceticism and Suffering

After their walk, the group decided to return to their respective lodgings to rest. This was so they could attend the traditional Montafon theater performance in the early evening. Chairwoman Kwon mentioned that Mr. Willi had reserved the tickets. Author Jeong and his wife went straight to their guesthouse. Perhaps because she had become more familiar with them over the past two days, the guesthouse owner seemed less shy. She cautiously approached them first.

"How was lunch?"

Author Jeong answered honestly.

"It was so salty it was hard to eat. Next time we go to a restaurant, I'll have to ask them not to add any salt. I'd rather season it myself."

"What did you have?"

"My wife and I shared a plate of spaghetti vongole."

"Ah, Italian food. Since Montafon is so close to Italy, people here often enjoy Italian dishes as well."

When they returned to their room, Mr. and Mrs. Jeong each drank a glass of lemon tea from the table. Their throats felt dry, perhaps from the salty meal, though the taste of salt still seemed to linger. Mrs. Park said,

"I don't think most people would understand what Mr. Willi says. Honestly, it doesn't come naturally to me either, though today, I'm starting to catch more of it."

"I completely empathize with him. It's because I understand it from a Buddhist perspective. Mr. Willi's way of thinking seems Eastern, he seems to prefer intuitive insight to rational thought. Europeans used to rationalism would probably find it hard to understand him."

"Which part, specifically?"

"Mr. Willi's childhood illness, for example. He was sick even in grade school, but the illness he suffered during adolescence is like a complex code. If that code could be deciphered, we might finally understand his life."

“If it’s like a code, it’s like a *hwadu* a monk contemplates in the meditation hall.”

“Exactly. Mr. Willi held on to his illness, or rather, he became one with it and fought through it. In the end, it opened the door of life for him. It even feels like a kind of resurrection. Before leaving Montafon, I plan to ask him more about his incurable illness. There’s something I’ve been thinking about.”

“Won’t Mr. Willi dislike having to relive those painful memories?”

“Not at all. His music began because of his illness, so he’ll probably speak of it warmly and with gratitude. People here in Austria wouldn’t understand the idea of being happy because of illness. There’s a saying in the sutras: ‘Take the suffering of illness as good medicine.’ Do you think people here could understand that teaching of the Buddha?”

“I suppose not.”

“The Buddha teaches us to take illness and suffering as good medicine, to see them not as obstacles in life but as opportunities for growth and enlightenment. Mr. Willi is a composer who has lived that teaching. To me, he’s no different from an Eastern practitioner. Must one shave one’s head and leave home to be an ascetic?”

“You really are deeply interested in Mr. Willi’s illness.”

Author Jeong lay on the bed, resting with his limbs spread wide like the character ‘大’. Mrs. Park took notes in her notebook about Mr. Willi, whom she had met just moments earlier. It was her usual habit and role. When they returned to Korea, she always handed the journal of notes to Author Jeong. She would laugh and call herself his manager, the one who handled his schedule. To that, Author Jeong would joke, not “manager” but “*manhi jwo*,” Korean for “give me a lot.”

The Jeongs arrived at Mr. Willi’s house a little earlier than planned, because something they wanted to tell him had come to mind. This time, they met in the garden instead of going up to his second-floor living room. In the garden stood a large earthenware jar, several flower pots, and a round iron table. Plants like Chinese evergreens grew in the jars, and flowers bloomed red in the pots. Since it was early autumn, the lawn was still fresh and green. The Jeongs sat on white iron chairs. When Chairwoman Kwon joined them a moment later, Author Jeong couldn’t hold back and began to speak.

“It’s the story of your painful years in the hospital that you told me yesterday. It was so deeply moving that it hasn’t left my mind. It seems those five years in the hospital became the turning point of your life as a composer, fated, one might say. In the East, monks deliberately undergo

ascetic practice to attain enlightenment. I've met several Korean practitioners who reached enlightenment through such austerity."

"I'd also like to meet and speak with those Korean practitioners who practiced such austerity. If I ever have the chance to visit Korea again, I'd very much like to meet them."

"I can introduce you to them. Some have passed away, while others are still living. For example, Venerable Seongcheol, Venerable Ilta, Venerable Hyeam, and Venerable Beopjeon have passed away, while Venerable Hyeguk and several others are still alive. Venerable Seongcheol practiced for eight years without ever lying down, even when he slept. Venerable Ilta burned four fingers of his right hand in a mountain hermitage. Venerable Hyeam never lay down, day or night, throughout his entire life as a monk. Venerable Beopjeon was so devoted to his practice in one hermitage that, in winter, he would cook enough rice for fifteen days at once, unwilling to waste time cooking, and would sometimes forget to eat. Among those still living, Venerable Hyeguk performed 100,000 prostrations over six months in the Dharma hall, then burned three fingers of his right hand. The heat was so intense that it harmed his liver. In a sense, it was a form of extreme self-mortification. Yet through such austerities, all of these practitioners attained enlightenment. They realized that they and the universe are one. When one becomes one with the universe, one naturally comes to know the truth it holds, just as you, Mr. Willi, hear the sounds of nature."

"That sounds terribly mysterious."

"In my view, Mr. Willi has already had a truly mysterious experience."

"You think I had such an experience?"

"Monks choose asceticism deliberately, but in Mr. Willi's case, it became ascetic practice under circumstances beyond his will, neither self-chosen nor forced by others."

"For me, it was more suffering than asceticism."

"Mr. Willi, you once said the hospital felt like a monastery. That, too, left a deep impression on me."

"Ha ha ha. Did I really say that the painful hospital felt like a monastery?"

Mr. Willi burst out laughing, seemingly amazed by Author Jeong's ability to pick up and interpret the tiniest details in their conversation.

"When the doctors all delivered a terminal diagnosis and gave up on him, Mr. Willi, like a monk in a monastery receiving a revelation, heard a voice from heaven: 'Herbert, you will be cured. You can live.'"

After leaving Innsbruck Hospital, Willi was moved to a Swiss general hospital at his parents' decision, but even the renowned doctors there delivered a hopeless prognosis. Finally, the head of the department, a female

doctor, called Willi's father in Montafon to inform him of the results and explain her opinion. When Willi's father arrived, he asked, "Would you like to come with me to see the doctor?" Willi agreed. In the doctor's office, in the presence of Willi, his father, and the nurses, the female physician spoke very matter-of-factly as she gave her opinion.

"There is nothing more we can do. As doctors, our work here is finished. Whether Willi remains in the hospital or goes home is now his choice."

For a moment, everyone in the doctor's office fell silent. Willi felt only resentment toward her. To die in the hospital or to die at home, there was nothing to say. For several seconds, or perhaps several minutes, a heavy silence hung in the air. No one spoke. It was a moment of complete stillness. Willi's father stood in shock, looking as if he might faint. They had come to the Swiss hospital with such hope, only to face this devastating prognosis. Then Willi heard a voice from heaven: "Herbert, you will be cured. You can live." No one else heard it, only Willi himself.

"In any case, I believe the sound of raindrops falling amid his pain gave Mr. Willi a kind of musical awakening. If anyone were to write his life story, I think that perspective would be essential. And that voice he heard in the Swiss hospital, wasn't it a moment much like the enlightenment Eastern ascetics reach after long austerities?"

"I wouldn't dare say they were the same. But what is certain is that after hearing that voice from heaven, I went to a monastery and did as the priest instructed, and from then on, my body slowly began to recover."

Chairwoman Kwon gave Author Jeong a look. It was time to go for dinner. Afterward, they were scheduled to see Montafon's traditional play. Thinking they could continue the conversation over the meal, Author Jeong quickly took the hint.

Deep Conversations Part 6 - The Last Supper

Author Jeong and his wife went to the Thai restaurant again. On their first day in Montafon, Mr. Willi had paid for dinner; this time, Chairwoman Kwon offered to treat them. The Jeongs felt a little guilty but decided to accept her kindness. It was still early, and several tables were empty. Willi and the group sat by the window overlooking the Montafon mountains.

A tall, cheerful waitress came over with menus. Willi pointed at the menu and asked her to explain. The waitress recommended two dishes and described them. Jeong was planning to order the same pork-leg rice bowl he had eaten before. The rice wasn't as sticky as Korean rice, but the lean pork, free of fat, had been wonderfully chewy. The waitress smiled brightly and explained kindly as she held up the menu.

"There are two rice dishes," she said. "One is Khao Kha Mu, stewed pork leg over rice, and the other is Khao Pad, fried rice with shrimp, squid, chicken, pork, and egg. We also have noodle dishes: Mama Pad Kee Mao Kung, spicy fried instant noodles with shrimp and squid; and Pad Thai, stir-fried rice noodles with shrimp, chicken, tofu, and crushed peanuts. For salad, I recommend Yam Woon Sen, a spicy, tangy glass-noodle salad with shrimp, squid, and lettuce."

Mrs. Park, saying she didn't care much for pork, ordered Pad Thai. Author Jeong again chose the Khao Kha Mu. Willi and Chairwoman Kwon ordered a Yam Woon Sen salad to share, along with Pad Thai and Mama Pad Kee Mao Kung, respectively.

While waiting for the food, they refreshed themselves with the Thai drink, coconut water, placed on the table. Chairwoman Kwon spoke first, her tone tinged with regret.

"It's been only three days since we came to Montafon, but it feels much longer. Tomorrow morning we'll have to say goodbye to Mr. Willi. That's why I'd like to pay for tonight's dinner. You'll miss him too, won't you, Mr. and Mrs. Jeong?"

“I’d like to thank Mr. Willi for his warm hospitality,” Author Jeong said. “And of course, Chairwoman Kwon as well. Dr. Werner isn’t here with us tonight, but I’m grateful for all his efforts too.”

“Werner went to Bregenz to see some friends,” Willi said. “He’ll be back early tomorrow. It’s been a long time since he’s met them.”

Mr. Willi added, “Meeting you, Author Jeong and Mrs. Jeong from Korea, has been a blessing. I truly thank you for understanding my music. I hope we can meet again and talk more.”

Chairwoman Kwon seconded Mr. Willi’s wish. “Since Author Jeong and his wife have come to Montafon once, they’ll surely come twice, or three times, won’t you?”

“We hope so too,” Author Jeong said.

“You will, absolutely. If not, I’ll come to Korea and bring you myself.”

At that, Mr. Willi rolled his eyes playfully and laughed. “Sonja, don’t kidnap them! Ha-ha-ha.”

“Our time together has gone so quickly. Mr. Willi says he has a question for you, Author Jeong.”

“Please, go ahead,” Jeong said.

“Yes, absolute silence, absolute stillness. How do you say that in Buddhism?”

“It is called *jeokmyeol*. It is a state of utter emptiness where everything has perfectly vanished. Upon entering that state, the ego, the self, disappears, and I exist as the whole. I told you that practitioners undergo ascetic practices to reach that state.”

“*Jeokmyeol*, so practitioners undergo austerities to realize that. Ah, I resonate with the notion of existing as the whole. In my own case, I came to understand that *jeokmyeol* doesn’t only exist within nature somewhere, but also within my own mind. In that moment, nature and I, the universe and I, become the whole.”

“I understand one hundred per cent what you mean about becoming the whole musically, Mr. Willi. There are people who live within the clamour of the city yet whose minds dwell as if in tranquil mountains, and there are those who live amidst tranquil mountains yet whose minds dwell as if in the clamour of the city. You seem like a composer who carries the tranquil mountains within you.”

“Of course, it was only after leaving the hospital and after much time had passed that I realized stillness existed within my heart. It was when my life had matured. Until then, I’d wandered the Montafon mountains for years. With no work came no income. Composing was beyond my reach. For years, I carried a small recorder. I recorded the sounds of mountain animals, water, even the crack of a branch breaking. When I listened to those

recordings some 45 years later, the sound quality wasn't great, but it gave me an idea for how to recreate that very same sound. Birds communicate with each other using very high-pitched notes from great heights, while we humans communicate with each other using much lower frequencies, don't we? So, by making the bird sounds lower and the water sounds higher, it seemed like we could create sounds we could communicate with. The *Nachtschwalbe* (nightjar) produces sound at an incredible speed in just a few seconds. But when I slowed down that sound, I could understand what it meant."

"I never intended to use such things in my compositions, but the composer Olivier Messiaen, whom I most respect and who taught me so much, would orchestrate bird songs directly and have them performed immediately."

"Then what significance did bird songs hold for you?"

"My interest lay entirely in how these sounds within nature operate within harmony, that was my true concern."

"So rather than directly translating natural sounds into music as a composer, you were more interested in nature's order or underlying principles?"

"That was precisely the reason I studied the bird songs I had recorded. If I, too, could perhaps be a bird, how should I go about reproducing its song? I needed to discover that secret to communicate with them, didn't I? I tried slowing down the recordings and then playing them on my clarinet. But I could never perfectly reproduce the birdsong, because certain notes would simply stop and not return. When I sped the recording up fourfold, the clarinet produced sounds it couldn't make before, but it was still not perfect. In the end, I discovered within my own heart the exact equivalent of nature's absolute silence. There is much music in this world that has no connection to nature. But the music that holds the most meaning for me is that which is born from a profound relationship with nature. When you turn inward, the sound you hear in the deepest part of your heart, from within that absolute silence, that is what is truly precious."

"In seeking nature's absolute silence, that absolute stillness, you found absolute silence within your own heart."

"Decades ago, when I wandered around collecting the sounds of nature, I was searching outwardly. Now, however, the silence within my heart has become precious, because all the sounds of nature already reside within the mind's absolute stillness. I realized that the birdsong heard in nature and the birdsong heard within the mind's absolute silence are one and the same. Everything exists within the mind. Thus, only the absolute stillness, the absolute silence within the heart, is truly precious."

"Hearing Mr. Willi speak of perceiving absolute silence within his mind reminded me of an old poem. It's about a Chinese Buddhist nun who once left her hermitage in search of spring. They say she crossed hills, climbed mountains, and even trod upon the clouds in her quest, yet she never saw spring. In the end, having failed to find it, she returned to her hermitage only to discover spring had arrived right there in the plum blossoms blooming in her courtyard. This also brings to mind the teaching, "All phenomena are created by the mind" (一切唯心造), that the mind is like a painter, sketching out all of reality. Put another way, everything exists within the mind."

Mr. Willi was truly touched by Author Jeong's words and exclaimed with delight that it was a profoundly moving poem. Just then, their dinner was served, preventing the conversation from continuing, but the poem was beautiful enough to soothe the regret of this being their final meal together. For Author Jeong, the braised pork rice bowl they had for dinner was even more delicious than he remembered from his first try. Unlike the excessively salty spaghetti alle vongole he had for lunch, this dish was perfectly suited to the Korean palate. The prawns in the Yam Woon Sen salad were also exquisite.

After the meal.

They moved to the village theater to watch a traditional Montafon play. As they didn't understand German, Author Jeong and his wife were not particularly moved by it. Frida, the woman said to be meeting Mr. Willi freely, slipped in quietly, but they paid her no mind, as matters between men and women often have their inscrutable aspects. For Author Jeong, however, the traditional Montafon costumes felt endearingly familiar, as they resembled those from Switzerland. The men wore round, cake-like hats, shorts, and long socks pulled up to their knees, while the women wore checkered blouses and skirts that flared out at the bottom like morning glory flowers. Among the cast, one man in particular gave Author Jeong a start. There was a male performer who bore an uncanny resemblance to the late children's author Jeong Chaebong, who had been both his university senior and his workplace colleague. It was a profoundly emotional moment for Author Jeong, as if he had been reunited with the departed writer.

So Long, Montafon

The owner of the guesthouse expressed regret upon learning that the Author and Mrs. Jeong were leaving, perhaps having grown accustomed to their presence. She asked if they had experienced any inconveniences during their stay, toasted bread for breakfast, and even brewed coffee specially for them. Having packed their luggage neatly into their suitcases the previous evening, the couple left the guesthouse lightly. They were going to bid farewell to Mr. Willi before departing for Vienna.

The weather was overcast with a light mist. The dew-covered leaves seemed to foretell a warming day ahead. Mr. Willi was waiting for the couple in the garden, his silver hair damp with morning dew as if he had been out walking. Author Jeong noticed the yellow leaves scattered across the lawn overnight and turned to Mrs. Park.

“Honey, please take a picture.”

Mr. Willi, his hands tucked into the pockets of his gray jumper, approached Author Jeong. Mrs. Park remarked that the author, dressed in a dark brown modernized hanbok top and trousers, and Mr. Willi in jeans, looked surprisingly well matched. Perhaps it was not their clothing but the sympathetic expressions they shared in conversation over three nights and four days that made them seem so attuned. Author Jeong, too, felt none of the sense of foreignness often felt toward Westerners. This was because he could fully understand Mr. Willi’s philosophy of music. In truth, “musical philosophy” was not quite right; it would be more accurate to say he had come to understand Willi the man.

Just as Mr. Willi was about to take a photograph, he made the group laugh. It seemed that the only Korean word he knew was “kimchi.”

“Kimchi!”

The group laughed heartily and got into Dr. Werner’s car. They soon descended from St. Anton, where Mr. Willi lived, and rounded a bend in the Montafon mountains. Chairwoman Kwon spoke.

“It seems Frida sometimes comes by to help at Mr. Willi’s house. That’s reassuring.”

“Wouldn’t it be better if she moved in with Mr. Willi?”

Chairwoman Kwon replied to Mrs. Park.

“Frida apparently has a son from when she lived with her ex-husband. That’s why she doesn’t move in with Mr. Willi but only drops by from time to time. Frida isn’t a full-time homemaker; she’s a working woman with a career.”

“Didn’t you say Mr. Willi had a wife?”

“Ah, there was a woman who had been a schoolteacher. But I heard that she and Mr. Willi came to an agreement and that she left quietly. She was a very fine woman whose father ran an orchard, but there are many things between husband and wife that no one can know.”

“It seems that Austrians part ways when their marriages become too uncomfortable to endure?”

“There is that tendency. It’s not uncommon for couples to separate yet remain friends afterward. Perhaps it’s because individualism is stronger here than in Korea.”

“Could it be that Mr. Willi loved music more than his wife? If so, she must have felt unbearably lonely.”

Author Jeong found little interest in their conversation. So he kept silent, his eyes fixed on the receding slopes of the Montafon. The car passed through the gorge and entered a long tunnel; once through it, they would leave the Montafon behind. At first glance, the Montafon’s scenery looked similar to that of other regions, yet it was unmistakably different. The green pastures and meadows were alike, but in the Montafon gorge the breath of the Alps flowed. Its high mountains held primeval glaciers and absolute stillness. To Author Jeong, that seemed the most striking difference.

Once the car had completely left Montafon, Author Jeong closed his eyes. Instantly, the tasks awaiting him in Vienna flashed through his mind. The title of his upcoming lecture at the Cardinal Koenig Haus came to him, and he realized it was time to set aside all thoughts of Montafon and begin preparing his talk in his head. The title he had been given was “What Is Buddhism for Koreans?”

Yet the fact that such a title had been requested in a Catholic country, and specifically at the Cardinal Koenig Haus, made him wonder if it came from a place of strong faith. Otherwise, inviting a Korean novelist to speak about Korean Buddhism might have risked unsettling their own convictions.

In any case, Author Jeong began thinking about how to shape the opening of his lecture. Chairwoman Kwon, Mrs. Park, and Dr. Werner, who was driving, exchanged words from time to time, but none of it reached his ears. Once lost in thought, Jeong had the habit of immersing himself completely. Then, an idea for his opening came to him: if he began by

speaking of the connection between Koreans and Austrians, it would open the hearts of the Austrians attending his lecture at the Cardinal Cultural Center. Naturally, that link was Mrs. Francesca Donner, the Austrian-born wife of Korea's first president, Syngman Rhee. Once he had decided on the introduction, the rest of the outline quickly fell into place. Author Jeong arranged his opening in his mind.

〈I am Jeong Chanju, a novelist from Korea.

I thank you all for coming despite your busy schedules and for your warm welcome. I am especially grateful to the staff of the Cardinal Cultural Center for granting me this opportunity to speak, and to Ms. Sonja Steindl-Kwon, Chairwoman of IMK, for arranging it. I have long believed that Korea and Austria, though geographically distant, are emotionally close nations. This is because the wife of Korea's first president, Syngman Rhee, was Mrs. Francesca, who was born near Vienna. I wish to share with you today that Koreans still respect and remember Mrs. Francesca, who was both wise and modest.〉

Once the opening was settled, the rest of the lecture flowed naturally, like a thread unwinding. Although the car suddenly stopped for some reason, it did not break Author Jeong's concentration.

〈The topic of my lecture today is "What Is Buddhism for Koreans?" First, I would like to briefly introduce how Korean history began. I hope this will help you better understand today's lecture.〉

Austria, too, must have its own founding legends of ancient kingdoms. Korea is no different. Korean history begins with Gojoseon in 2333 BCE. This is recorded in *Samguk Yusa*, a Korean historical text compiled about a thousand years ago by the monk Ilyeon. In it, he recounts the founding of Gojoseon in the following mythic form.

Hwanung, the son of Hwanin, the Heavenly Emperor, received three heavenly seals and descended with a retinue of three thousand to the sacred mountain Taebaeksan. Beneath the divine altar tree on its summit, he established the divine city. He appointed the Lords of Wind, Rain, and Clouds to govern the various affairs of the human world. Then, a bear and a tiger living together in the same cave came to Hwanung and prayed to become human. Hwanung gave them a handful of mugwort and twenty cloves of garlic, saying, "If you eat these for one hundred days without seeing sunlight, you will become human."

The bear obeyed Hwanung's command and became a woman after twenty-one days, while the tiger failed to do so. The bear, now a woman, prayed to Hwanung for a child. Hwanung briefly took human form and granted her wish. Their son was Dangun Wanggeom (Dangun: priest; Wanggeom: ruler), who governed Gojoseon during the era when ritual and

governance were one. Thus Gojoseon became the root of Korean history, marking the beginning of five thousand years of Korean civilization.

Why did Venerable Ilyeon record the story of Gojoseon as a legend rather than as historical fact? In Ilyeon's time, the Yuan dynasty of China constantly interfered with the sovereignty of Goryeo, the small Korean kingdom. Thus, conscious of China's power, Ilyeon could only present Gojoseon's founding as myth. To reveal the roots of Korean history was to awaken the Korean spirit, precisely what China sought to suppress.

Hwanung, son of Hwanin, the Heavenly Emperor, was the ruler of a powerful tribal confederation that worshipped heaven. The bear and tiger likely represented tribes that revered those animals. How could the son of Heaven marry a bear and produce a human child? It must have symbolized the union of a strong tribe with a smaller one. The tiger-worshipping tribe probably migrated elsewhere. The bear symbolizes endurance and virtue, while the tiger symbolizes courage. Koreans are the descendants of the tribe that revered the bear. Perhaps that is why Koreans so often say *gomapda* ("thank you") rather than *gamsahada*. One theory holds that *gomapda* derives from the word "bear," meaning "you are like a noble bear." Thus, *gomapda* is an even more respectful expression than *gamsahada*.

Dr. Werner suggested that they spend the night in Krems instead of going straight to Vienna, to rest at his home on the banks of the Danube before continuing on. Mrs. Park readily agreed on behalf of Author Jeong. Jeong kept his eyes closed, fully absorbed in shaping the lecture in his mind, and took no part in their conversation.

Taegeukgi on the Danube

The group had lunch at a service station halfway between Montafon and Krems. Though it was a buffet restaurant, the menu was disappointing. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park took bread and vegetable salad, eating bread again after having had it for breakfast. As they didn't care for meat, there wasn't much else to eat. The spaghetti vongole they'd had in Montafon wasn't on the buffet. While Dr. Werner filled the car with gas, Chairwoman Kwon remarked,

"You must be tired. You've had your eyes closed ever since we left Montafon."

"Not at all. I was organizing my thoughts for the lecture at the Cardinal Culture Center."

"We've been chatting all this time. Were you really able to concentrate?"

Mrs. Park chimed in.

"When my husband focuses on a thought, he pays no attention to those around him."

"Ah, I see. That could be it."

"Shall we take Mr Willi as an example? He mentioned hearing various sounds twenty-four hours a day, even during sleep, didn't he? Yet it is as if he has been working on his own music within that. Things are happening all around him, but they do not interfere with his focus on his own thoughts. Perhaps that is on a different level from concentration or immersion. When one is truly concentrated or immersed, it becomes impossible to take in what is going on around one."

Chairwoman Kwon asked with a smile.

"When Mr. Willi says he hears sounds 24 hours a day, it pains me. How tormented he must be?"

"In my view, he isn't tormented. The sounds merely exist. They offer Mr. Willi no stimulation whatsoever. Nor do they hinder his composing."

"Is that possible?"

"It is a state that goes a level beyond concentration or immersion. In Buddhism, this is called samadhi. When one enters samadhi, one can still

take in what is happening around one while devoting oneself fully to one's work. In that sense, Mr. Willi is in samadhi twenty-four hours a day."

"Was Author Jeong also in samadhi just now?"

"I've never been in samadhi for an entire day. But I have often entered it briefly when writing. I heard everything Chairwoman Kwon and Dr. Werner said just now. Yet my single thought was not disturbed at all, that thought being the organization of my lecture content. Shall I tell you what Chairwoman Kwon and Dr. Werner talked about?"

"It wasn't particularly important."

"Before going to the Krems house we talked about stopping at the supermarket, since Author Jeong doesn't eat meat from four-legged animals we should buy turkey; before moving Mrs. Park's work from the Ampark Gallery to the hall where Author Jeong will lecture we should meet Sabine first to discuss it, and so on."

It was Chairwoman Kwon's idea for Mrs. Park to hold a two-person exhibition with the Austrian ceramic artist Sabine at the venue where Author Jeong would lecture. Since he knew Sabine he planned a joint East-West ceramics exhibition. The venue would be empty for the day so holding an exhibition there presented no difficulty.

At last the car entered the town center of Krems. It was the first time Author Jeong and his wife had seen it. Their first impression was that it was historic and quiet. The old brick buildings all had a weighty look. It resembled the streets of Gyeongju, Korea's ancient capital. The group saw the town only through the car windows before going directly to a large supermarket. The ingredients were mainly bought by the meticulous and careful Dr. Werner. As if wanting to make a good impression on the author, Dr. Werner said:

"Author, a turkey is not a four-legged animal."

"Thank you."

"Not at all."

However, buying a turkey did not satisfy both guests from Korea. Mrs. Park did not eat meat from creatures with two legs, such as chicken or duck. Yet, Author Jeong did not mention Mrs. Park's dietary habits to Dr. Werner. The doctor's kindness meant more to him than Mrs. Park's dietary preferences.

Dr. Werner and his wife's house lay on the outskirts of Krems. Only after passing orchards, farms, and a couple of small villages did their detached house appear. Opposite stood the banks of the Danube. Its location, removed from the village, gave it the feel of a secluded, quiet retreat. After Dr. Werner entered first, the Jeong couple lingered outside for a moment, admiring the peaceful surroundings. Chairwoman Kwon remarked,

"This house was originally an annex to the monastery. Dr. Werner acquired it through a close priest friend at the monastery."

"I sensed that immediately."

"The monastery found it difficult to maintain, hence the sale. The building visible on the hill over there is the monastery itself, though it's quite a distance away."

Dr. Werner had informed Chairwoman Kwon that he had roughly tidied the house. However, upon gazing at the garden, the writer couple were startled. The Korean national flag [called the Taegeukgi] was hoisted on the flagpole. It was clear Dr. Werner had gone in first to raise it. Author Jeong felt his heart swell, as if he were receiving a state guest's welcome. The Taegeukgi waved gently in the river breeze.

Only upon entering the living room of Dr. Werner and his wife's house did Author Jeong express his gratitude to Dr. Werner.

"Thank you, Doctor."

"Not at all."

"If you were to visit Korea, Doctor, I would erect a flagpole at my residence and hoist the Austrian flag."

Chairwoman Kwon responded to Author Jeong's words.

"That is a splendid idea. Should Mr. Willi also visit Author Jeong's residence, I imagine he would be most pleased if the Austrian flag were displayed."

"Of course. Whenever guests arrive from abroad, I intend to fly their nation's flag."

Dr. Werner prepared the turkey dish at the sink. Meanwhile, Author Jeong admired the landscape paintings by Dr. Werner hanging in the hallway and living room. They were oil paintings in an Impressionist style. The color combinations and brushwork were skillful for amateur work. While eating the turkey dish at dinner, Author Jeong said to Dr. Werner.

"Next time my wife and I visit, I hope to see your work exhibited in a gallery. I sincerely hope you hold a solo exhibition."

"They're just paintings done as a hobby; I'm not sure they're worthy of exhibition."

"Actually, I too loved painting enough to be in the art club until high school. I copied Van Gogh's paintings a lot."

"So we share that affinity, Author Jeong. But I'll give the solo exhibition more thought."

After dinner, Dr. Werner guided Author Jeong and his wife to the banks of the Danube. The riverbank lay right at the edge of their garden and their vegetable patch. Standing on the embankment, the Danube flowing through the outskirts of Krems didn't appear particularly wide. A reed bed along the

riverbank made it seem even narrower. A sharp river breeze blew in, making it impossible to sit on the bench for long. Mrs. Park was rather sensitive to the cold.

Chairwoman Kwon offered the couple a room on the second floor. There was a small sitting room with a sofa upstairs too. Mrs. Park went into the bathroom and ran a warm bath, while Author Jeong continued developing the lecture outline he'd conceived on the journey to Krems. This time, he focused on the Korean peoples' love of peace and their distinct identity.

〈Korea has historically endured countless invasions from China and Japan. Geographically, China and Japan could only expand their territories by occupying Korea. Despite this, Korea has never once invaded China or Japan. Koreans have never attacked other nations; even when wronged, they have endured like bears, loving only peace.

There is another reason I take pride as a Korean. Despite frequent invasions, Korea was never absorbed or assimilated into the culture of any great power. I am proud that Korea has maintained its unique identity and developed its own distinct culture. Korea possesses its own language, used exclusively by Koreans, and the highly scientific and original script, hangeul. When China exerted diplomatic influence over Korea, Chinese characters were used; when Japan forcibly occupied and ruled Korea, Japanese characters were used. Yet today, all Koreans use hangeul, created five hundred years ago during the Joseon Dynasty by King Sejong the Great and the monk Sinmi. As a writer who composes novels in my mother tongue, hangeul, I have always held a profound interest in it. It was this motivation that led me to publish the novel *The Moon Reflected in Thousand Rivers*, which unravels the secrets behind the creation of hangeul.〉

After a cursory wash of hands and feet, Author Jeong lay down on the bed and continued his lecture. Mrs. Park, evidently exhausted, soon drifted off to sleep.

A Night in Krems

The ceiling of the Jeong's second-floor room featured a rectangular skylight. Moonlight streamed through, keeping the room from being dark. Due to its position, the moon itself wasn't visible. Mrs. Park soon began snoring softly. Author Jeong came out into the living room and took a notebook from his suitcase. While he could memorize the opening of the lecture, committing the entire content to memory felt burdensome. He reckoned he'd have to jot down the lecture content in his notebook and refer to it during the talk to avoid mistakes. He first organized the main body of the lecture in his mind. He then settled on 'Why do Koreans like Buddhism?' as the central theme. He'd previously published similar content in an essay and it was a topic he'd occasionally discussed over tea with acquaintances, so it posed no difficulty.

〈Buddhism is a religion that originated in India around the fifth century BC. Its founder was the Buddha and its doctrine is the truth the Buddha realized. Buddhism begins from the premise that life is marked by suffering through the course of birth, aging, sickness, and death. To escape suffering, one must remove its causes by oneself. In Buddhism, this is the only way that salvation and happiness could be found. The Buddhist position is that I save myself; no god or other transcendent being saves me. Buddhism is not a theocentric religion but a humanistic one. It is a religion that seeks above all to uphold the value and dignity of human beings as they exist in reality. Thus, the Buddha rejected the caste system and taught that all human beings are equal.

Early Buddhism during the Buddha's lifetime held that achieving one's own happiness was the supreme goal. The aim of Mahayana Buddhism, which emerged after the Buddha passed away and entered parinirvana, was to seek the truth (上求菩提: seek enlightenment above) and then benefit all beings (下化衆生: transform sentient beings below). Mahayana Buddhism upholds as its ideal that both I and others attain happiness. Mahayana Buddhism does not pray for oneself; praying for others is true prayer. Its basis lies in the Buddha's logic of interdependence: "Because this exists, that exists; because that ceases, this ceases." Without me, not a single

flower, cloud, or star would exist. Without the sun, wind, and rain, I too would disappear. In other words, the Buddha's truth is that all beings in the world are branches, leaves, and flowers arising from a single root. Therefore, when others become happy, I too become happy; when others become unhappy, I too inevitably become unhappy.

There are two theories regarding the transmission of Buddhism to Korea. One holds that it was formally adopted through diplomatic channels from China in the second year of King Sosurim (372 AD) of the ancient northern kingdom of Goguryeo. The other holds that Queen Heo Hwang-ok of the southern Indian kingdom of Ayuta, having set out in search of a new land, brought Buddhism to the ancient southern Korean kingdom of Gaya in 48 AD. In any case, Buddhism has been in Korea for more than 1,600 years. Why did Buddhism spread so quickly through the royal court and wider society after its arrival? As a writer, this is how I see it.

First, Buddhism suited the Korean people, who cherished peace over conflict. Before Buddhism arrived, Korea had only modest forms of indigenous beliefs, Daoism, and Confucianism. That is, indigenous beliefs involving totem worship and belief in mountain spirits; Daoism centered on praying to the Big Dipper; and Ruism [commonly known as Confucianism] based on the teachings of Kongzi (Latinized: Confucius). Buddhism, however, did not conflict with these traditions, it embraced them all. Even today, when visiting Korean temples, one finds traces of Daoism in the Chilseonggak shrines to the Big Dipper and Sangingak shrines to mountain spirits, and many poems and writings left by Ruist scholars.

Buddhist compassion is the non-dualistic love of becoming one with others. It is never a dualistic love that distinguishes between self and others. The philosophical depth and greatness of Buddhism lie precisely in this non-dualism, as vast as the sky and as deep as the ocean. Integration and harmony, not separation and conflict, are Buddhism's defining characteristics.

Second, Buddhism was a good fit for the patient Korean people. Buddhism's concept of time is not limited to the present alone. It encompasses the past, present, and future. Thus, present life is merely a fleeting moment. This Buddhist view of time aligned well with the relaxed disposition of Koreans. When an adult passes away, Koreans do not say they "died" but rather that they "have returned." In other words, it expresses the idea that they have moved from this point today to some point tomorrow. Buddhist cosmology is also not limited to just our solar system. There are countless solar systems and heavens. It is said that the Buddha, living as the Bodhisattva Prabhupala (Kor: Homyeong) in one of these heavens, the

Tushita Heaven, descended to the human world to become a teacher, helping humans realize "perfect happiness" by eliminating their own afflictions.

Because Koreans believe in both the past and the future, they have generally overcome hardships and adversities without succumbing to despair or discouragement. In a sense, they have developed a genetic code for an unyielding vitality. Buddhism emphasizes endurance and patience, while also teaching the importance of accumulating good deeds. These acts are, in essence, a form of savings laid aside for future happiness. In Buddhism, no one is exempt from the law of cause and effect. It applies equally to all; no one receives special privilege. If you sow good seeds, you will reap good fruit; if you sow evil seeds, you will reap evil fruit. There is a Korean proverb that expresses this perfectly: "Plant beans, and you get beans; plant red beans, and you get red beans." This saying, too, has its roots in Buddhist teachings. And in the Buddhist *Lotus Sutra*, we find a similar lesson:

Do you want to know what happened in the past?

It is what you receive today.

Do you want to know what will happen in the future?

It is what you create today.

Third, a full 80% of Korea's cultural assets are a legacy of Buddhism. It is impossible to discuss Korean culture and thought without acknowledging the central role of Buddhism. The Korean government, which maintains a strict separation of religion and state, provides support for the preservation and management of Buddhist culture. This is done not to promote the religion of Buddhism itself, but to protect Korea's traditional culture and ideology. It is a matter of national policy to ensure that Korea does not lose its unique identity.

I have been sharing my thoughts on "What is Buddhism to Koreans?" as they come to me. Yet, even from this cursory overview, it is clear that Buddhism is more than just a religion to us; it has become part of the very lifeblood of the Korean people.

Present-day Korea is a multi-religious society. Calling it a "religious department store" would not be an exaggeration. Adherents of Christianity, Buddhism, Ruism, Daoism, Islam, and other faiths live their religious lives with vibrancy and freedom. The greatest aspiration of the Korean people is the reunification of the Korean peninsula. However, some scholars suggest that the most significant challenge after reunification could be conflict among religions. Yet, considering the inherent resilience of Koreans, I believe such a tragedy will not come to pass.

In the 2nd century BC, Emperor Ashoka of India converted to Buddhism, renounced the sword of conquest, and dispatched monks to spread the Dharma to regions including Rome, South India, Sri Lanka, and

Southeast Asia. His dream was to achieve world peace through the truth of Buddhism. Ashoka enacted policies for the benefit of all living beings, not just humans. Among these was the construction of animal hospitals throughout India, a measure rooted in the conviction that animal life possesses the same dignity as human life. Though these events transpired in the 2nd century BC, I believe Ashoka's model of leadership is one we still require in the 21st century. To contemplate the dignity of all living beings in this world and to love them as part of one's own body is, I believe, our duty and our wisest course of action today.>

Author Jeong was unable to finish his lecture notes and stepped into the room where Mrs. Park lay sleeping. A tide of weariness and exhaustion suddenly washed over him, and his shoulders grew heavy, as if made of stone. It seemed a lamp was lit in the room, or perhaps it was the moonlight, filtering through the skylight, filling the space with its gentle, rippling luminescence.

The Sound of Warm River Water

The moonlight kept Author Jeong from falling asleep easily. Although he felt he would soon drift off once he lay down, the moonlight filtering through the skylight kept flickering before his eyes. He pulled the duvet over his head, but it was no use. Tossing and turning with his eyes closed, sleep seemed to drift farther and farther away. Soon after, a whispering sound kept drifting in from somewhere. Thinking it might be an auditory hallucination, Author Jeong shook his head. But it was neither a hallucination nor the sound of crickets. The whispering was coming from outside the window.

With no other choice, Author Jeong got up and quietly walked into the living room. After sitting briefly on the sofa, he opened the balcony window and stepped outside. The night air swept over him with a sharp chill, but he stood at the balcony railing in his slippers. The moon was high in the middle of the sky. The sky was a cloudless expanse, dark blue like a deep sea. It wasn't the moon that had called him out. Jeong was no sleepwalker. The sound was clearly coming from the direction of the Danube. Flowing between the reeds, the Danube shimmered gold.

"Sweetheart, what's wrong?"

"I thought you were asleep, so I came out quietly."

"Actually, I woke when you were tossing and turning."

"I came out because I thought I heard whispering from somewhere."

"You'll catch a chill in this cold night air. Hurry inside."

Sleep had already fled far away, and Author Jeong was completely absorbed by the identity of the whispering sound.

"It sounds just like this."

"Could it be the sound of fallen leaves rustling in the river breeze?"

"The river breeze blew during the day, but it's calm now. Look at the leaves. Not a single one is moving."

Mrs. Park listened closely and looked around.

"It seems to be coming from the Danube, the place where Mr. Willi spoke of absolute silence."

"That seems so."

"It might be the sound of birds nesting in the reed beds."

Mrs. Park spoke as if she had gotten a hint from Author Jeong's mention of the reed beds.

"It sounds like the river water brushing against the reeds. It's the same sound, right? Listening to it, the night air feels cold, but my heart feels warm."

"The moonlight reflected on the river does look warm. It suddenly feels like a warm night."

Yet the cold night air made Mrs. Park shrink back, and Author Jeong felt the same. The Danube, shimmering gold, was serene and beautiful, but they did not have the resolve to keep standing there taking it in. The couple returned to their room and lay down. The sound of the river brushing the reeds seemed to follow them inside and linger briefly in the room. Before long, Mrs. Park fell asleep easily, while Author Jeong, having not finished his lecture manuscript, went back out to the living room and sat on the sofa. Now the river's low whisper was warm yet distinct.

Author Jeong decided to conclude his lecture with the question, "Why do I study Buddhist literature?" because he had omitted a self-introduction in both the opening and main body. For the audience, a speaker's self-introduction could be a matter of courtesy. Jeong judged that explaining the history of Korean Buddhist literature first would be the right way to express his identity as a Korean.

〈Korean Buddhist literature begins in the Unified Silla period, one of Korea's ancient states. From the mid-7th century to the early 10th century, poetry using Buddhist themes flourished. Buddhist literature then continued vigorously through the Goryeo period, from the early 10th century to the late 14th century. It was therefore central to Korean literature from the mid-7th century to the late 14th century. During the five hundred years of the Joseon period, Buddhist literature grew alongside Confucian literature as paired traditions. It was only in the modern era, with the influx of Western literature, that Buddhist literature shifted from the center to the margins of Korean art.

However, I am certain that Buddhist literature and Buddhist art will not disappear from Korean society, because Buddhism is part of Korea's traditional culture and traditional thought. As Korea entered modernity and Buddhist literature was pushed away from the center of Korean literary life, a new phenomenon emerged in which foreign Buddhist literature was introduced to Korea. The poetry of the great Indian writer Gandhi, still loved by Koreans today, and Hermann Hesse's novel *Siddhartha* are among those examples.

Being deeply immersed in Buddhism, I read many biographies and novels about the Buddha. Hesse's *Siddhartha* moved me deeply. It is a novel that depicts only half of the Buddha's life, covering the period up until Prince Siddhartha of Kapilavastu leaves home and attains enlightenment as the Buddha. It portrays the human Siddhartha's anguish and love. I believe that is why it was so moving, because young Siddhartha is a human being who struggles just as we do. In my university years, I learned from Hesse that no matter how outstanding a sage may be, a writer must portray the human in order to truly gain the reader's sympathy.

I once heard my mentor Hong Gi-sam, who studied German literature at Heidelberg University, call Schopenhauer the 'father of German Buddhist literature.' I also learned that two figures influenced by Schopenhauer were Nietzsche and Wagner. Wagner's opera libretto *The Victors* (Die Sieger) is a Buddhist opera. Its title was inspired by the Buddhist text the *Dhammapada*.

'Those who conquer themselves are the greatest victors of all. Conquering oneself is harder than vanquishing thousands on the battlefield.'

The story of Wagner's *Die Sieger* is also based on Buddhist scripture. The heroine, Pragriti, the daughter of an outcaste, falls into erotic love after being captivated by the appearance of Ananda, a disciple of the Buddha. Eventually she hears the Buddha teach that in a past life, when she was the daughter of a Brahmin, she mocked and rejected the chieftain's son when he confessed his love, and that as a karmic consequence she has been born in this life as the daughter of a low-caste chieftain to suffer the pain of love. Realizing her situation, she becomes Ananda's spiritual sister, loving him only in spirit. This scriptural story naturally frames the opera's theme as an agape-like love rooted in self-overcoming.

Wagner is said to have written in a letter to his wife Mathilde Wesendonck that "the greatest and most important phenomenon the world can offer is not the 'world conqueror' (Welteroberer), but the one who overcomes the external world through overcoming the self (Wetüberwinder)." This suggests how deeply Wagner was drawn into Buddhist teachings, which emphasize human reason and will.

To date, I have written many novels centered on Korea's great Buddhist masters. This has been part of my effort to explore the virtues and identity that Koreans must never forget. These include *Mountains Are Mountains*, *Water Is Water*, the life story of Master Seongcheol, who practiced without sparing his life for truth, and *Musoyu - the Novel*, a biography of Master Beopjeong, who tirelessly sought dialogue with Christian leaders for the recovery of humaneness.

Under the title *Seven Years of Yi Sun-sin*, I am currently serializing the story of Yi Sun-sin, whom Koreans most revere as the admiral who fought

the Japanese navy, winning 23 battles out of 23, and whom one Japanese general revered as a military god . As for future plans, I wish to write a novel exploring the life and love of Mrs. Francesca, who lived as a boundary-dweller between Austria and Korea. I hope that this novel might then be adapted into an opera to be performed in Vienna, Austria.>

Having finished his lecture at the crack of dawn, Author Jeong closed his eyes contentedly. Though the moon would soon set and dawn would break, he felt he would sleep sweetly and deeply, however fitfully. Having fully prepared his lecture in advance, the mental burden had lifted. Listening to the river's affectionate murmurings like a lullaby, Author Jeong drifted into a deep slumber.

A Special Lecture and Recital

Author Jeong was thoroughly satisfied with his lecture at Vienna's Kardinal König Haus (KKH), having prepared meticulously. He spoke for one hour starting at 3pm, with Chairwoman Kwon providing simultaneous interpretation. Bolstered by the deep interest and enthusiastic response from the packed audience, Jeong delivered his entire prepared content without omission. A 30-minute question-and-answer session followed the lecture. Two individuals left a particularly strong impression. One was a broadcaster.

Austria had only one state-run broadcaster. Their female director, who attended the lecture, remarked, "Through this lecture, I learned that Mrs. Francesca was of Austrian origin," expressing gratitude for the valuable information.

Most of the audience also showed great interest in the fact that Mrs. Francesca was Austrian. Two or three members of the audience asked questions about Mrs. Francesca, such as "What connection led her to meet Korea's first President, Syngman Rhee?" and "Did Koreans love Mrs. Francesca?" Perhaps being a fellow Austrian made them particularly curious. Witnessing this, I felt a strong sense of expectation that Mrs. Francesca would become a figure who would strengthen the friendship between Korea and Austria.

Another question concerned dialogue between Korea's different religious leaders and original sin in Christianity. In response, Author Jeong stated, "As seen in the examples of Cardinal Kim Suhwan and Venerable Beopjeong in Korea, religious leaders frequently engage in dialogue." He then succinctly replied, "If Christianity has original sin, Buddhism has no such concept. Instead, it holds that one reaps what one sows (*jajak jasu*, 自作自受), that cause must precede effect (*ingwa eungbo*, 因果應報), and that both good and evil deeds undergo their own cycle of rebirth." This answer drew applause. Particularly noteworthy was a gentleman resembling a young Catholic monk who had flown in on his private plane from Innsbruck, the city where composer Herbert Willi attended theological seminary. He

consoled Author Jeong, saying, "Though the lecture hall is small and the audience modest, consider that those representing Austria have come."

Jeong concluded his lecture by reiterating key points from his talk during the Q&A session before stepping down from the microphone.

"The opera *Madame Butterfly* introduced Japan to Europe through the appearance of a Japanese woman in a kimono. If I novelize the story of Mrs. Francesca and Austrian composer Herbert Willi composes an opera using it as a libretto, a beautiful and elegant Korean woman in hanbok will appear. I shall await that moment."

Once again, he received thunderous applause, but then Author Jeong suddenly proposed ending the Q&A session. Seeing his strained expression, Chairwoman Kwon hastily made closing remarks. Though the audience felt a pang of regret, they had to content themselves with admiring Mrs. Park's ceramic works displayed around the lecture hall. One woman had already arrived specifically to view the ceramics. She was the gentlewoman who had purchased one of Mrs. Park's pieces at the Ampark Gallery. Author Jeong had recognized her at a glance as someone with a particular fondness for Mrs. Park's work. Moving to the café on the second floor of the Kardinal König Haus, Author Jeong confessed to Chairwoman Kwon and Mrs. Park.

"Before the lecture began, I drank an espresso because I loved its rich aroma, but it seems to have irritated my stomach and startled me."

"Your face went pale during the Q&A session."

Chairwoman Kwon responded to Mrs. Park's concern.

"The espresso's aroma tempted the writer, I see. First-timers should dilute it with water."

"I didn't know that and drank it straight. I was fine during the lecture, but by the end of the Q&A, I was breaking out in a cold sweat."

"So that's why you said you'd wrap up the Q&A session quickly."

"Truth be told, I actually found the Q&A more enjoyable. But I felt I might collapse if I'd continued any longer..."

Mrs. Park inquired.

"Are you better now?"

"Resting has eased the cramping in my stomach."

"But I can't return to the accommodation to rest immediately, as I have a two-person exhibition with Sabine shortly."

"Don't worry. You're gradually improving."

Author Jeong drank warm water instead of tea. It was to soothe his stomach, startled by the strong espresso concentrate. The espresso's stimulation hadn't been fatal, it seemed, as Jeong's condition gradually recovered. Shortly afterward, he regained enough energy to attend the opening ceremony for the two-person exhibition with Mrs. Park and Sabine.

Just then, a text arrived from a Korean Buddhist media outlet. It was reporter Lee Hakjong from *Media Buddha*. Jeong had mentioned the reason for traveling to Austria over the phone when leaving Korea, so the reporter must have been very curious.

It was just 30 minutes after Author Jeong sent his message. It was around 1 a.m. in Korea, past midnight, when reporter Lee Hakjong sent Author Jeong a text after drafting the article, saying, "I'm off to bed now."

Novelist Jeong Chanju (Dharma name: Muyeom) and ceramic artist Park Myeongsuk (Dharma name: Muryanggwang), who are actively engaged in creative work at Ibuljae above Ssangbong-sa temple in Hwasun, South Jeolla Province, embarked on a very special 18-day visit to Austria on September 10.

Their visit, which lasted until September 27, was by invitation from Vienna's KKH for Austrians and overseas Koreans. On September 20, novelist Jeong Chanju gave a special lecture and Q&A session titled "What is Buddhism to Koreans?" From September 14 to 18, Buddhist ceramic artist Park Myeongsuk held a Vienna invitational exhibition themed "The Beauty of Korea" at Galerie Ampark. Artist Park also held a two-person exhibition with Austrian ceramic artist Sabine at the Kardinal König Haus.

The two conveyed to *Media Buddha* that this 18-day visit to Austria was an immensely rewarding journey, conveying the very essence of Korean Buddhist culture, viewed through the dual prisms of "Korean Buddhist Literature" and "Traditional Korean Ceramics," directly to the heart of Austria, a Catholic nation where interest in Buddhism is growing.

Author Jeong intended to send more detailed information via text message, including that the trip to Austria was arranged at the invitation of IMK Chairwoman Kwon Suk-nyeo [Sonja Steindl-Kwon], but decided against it. Reporter Lee's draft article was sufficient. In any case, he planned to refine it further after arriving at work before publishing it in the People in the News section of *Media Buddha* around the time the Jeong couple returned home.

One week later.

It was September 26. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park changed into hanbok once more. They were heading to Vienna's Musikverein Golden Hall, known to Austrian musicians as the Golden Hall. Every year, IMK held a charity concert event at the Golden Hall. This IMK charity event invited Austrian seniors, who seldom encountered classical music, to the concert. The seniors, invited from various Austrian provinces, experienced Korea's filial piety culture through the concert. Chairwoman Kwon, who planned and directed the filial piety concert, announced that the performers participating

in this event were Chinese pianist Shiran Wang (王詩然) and a rising Korean violinist.

As the Jeong-Park couple entered the Golden Hall dressed in hanbok, the Austrian seniors welcomed them with thumbs up gestures. The elderly men and women were also smartly dressed, looking their best. Thanks to Chairwoman Kwon's consideration, the Jeong couple were seated in the middle of the main auditorium on the first floor, with a direct view of the stage.

Chairwoman Kwon sat immediately beside the stage where the musicians were seated before delivering the opening address for the filial piety concert. Though it was in German and thus incomprehensible, it was astonishing in itself that a petite Asian woman was delivering the address with a voice that resonated powerfully throughout the first floor and the upper tiers encircling it. It struck Author Jeong as particularly special and a source of pride that a successful expatriate was holding a charity concert for some 1,700 Austrian seniors in the Golden Hall, the most prestigious of all concert houses.

The two-hour concert ended all too soon. Frankly, though Author Jeong knew little about music, he found it not at all tedious, and seeing the happy expressions in the Austrian seniors' eyes alone was deeply moving. Moreover, after the concert, the Jeong couple were invited to the Golden Hall banquet. Their designated seats were practically VIP level. Seated beside them, Shiran Wang was performing on the piano, and from their vantage point, they could see every subtle expression on her face and the intricate movements of her fingers.

A Month Long Vacation

By late February, blue, red, and white plum blossoms were blooming along the courtyard of the Jeong couple's mountain hermitage, Ibuljae. Looking at the swollen buds on the plum trees, Author Jeong reflected on the epic novel *The Seven Years of Yi Sunsin*, which he had written over the past three years. It was a work he had serialized weekly without missing a single installment. As a result, seven volumes of the epic novel, published by Jakka Publishing house, now sat on his bookshelf. Writing roughly fifty-five 200-character manuscript pages each week for a total of some 8,800 pages, the sheer scale of the work called to mind the height of Mount Everest. At times, Jeong truly felt as though he were climbing step by step toward Everest's summit. Although he received yet another offer to serialize a new work, he decided that, exhausted in both body and mind, he needed at least a month of rest. He wanted to go abroad, choose a place to stay in one or two unfamiliar places, and rest fully.

Mrs. Park felt the same way. Over the three years of weekly serialization, she had proofread each installment whenever Jeong finished a section. As she was teaching and running hands-on sessions for her pottery students while creating her own ceramic works, she fit proofreading into spare moments, so it was only natural that she, too, longed for rest.

"Sweetheart, the Trans-Siberian Railway or Machu Picchu in South America would be pretty difficult now, right?"

"If we were ten years younger, we could probably manage, but long-distance travel seems too taxing now."

"Then where shall we go? How about Greece?"

"But we went to Greece last November, didn't we? Even if it was only a whirlwind visit because it was a cruise."

"When we disembarked on Crete, I was disappointed that I alone didn't get to visit Kazantzakis's grave. I've read *Zorba the Greek* three times. You went only with the university president and one of your juniors. And beyond that, just think how many historical sites Greece has. Last year, we only saw the surface of Greece."

"We couldn't help it, since we had hired only one taxi."

Last November, several disciples had accompanied their revered teacher, Hong Gisam, former president of Dongguk University, on a trip to Greece aboard a 100,000 ton cruise ship departing from Venice. In truth as Mrs. Park observed, although they had gone to Greece, they had visited only Athens and Crete, the ports where the ship docked, and they had not seen any other historical sites. Still, for Jeong, simply paying his respects at Kazantzakis's grave on Crete was as satisfying as seeing all of Greece's other ruins. The epitaph that Kazantzakis had requested be carved on his grave had left a profound impression on him.

"I desire nothing. I fear nothing. I am freedom."

At that moment, Jeong reread "I am free" as "I am nirvana" and surmised that Kazantzakis might have been deeply absorbed in Buddhist thought. To desire nothing, after all, meant having laid down greed and attachment, and to fear nothing meant the extinction of anxiety and the fear of death. This would be Nirvana, the state in which the fires of all afflictions, the very causes of suffering, are completely extinguished, a realm of absolute freedom and absolute peace.

As the coffee in his cup began to cool, Jeong spoke.

"Last year, we really had no choice but to take our mentor on a cruise. It was the shared wish of his close disciples to mark his 77th birthday."

"I really loved the president's lectures on board the ship. I still have the notes I took."

"Our mentor's lectures are delivered in an elevated literary register, so that simply writing them down turns them into finely crafted sentences."

"I especially liked the parts where you spoke about Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Wagner, and the others."

"Could you show me that notebook?"

Mrs. Park brought over a palm-sized notebook and showed it to Author Jeong. Across several pages, their mentor's shipboard lectures were written out in tiny, meticulous script. She appeared to be the only person who had taken notes on his lectures at sea. Jeong read the notebook carefully, paying close attention to the passages that cited the Buddhist scripture *The Dhammapada*.

Schopenhauer, often called the father of German Buddhist thought and Buddhist literature, is widely known to have had two brilliant disciples, Nietzsche and Wagner. It is also well known that Wagner was a major genius composer and writer born within a Christian cultural sphere. In 1865, by composing the opera *The Victors*, he ushered in a new chapter in German Buddhist literature. Scholarly views that define the first period of German Buddhist literature as running from 1865 to 1890 likewise rest on the fact

that this opera was written in 1865. Wagner's decision to title the opera *The Victors* is grounded in the following passage from the *Dhammapada*: "One who conquers oneself is the greatest of all victors. To conquer oneself is more difficult than defeating thousands of enemies on the battlefield. Neither gods nor gandharvas, neither Mara nor Brahma, can overturn the victory of one who has mastered oneself." This teaching, which clearly reveals Buddhism as a religion of self power, affirms that the true victor is not one who conquers the world but one who overcomes oneself, and it was this teaching that inspired the opera *The Victors*. The most meaningful encounter in Wagner's life was his love for Mathilde Wesendonck. He dedicated many works to her and even fashioned operatic protagonists after her. In a letter he wrote to her, Wagner once said, "Compared with the Buddhist worldview, every other dogma ends up looking foolish." It is a well known anecdote that Nietzsche wrote his celebrated work *The Birth of Tragedy* after seeing Wagner's opera *Tristan und Isolde*, and with regard to the overture of this opera Wagner himself remarked: "The only liberation is simply death, extinction, never opening one's eyes again, nothing but moving toward death, the most rapid shedding of existence, the final end of that strange realm, the joy of liberation alone." I have not invoked a renowned Western artist here in order to demonstrate how great the teachings of Shakyani are. How shameful it would be to check Westerners' reactions just to confirm that something of ours is excellent.'

It was then that Author Jeong remembered Mr. Willi, who had once lived in Tuscany, Italy for a year. This was the place where Willi withdrew at the age of forty was near the primeval forests of northern Tuscany. At the height of his fame as a composer, longing for the absolute stillness he had once realized, he left for the villa of an acquaintance in Tuscany. For the next four years, he composed nothing, living in seclusion and devoting himself to silence and contemplation. Jeong vividly remembered the voice he had heard at Willi's home in Montafon.

"It is a shameful story. By the time I was forty, I had, honorably, received nearly every major award available to a composer. I had fulfilled my dream as a composer. But as my name became known, I began to hear things that unsettled my heart, criticisms born of competition and envy. There were malicious rumors that Willi should no longer receive prizes, that my abilities were overrated, slanders that weighed on me. So I decided to withdraw. I discussed with my wife Marianne the idea of leaving Montafon and retreating to an unfamiliar place. Marianne was a schoolteacher, and she took a leave of absence and chose to follow me. We decided to disappear to Tuscany, Italy. The villa of an acquaintance stood in a truly secluded place, with the nearest house ten kilometers away. We lived in Tuscany for about a

year, and from that time on, for four years, I deliberately refrained from composing, spending each day in prayer to the Lord and in contemplation. I devoted myself to the Lord more completely than ever before."

At that moment, Jeong understood Willi's confession that he had "dedicated himself to the Lord" not as meaning "to become the Lord's servant," but rather as "to lay myself down before the Lord." Without laying down the self, one could never encounter absolute stillness. In Buddhist terms, only by laying down the self, that is, by becoming selfless, could one permeate all beings in the world and become the kind of self that lives as the whole. Author Jeong said this to Mrs. Park.

"Let's go to Tuscany, Italy. Let's go to the place where Mr. Willi dedicated himself to the Lord."

"Mr. Willi originally applied for a scholarship offered in Rome so he could go there, but when he didn't get it, he went to a friend's villa in Tuscany instead. So we could go to Rome first and then stay in Tuscany, couldn't we?"

Author Jeong agreed. It came from the thought that he would never have another chance to go to Italy again. He made plans to spend about fifteen days in Italy and then fifteen days in Vienna, Austria.

Tuscan Villa

Author Jeong received an important manuscript by email from Chairwoman Kwon. It was a book length manuscript recording an interview in which Martin Skamletz, a former student who studied composition under Mr. Willi documented his teacher's "musical life." Skamletz was a lecturer in music theory and the director of the Institute for Interpretive Research at the Bern University of the Arts. The interview was presumably conducted in German, but Chairwoman Kwon graciously sent Jeong a Korean translation so he could read it.

While reviewing the Korean translation, Author Jeong discovered something new: Mr. Willi's interest in composition began around the time he met Ms. Marianne. Meanwhile, the manuscript laid out in detail Willi's reasons for going to Italy. The narrative was organized into childhood, boyhood, youth, and adulthood, and the adulthood section's year 1986 began like this:

"I got married that August. I had known Marianne for several years. I first met her at a dance held during the village festival in Schruns in the Montafon Valley. At the time, she was attending grammar school (Gymnasium) in Feldkirch, and I was studying in Innsbruck, aiming to become an orchestral musician. I saw her at the dance, approached her, and we danced together for an hour or two. We barely spoke. Then one day, I took her home, and we stayed together from then on. This was in the late 1970s. Until then, I had never even considered becoming a composer. At the time, Marianne knew much more about contemporary music than I did. She often went to concerts featuring contemporary music. Of course, there were days when she went with me to such concerts, too.

At some point, I began studying composition, and my wife became a teacher, teaching German and music at a secondary school. After we were married, as I spent several years building my career as a composer, she encouraged me, stood firmly by my side, and always understood me while I was composing or traveling for performances. In short, she was an excellent wife."

Meanwhile, in 1987, Willi was invited by Father Nathaniel to a concert held at the Abbey of St. Gerold. It was early May 1987. The conductor of the concert orchestra was Rudolf Baumgartner, whom Willi met again over dinner and spoke with at length. Baumgartner showed a quiet interest in Willi's compositions and asked about his musical plans. This interest reflected the fact that Willi was gradually gaining recognition as a composer.

In 1987, Willi's piece, together with a work by Beat Furrer, won first prize in a competition hosted by the Vienna Konzerthaus, judged and performed by the Arditti Quartet. The Arditti Quartet was a string quartet founded in 1974 under the leadership of the British violinist Irvine Arditti. Willi's piece was premiered by the Arditti Quartet, becoming one of the first steps that carried his music onto a larger stage. It marked the first performance of his work outside the state of Vorarlberg, and newspapers and broadcasters praised it as "a musical application of the laws of nature." It was also at this time that he met Alexander Pereira, then Secretary General of the Vienna Konzerthaus and later director of the Zurich Opera House.

It was only seven months after meeting Rudolf Baumgartner that he invited Willi to Zurich in early December 1987. Although Willi had received a scholarship from the Austrian government to go to Rome, he was looking for a quiet place in Italy instead of a large city. Rather than exposing his now-recognized music to praise and envy, he wished to live quietly in silence, as he had done in Montafon.

"We met in Zurich and had a long, in depth conversation. We spoke for hours about many interests, not only music. It was then that I also came to know his wife. She was a sculptor from a wealthy family and often spent time at Japanese Buddhist temples. Her mother was a woman who had studied medicine at a Swiss university.

The Baumgartners owned a villa in Tuscany, Italy, though they did not live there. Baumgartner suggested that instead of going to Rome, I stay at his villa and compose there. I had no reason to object. In early January 1988, I took several days with my wife, Marianne, and visited. After that, everything was decided quickly. Marianne decided to take a one year leave of absence and we moved to Tuscany in February 1988.

Mr. Willi thus decided to stay at Baumgartner's villa rather than go to Rome, judging that the broad plains of Tuscany, though geographically different from the mountainous Montafon, were quiet and appealing. Baumgartner, of course, had lent him the villa in anticipation of Willi's compositions, and he even came in April, staying for several days in order to see the works Willi had written.

Born in Zurich, Switzerland, in 1917, Rudolf Baumgartner was thirty nine years older than Willi, belonging to his father's generation. He was a

conductor and violinist who co-founded and long led the Lucerne Festival Strings, a chamber orchestra established in 1956 together with the Austrian violinist Wolfgang Schneiderhan. He also served as director of the Lucerne Conservatory and as artistic director of the Lucerne Festival from 1969 to 1980.

"Baumgartner looked over my work and evaluated it positively. As a result, I remained there throughout 1988. He also commissioned me to compose a piece for the Lucerne Festival Strings, and the outcome was my cello concerto.

In the end, I couldn't receive the Rome scholarship. I gave it up myself. I had resolved to secure complete silence within the time and space of rural Tuscany. As a child, I had been forced into silence in hospitals, but now I wanted to return voluntarily to absolute silence and listen for how music emerged within me. That was the criterion by which I would decide whether to become a freelance composer. Even while traveling, lecturing, rehearsing, and performing, my guiding principle was to withdraw for long periods into complete silence in order to compose. Those around me did not understand my wish to live as a freelance composer. But I have come to know, then and now, that this was my path. I have never regretted or doubted my decision. Doctors said I would die, but I did not. What then should I fear?"

Rudolf Baumgartner's villa in Tuscany was located in a secluded rural area roughly halfway between Florence and Siena.

The nearest town where one could shop and receive mail, was some eight kilometers away, making it a truly remote location. Yet the villa itself was extraordinary. In the main building were a music room with a large table, a fireplace, and a harpsichord, the keyboard instrument regarded as the forerunner of the piano, as well as a vast reading room with a great hall housing an extensive record collection. Before the villa's garden stretched large vineyards, Etruscan tombs, and an old chapel built in harmonious proportions, into which the noon sunlight of the spring equinox streams through a round window. At the villa, I could listen to music in exactly the atmosphere I desired, and I found not only the inner and outer peace necessary for composition, but also the ability to immerse myself in a spiritual world rich with inspiration.

"On the first night, I could not sleep because the sound of the nightingales was so loud. It felt as though hundreds of them were singing."

It was the sound of hundreds of nightingales singing as they moved across the Tuscan hills. The barren hills and vast forests surrounding the villa were their natural habitat.

"While staying at the villa, I took long walks for several months. I encountered many hedgehogs, wild boars, and snakes. The forest was dense,

and the mountain paths were difficult to find. Rotting fallen oak trees and ravines often brought my steps to a halt. The landscape, seemingly untouched by human hands, felt like 'primordial nature.' From the moment I encountered this absolute silence of nature, I began to discover an inner absolute silence. I came to uncover the primal nature within me, long confined by education and religion, and to find my original self."

However, Willi did not remain solely within this primal nature. Whenever the urge arose to step away from it, he went to Siena rather than Florence.

"I loved Siena's Piazza del Campo. I even joined the crowds at the Palio, one of the most thrilling horse races in the world, held in the Campo at the heart of the old city."

The Palio horse race held in Siena's Piazza del Campo took place twice each year. A four day festival was held on July 2 and August 16, with the horse race itself occurring on the final day.

Meeting Abbado and Messiaen

While staying in Tuscany, Willi suddenly felt an urge to go to Vienna. He neither knew the reason nor could he explain it. After being gripped by the feeling for several days, he finally boarded a train from Tuscany to Vienna. Unable to go without any purpose, he made a phone call and arranged to meet a member of the organizing staff of the cultural arts festival Wiener Festwochen at Café Sperl at 11 a.m.

However, that person did not keep the appointment. After waiting for about 30 minutes at the café, Willi called the office and was told, with apologies, that the meeting could not take place because of another urgent matter. Willi was not particularly disappointed, as it had been a hastily arranged appointment. The train back to Tuscany was at 5 p.m.

Willi left the café and walked through the streets of Vienna. In front of the State Opera, he stopped just as he was about to head toward Kärntner Straße, in the direction of St. Stephen's Cathedral. A group of people was approaching the opera house, and among them Willi recognized Claudio Abbado, the opera house's music director. When the group entered the building, Willi naturally followed. It was an occasion at which Abbado was announcing the first Vienna Modern Festival, to be held in the fall of 1988.

Abbado sat in the front row with a few others, while Willi blended into the group of reporters facing him. Having come this far, Willi wanted to meet Abbado and waited until the press conference ended. Abbado was a world-renowned conductor, born in Milan, Italy, in 1933. Willi approached him as soon as the press conference was over, but Abbado was surrounded by people, and he had to wait for quite some time. Willi even considered giving up and leaving, but he sat down on a chair in the hall and patiently waited until everyone had gone.

When only the two of them remained, Willi approached Abbado. An awkward silence lingered for a moment. Abbado spoke first.

"Do you work at the opera house?"

"I just happened to be here."

Willi did not say that he was a composer. He had not released many works, and his compositions were rarely performed, so he felt embarrassed to call himself a composer. Then Abbado spoke again.

"You seem to have come to see me. Tell me."

Willi explained why he had come to Vienna.

"I brought the score to show a member of the Wiener Festwochen staff, but he said he had another appointment, so I was unable to pass it on."

"Really? Can you show it to me?"

"Of course."

Willi took the score out of his bag, handed it to Abbado, and said goodbye. He then caught the 5 p.m. train back to Tuscany.

A short time later.

Willi encountered another stroke of luck. He drove to Florence to watch the live broadcast of the football match between the Soviet and Italian teams. It was a semifinal match scheduled for the afternoon of June 22nd at the stadium in Stuttgart, Germany. Willi wanted to watch the semifinal, so he parked his car on the edge of Florence's old town and walked into the city center. He immediately entered a bar that was showing the match, but one of the patrons had brought a trumpet and started cheering for the Italian team, making it too noisy to watch calmly. Not only that, since Italy lost 0-2, Willi wasn't in the mood for drinking. He left the bar to return to his Tuscan villa.

And then, in front of the old Teatro Comunale, Willi spotted a large poster advertising a concert celebrating the 80th birthday of the veteran French composer Olivier Messiaen. Messiaen was someone Willi wanted to meet as much as Abbado. Moments later, something unbelievable happened. Messiaen was walking towards the theater. Willi hurried over and greeted him.

"My name is Herbert Willi and I study composition. I've been wanting to meet you."

Willi couldn't speak French well, so he couldn't have a long conversation. But he managed to say he wanted to show him his work.

"Would you please take a look at my work?"

Messiaen saw the earnest look on Willi's face and nodded. In any case, Willi had persuaded him.

The next day, Willi returned to Florence with his scores and recorded music, first meeting Messiaen's wife, Yvonne Loriod, at the Teatro Comunale. After she went to see Messiaen, she said,

"My husband is busy and only has five minutes. Please understand."

But after looking at Willi's scores, Messiaen showed no sign of getting up even after five minutes had passed. Two hours flew by. Willi was astonished by Messiaen's serious attitude. In particular, Messiaen scrutinized

every single note of the piece Willi had composed for solo flute, then closed his eyes gently. It seemed he was appreciating the music in his head.

"I have a recording. I'll play it for you."

"That won't be necessary."

Messiaen declined because he felt that the source of Willi's music was similar to his own. He thought it would be a waste of time to listen to the recording as well. As an ornithologist, he incorporated birdsong, that is, the sounds of nature, into his compositions. Like Willi, he combined natural sounds with a sense of color and was thus also known as a composer of color. On the spot, he asked Willi to compose an orchestral work. Afterward, they shared a warm and intimate conversation, during which he also pointed out the darker side of the music world and offered Willi advice.

Such was the kind of advice he gave: that the music world is riddled with factions, schools, and conspiracies; that there may be times when one's music does not align with the prevailing trends; and that even then, one must not change one's style to follow the times, but compose only what one hears from within. For Willi, this advice could not have been anything other than a confirmation and affirmation of his own musical world.

From then on, Messiaen and Willi bonded musically like a long-acquainted master and student. Messiaen connected Willi with Pierre Boulez and other French musicians, and the two exchanged letters.

That autumn.

Willi received a call from Abbado, asking to meet at the State Opera at 1:00 p.m. on December 2. Willi took an early-morning train up to Vienna; it was not long after the First Vienna Modern Festival had ended. Abbado had summoned Willi in order to commission a work to be performed at the next festival. Having reviewed, from time to time, the scores Willi had previously left with him, he felt sufficiently confident to proceed with the commission.

"Work out the concept by Christmas, and try to finish it by early in the new year."

"Thank you."

Yet for Willi, this was a work he would have to complete under tremendous time pressure. He immediately loaded his materials into the car and, as if taking refuge, withdrew to a rented house in Hittisau, a village in the Bregenzerwald north of Montafon. It was a bitter winter, with snow pouring down. He also spent two weeks working at a recording studio in Lützelflüh, in Switzerland's Emmental. As a result of these efforts, 1989 became a year of dramatic professional advancement and growing recognition for Willi as a composer. His works were performed or premiered by the Vienna Boys' Choir, the ORF Symphony Orchestra of the Austrian Broadcasting Corporation, the Vienna Konzerthaus, and the Vienna

Symphony Orchestra, among others. For Willi, 1989 was a happy year. It was also a major stroke of good fortune that he received the Austrian State Scholarship for Composers for the first time, allowing him to live without financial concern.

This good fortune could be said to have come from his encounters with Abbado and Messiaen. Of course, it would not have been possible had Willi not first reached out to them while staying in Tuscany.

Roman Vacation Begins

May 8, 2018.

Raindrops brushed against the airplane window. Rome seemed drenched in rain. In the distance, I could see the terminal of Rome's Fiumicino Airport. Officially known as the Leonardo da Vinci Airport, I envied the Romans for giving their airports historical names. Venice had its own Marco Polo Airport.

As the plane landed at the terminal, the tightly shut doors opened. Only then did it feel real that they had arrived in Rome. For Jeong and his wife, the four nights and five days of their month-long European tour in Rome finally felt like they were beginning. Author Jeong was thrilled by the prospect of seeing the Colosseum, a culmination of Rome's history and culture; the Catacombs, an underground burial complex, and the Basilica di St. Paul, which would prompt them to reflect on the meaning of faith; the Goethe Museum, where Goethe is said to have stayed; and the Vatican Museum, where they could compare and appreciate the sacred paintings of da Vinci and Raphael.

The immigration hall was bustling. Hundreds of people were waiting in line. Perhaps because it was past the 5 p.m. workday, most counters had "NO BUSINESS" signs posted. Only four or five counters were open. The line of tourists showed no signs of slowing down. The immigration officer, whether he knew it or not, remained unhurried and indifferent, despite the fact that 50,000 people once entered the Colosseum within 30 minutes. While chatting with his colleagues, he stamped the passport of author Jeong with a loud bang.

At the baggage claim, bags and luggage were already out, waiting for their owners. Unfortunately, Author Jeong's suitcase was missing a wheel. He had no idea how to complain to the airline, and it was already nearing 9 p.m. As he dragged his wobbly suitcase to the taxi stand, rain poured down in sheets. The taxi stand, too, had a long line of passengers. The harsh rain quietly dampened the spirits of Author Jeong, who had come dreaming of a

trip to Rome. Still, Author Jeong hoisted his now crippled suitcase into the taxi trunk and shouted,

“Del Corso Hotel!”

Although they had booked a hotel in central Rome online, a lingering unease crept over them. The taxi picked up Jeong and his wife almost as if it were abducting them, then tore through the rain. The downpour was so heavy the wipers could barely keep up, and the taxi even had to stop mid ride. What made Author Jeong still more uneasy was the driver. He kept searching the destination on his phone more than ten times, repeatedly turning left and right.

Only after they reached the hotel did Author Jeong regain his composure. The lodging they had reserved was not in the building with the front desk but in a separate wing. Perhaps because an old building had been renovated, the heavy doors let out a racket every time they opened. Their room was 503 on the first floor. It was odd to run into that familiar yet uncomfortable number. 503 was the inmate number of a former Korean president.

“The room number just happens to be the former president’s inmate number.”

“Oh my, how can that be!”

Sitting on the sofa, Author Jeong pulled the travel guidebook Italy, which he had bought at the Incheon Airport bookstore, from his backpack and opened it to the Rome section. He was trying to decide where to go the next day. Like Mrs. Park, he found himself drawn toward the Colosseum, the amphitheater that lets you take in Rome’s history and culture at a glance. He had often heard that a trip to Rome starts with the Colosseum.

The next morning.

Had Goethe said that the Roman sun makes even the dust shine? Rome looked completely different from yesterday. Even in the early morning, tourists were already strolling about in small groups. When they asked the front desk, a taxi arrived at once. The driver, too, was nothing like yesterday: he drove mostly straight, pointed toward the Colosseum with his finger, and kindly told them to pay whatever the meter showed.

Author Jeong and his wife read the introduction first. The Colosseum, built on the site where Emperor Nero had planned an artificial lake, was begun by Emperor Vespasian in AD 72 and completed during the reign of his son, Emperor Titus. It was truly remarkable. The oval open air arena measures 187 meters along its long axis, 155 meters along its short axis, and stands 48 meters tall.

“Honey, the explanation of the column styles is interesting.”

“Yes, we saw it in Athens, Greece.”

The phrase in the guide caught their eye: “The stone columns are in the Greek style, Doric on the first floor, Ionic on the second, and the most ornate Corinthian on the third.” Knowing the column styles made them even more eager. Author Jeong and his wife had gone on a study trip to Greece three years earlier and had come back with a firm grasp of the orders. They also noticed the note that the interior seating was tiered and could hold 50,000, and up to 80,000, spectators, and that there were 75 entrances so visitors could enter and leave quickly. The fact that the entrances were marked on tickets made of wooden tablets and clay struck them as something worth learning from even today.

The Colosseum was supposedly built so that emperors could soothe the Romans’ political and economic discontent by offering free spectacles, plays, circuses, and the horrific combat of gladiators. But was that really so? A politics of stupefying the people, of numbing reason, seemed to have continued even into the modern age of imperialism. Had he seen it in the film *Gladiator*? The image came to mind of foolish crowds roaring with delight at the brutal sight of gladiators fighting for their lives. Seeing the place with his own eyes, he felt as though every line in the guidebook must be true. The Colosseum was a colossal amphitheater, too vast to capture in a single shot. He climbed the hill facing its front and tried to press the shutter, but it was no use. He found himself recalling the poem of praise that the satirical poet Martial wrote after attending the Colosseum’s dedication ceremony.

O Egyptians, do not boast of the pyramids.

O Assyrians, do not let Babylon pass your lips.

Before the Emperor's new amphitheater,
there is no place for them to stand.

All fame is for this alone—

All shall be overshadowed by it.

It did not sound merely like a piece of flattery that Martial offered to Emperor Titus. Faced with an amphitheater of such colossal scale, any poet would have been unable to hold back his admiration, and Author Jeong felt the same. More astonishing still was the claim that they supplied water and filled the arena, then staged mock naval battles. Since Rome was stronger on land than at sea, perhaps those sham sea battles featured charges and close quarters combat. And Author Jeong was speechless as he read the notice explaining that the first tier, with the best view, was reserved for nobles, the second for Roman citizens, and the third for those admitted free, that is, slaves, women, and foreigners without citizenship, and that there was even a massive awning to block the sun. Titus, it said, had dismantled the tyrant Nero’s “Golden Palace” and used its materials, and had financed the

Colosseum with treasures plundered from Jerusalem, winning the Roman people's wholehearted support, a ruler who seemed to possess exceptional political instincts.

After lunch, Author Jeong and his wife decided to head to Piazza Venezia, where the dictator Mussolini had declared Italy's entry into World War II. They said there was a building modeled on the Doge's Palace, once the residence of the Venetian Republic's doge. But what Author Jeong most wanted to see was the area around the Piazza del Campidoglio, above the monument to Vittorio Emanuele II, the first king of a unified Italy. Most of Rome's major sites were within a thirty minute walk, so there was no need for a taxi or tram. The sidewalk up the sloping road to the right of the Vittorio Emanuele II monument led to the Piazza del Campidoglio. Yet the monument itself, a white building, drew constant complaints from Romans for clashing with the surrounding time worn ruins, and Author Jeong agreed it looked out of place. Beside it, too, a five story apartment building from the Roman period lay below the present ground level, as if an earthquake had made it sink straight down. The staircase up to the square, however, was striking. Designed, they said, by Michelangelo, it lengthened the upper flight so that the square would appear closer, taking optical illusion into account. Because perspective makes the upper steps look smaller than the lower ones and thus feel psychologically farther away, he had designed the stairs by reversing that effect, prompting an involuntary thought: "A genius really is different." The Capitoline Museums were easy to find, right next to the Piazza del Campidoglio. After using the restroom at the museum, the couple went straight down behind the building, hoping to see the Roman Forum for free.

Foro meant a public square, and it seemed likely to be the origin of the English word "forum." In ancient Rome, the Forum Romanum had been the center of civic life, but it was said to have declined after political activity shifted to the emperor's palace. Buildings stood along a cut hillside, and it looked as though medieval structures had been added onto ancient ones. A distinctive feature was that the windows grew progressively larger as the periods advanced. Across from that building stood the Arch of Septimius Severus, who became emperor in AD 193 after being acclaimed by his soldiers. A triumphal arch was a monument that Roman citizens and senators erected when a general returned from war victorious. Seeing the ruins of the Temple of Caesar brought to mind the full text of the letter Caesar sent to the Roman Senate in 47 BC after defeating King Pharnaces of Pontus.

'I came. I saw. I conquered.'

Perhaps those three phrases suddenly came to mind because they seemed to speak for Author Jeong's feelings after making his way to Rome through truly bitter and exhausting days. Thus the second day of Author Jeong and his wife's four night, five day stay in Rome came to an end.

Goethe's Italian Journey

The Goethe Museum was very close to the hotel where Author Jeong and his wife were staying. It took only about a 15-minute walk. The Goethe Museum was the place where Goethe had stayed during his travels in Rome. As Author Jeong headed toward the museum, a thought suddenly crossed his mind.

“Why did Goethe abandon his fame and comfortable life in Germany and come to Rome? What was Goethe hoping to see in Italy?”

At the left end of the Corso Street in front of the hotel where Author Jeong was staying lay the Roman Forum, and at the right end was Piazza del Popolo. Piazza del Popolo, meaning “People’s Square,” located between the Pincian Hill and the Tiber River, was designed in 1820 by the architect Giuseppe Valadier. At the center of the square rose a 36-meter-high obelisk, a 3rd-century BCE artifact brought from Egypt. The Porta del Popolo had been the northern gate through which people entered Rome from Europe since ancient times. It was said that foreigners had to pass through the Porta del Popolo, so Goethe must have gone through that gateway as well.

The Goethe Museum was not yet open. So Author Jeong and his wife had no choice but to walk over to Piazza del Popolo to pass the time. On the wall of one building in the square hung a Samsung mobile phone billboard, as if flaunting our national power. On one side of the square there was also the Leonardo da Vinci Museum. A street musician, from early morning, strummed a guitar and sang the familiar Beatles song “Yesterday.” Author Jeong and his wife wandered around the square until 10 a.m., when the Goethe Museum would open. At the southern entrance of the Corso Street stood the so-called “Twin Churches,” Santa Maria dei Miracoli and Santa Maria di Montesanto. Built in the 17th century, they were places where Martin Luther celebrated his first Mass and where Galileo was once imprisoned. Now they serve as the French Embassy. Once again, thinking of Goethe, Author Jeong sank into contemplation. He recalled a page from a world literature encyclopedia he had read back home.

Johann Wolfgang von Goethe was born in Frankfurt, Germany, on August 28, 1749. As a child, Goethe composed poems at the age of eight and published his first collection of poetry at thirteen, earning him the reputation of a prodigy. Though not of noble birth, he grew up in a wealthy family, naturally exposed to literature, painting, and music. His father often told the sensitive young Goethe stories of travel and the sculptures, maps, and museum specimens brought back from Italy stimulated the boy's curiosity. Italy naturally took shape as Goethe's ideal land.

At university, under his father's insistence, Goethe studied law and then returned to his hometown to work as a lawyer. But his true interest was always literature, not law. In fact, while socializing with various writers, Goethe began to practice writing poetry and plays. In 1772, after leaving Frankfurt to work in Wetzlar, Goethe fell into an unrequited love. The woman was Charlotte Buff, the fiancée of his friend Johann Christian Kestner. After returning home, Goethe was devastated to hear that his friend Karl Wilhelm Jerusalem, who had been in a situation similar to his own, had committed suicide.

Based on this tragic news about his friend and his own experiences, Goethe wrote the novel *The Sorrows of Young Werther* in 1774. In his mid-twenties, Goethe became Germany's leading writer overnight with a single work. The bestseller *The Sorrows of Young Werther* shook Europe. The yellow waistcoat and blue coat worn by the protagonist Werther even became fashionable among young people. In some countries, young men ended their lives with pistols, just like Werther.

Perhaps burdened by the praise pouring in, Goethe left Frankfurt in 1775 and headed to Weimar, which became his second hometown. Karl August, the new ruler of the small duchy with a population of 6,000, trusted Goethe as an avid reader and entrusted him with state affairs. Goethe was appointed a privy councillor and given the rights to operate silver and copper mines. Yet Goethe dreamed not of comfort but of escape. This was due to the thirst for art that surged within him. Beyond comfort always loomed the shadow of anxiety and dissatisfaction.

Goethe called this condition of mind and body a severe illness. He often complained, "I have wings, but I cannot use them." Neither his relationship with his intellectual lover Charlotte von Stein nor his association with contemporary intellectuals such as Herder could wash away his anguish. Finally, after ten years of life in Weimar, Goethe decided to flee. The place he chose was Italy, the ideal land of his childhood. In his diary dated September 3, 1786, Goethe confessed the following:

"At three in the morning, I secretly slipped out of Karlsbad. Had I not done so, people would have prevented me from leaving. Those friends who

sincerely wished to celebrate my birthday on August 28 had every reason to dissuade me. But I could no longer remain there. Packing only a travel bag and a badger-skin knapsack, I boarded the mail coach alone and reached Zwota at 7:30 in the morning. It was a beautiful and quiet morning filled with mist.”

Goethe referred to his Italian journey as a “secret journey” or an “underground journey,” because he left without telling anyone and concealed his identity. Carrying out this secret journey, Goethe toured Italy’s major landmarks, left Venice, and finally arrived in Rome. That day—the day he arrived at the very Goethe Museum that Author Jeong and his wife were now entering—was November 1, 1786. Goethe recorded the emotion of that day in his diary:

“(Omitted) For the past several years, I have felt as though I were ill. The only way to cure it was to come here, to see it with my own eyes, and to place my body upon this land. (Omitted)”

Wouldn’t anyone sympathize with Goethe’s words? For Goethe, travel was a process of healing himself. At the counter on the museum’s second floor, they received their admission tickets; visitors aged 65 and over were given a discount. It was only a few euros, but still a stroke of luck.

The museum was not large. It was small enough to see all the rooms in about 20 minutes. There was a room displaying Goethe’s books, a room with his portraits, and rooms exhibiting his botanical sketches and notebooks in which he meticulously recorded travel expenses. Yet Author Jeong found himself unable to leave for quite some time while gazing at Goethe’s portrait titled *Goethe in the Campagna*, painted by Johann Heinrich Wilhelm Tischbein. It was as if he had been seized by Goethe, suddenly come alive from within the painting. Though it was a copy of the portrait housed at the Städel Museum in Germany, to Author Jeong’s eyes it was impossible to distinguish the original from the reproduction. It was the portrait Goethe himself had liked best among all those made of him. Draped in a white cloak, Goethe gazes at the ruins scattered across the Campagna plain south of Rome. On Goethe’s face rested the happiness bestowed by his Italian journey. In a letter dated August 11, 1787, sent from Rome, Goethe wrote:

“There is not a single day that passes without acquiring or training my knowledge of art. Just as water easily fills a bottle cap dipped into it, a person rich in sensitivity and prepared in spirit can savor inner fulfillment in Rome.”

After leaving the Goethe Museum, Author Jeong and his wife decided to go to the Campagna plain, the background of Goethe’s portrait, and called a taxi. The driver explained that the Campagna had aqueducts, bridge-like water channels. Come to think of it, Author Jeong recalled seeing aqueduct

ruins somewhere near the middle right edge of Goethe's portrait. He remembered learning in history class that bridge-type aqueducts, which used the gradient of terrain to convey water, had been developed since ancient Roman times. Without advanced civil engineering and architecture, and without humanity's tenacious challenge, such structures would have been impossible. Goethe, too, must have been deeply impressed by the aqueducts built to supply water from distant sources to Roman citizens' fountains, public baths, and the villas of nobles and the wealthy. The representative Aqueduct of Claudius was begun in 38 CE by Emperor Caligula and completed only in 52 CE by Claudius, the fourth emperor of the Roman Empire. Through it and ten other channels, about 300 million gallons of clean water were supplied daily to the city of Rome. The aqueduct ruins before Author Jeong and his wife stretched an astonishing 90 kilometers from the source. Author Jeong recalled a line from *Faust*, which Goethe conceived and began writing at the age of 23 and completed more than 60 years later, just months before his death: "Awe is the finest emotion that humanity possesses."

Author Jeong wondered whether it had been misfortune that Mr. Willi had not met Goethe in Rome. Had he met Goethe, he might have gained no small amount of inspiration as a composer.

Vatican Museum

Author Jeong and his wife set out for an early morning walk. They chose a route that took them up Pincian Hill, past the palazzo of the Medici family, made wealthy long ago through banking, and down to the Spanish Steps. These Steps are well known as the spot where Audrey Hepburn was eating gelato and giving her memorable performance in *Roman Holiday*. The steps were already crowded with tourists. They were not there simply out of longing for Hepburn's beauty. Frankly, because it was an old film, Jeong's sense of her beauty was only faint. More than her beauty on screen, what he remembered was the testament she told her son on Christmas Eve, one year before she died. She seemed like a poet and a philosopher.

"If you want beautiful lips, speak kind words. If you want lovely eyes, look for the good in people. If you want a slim figure, share your food with the hungry. If you want beautiful hair, let a child run their fingers through it once a day. (Omission) As I grow older, I will come to see that I have two hands: one to help myself and one to help others."

The last line sounded like the Buddhist principle of *jari ita* 自利利他, "self-benefit by benefiting others," the wise language of a cleric. Her son, Sean Hepburn Ferrer, once stopped by Paengmok Port in Jindo, South Korea, to comfort the families of the Sewol ferry victims. Jeong could not help thinking, "like mother, like son." He sat down on the stairs for a moment and then stood up to visit Antico Caffè Greco located at the entrance of the street extending from the center of the square. "Antico" means "ancient Greek." A Greek owner opened Caffè Greco in 1760, and because it is recognized as the oldest café in Rome, it has been designated an Italian cultural asset. Jeong wanted to make sure to drop by.

The moment the doors opened at nine, Author Jeong and his wife became the first customers at Caffè Greco. The hall was not large, but every red velvet wall was densely hung with paintings, so it felt like stepping into a gallery. The café is said to own more than three hundred works and the staff were all in tailcoats. While they waited for a server, the couple looked at the paintings. Most were landscapes depicting scenes in the dim light of

twilight. Many were by Impressionist painters and all were originals. A cappuccino cost nine euros, so with a one-euro tip, it came to about 13,000 won. Hardly cheap, but thinking of it as a visit to an art gallery made the expense feel less burdensome.

Goethe began his day here, drinking mocha at Caffè Greco. As it turns out, after Goethe, Caffè Greco became a kind of salon for German artists and notable figures. Among the familiar names were the composers Mendelssohn, Liszt, and Wagner; the philosophers Schopenhauer and Nietzsche; and the novelist Thomas Mann. Wilhelm Müller, who wrote the texts for Schubert's *Winterreise*, was also a regular. And it was not only Germans. Artists from many Western countries came as well. Denmark's fairy tale writer Andersen and the British poets Byron, Keats, and Shelley were well known visitors. It was astonishing to learn that the Russian novelist Gogol also completed the final part of *Dead Souls* here at Caffè Greco. The French poets Baudelaire and Apollinaire; the novelists Stendhal and Marcel Proust; the American writer Benjamin Franklin; the novelists Mark Twain and Nathaniel Hawthorne; and the Irish writer Oscar Wilde, among many others, were all among those who were said to have stopped in here often.

Author Jeong recalled his high school days, standing on the bridge near his home in Pangnim-dong, picturing the Gwangju Stream as France's Seine, and memorizing Apollinaire's *The Mirabeau Bridge*. As he drank his cappuccino, he recalled his adolescent days, when he would murmur, "Under the Mirabeau Bridge flows the Seine, and so does our love. Must I remember? That joy always comes after sorrow." It was the romanticism of adolescence, taking the trickling waters of the Gwangju Stream for Paris' Seine.

Their next stops were the Trevi Fountain, a ten-minute walk away, and then the Pantheon, another seven minutes beyond. The Trevi Fountain is a monumental work that carries on the Roman tradition of public fountains. In ancient Rome, fountains in the piazzas supplied citizens with drinking water, but now they exist for tourists. Designed by the architect Niccolò Salvi and completed in 1762, the Trevi Fountain is carved with two figures and horses from Greek mythology. At the center stands a prominent statue of Poseidon, the god of the sea. The water looks emerald because of the limestone on the bottom. Because it draws such crowds, unpleasant incidents sometimes occur. Police patrolled around the basin in pairs. Violations of public decorum, such as putting your feet in the water, can be fined up to 240 euros, so the couple needed to be careful.

From the Trevi Fountain they quickened their pace to Piazza della Rotonda, because the Pantheon stands in that square with its obelisk.

"Pantheon" means "all gods." Since it is a temple dedicated to every deity, its Korean rendering would be *mansinjeon*. Hearing that Raphael, who loved the Pantheon, is buried inside, Jeong wanted to see his tomb for himself. The Pantheon is regarded as one of the greatest achievements of Roman architectural engineering, especially its magnificent rotunda and dome. Mrs. Park said:

"They say they're switching to paid admission, but for now it still seems to be free."

"Maybe that's why the tourist crowds never seem to end."

Tourists flowed in and out between the Corinthian granite columns at the entrance. Swept along by the crowd, they entered the rotunda, whose floor was glossy marble. Sunlight poured in through the oculus, a nine-meter-wide opening at the top of the dome, brightening the interior. This is the oculus that Raphael is said to have visited mostly at night to admire the moonlight passing through. The height up to the crown of the dome and the diameter of the rotunda floor are exactly 43.3 meters. This is the feature that makes architects marvel, and Jeong and his wife, too, could only be amazed by the columnless rotunda and dome. Along the lower walls of the rotunda ran the tombs of two Italian kings and of Renaissance painters and architects. Raphael's tomb was easy to spot beneath the sculptures of two birds. Jeong noted to Mrs. Park that now only a single burial space remains in the rotunda.

"There was once a poll asking who ought to be placed in that space, and surprisingly it turned out to be a current soccer player."

"That tells you how much Italians love soccer."

As Jeong hesitated over taking a taxi, he and Mrs. Park agreed to walk to the Vatican Museums. He wanted to stroll along the Tiber. The sky was overcast and a light breeze was blowing, so it was not hot. He had heard that to see the Vatican Museums properly, you would have to come in every day for a week, almost like commuting to work. So Jeong decided to look closely only at Michelangelo's *Creation* and *The Last Judgment*, and at Raphael's *School of Athens* in the Raphael Rooms, saving the rest of the artworks and sculptures for another time. Because he had reserved their tickets online, there was no need to stand in line. Had his judgment been right? Above the arched entrance, reliefs of Michelangelo and Raphael were carved. It seemed to suggest that, among the countless painters, only those two were the true protagonists of the Vatican Museums.

Before going on to the Raphael Rooms, he could not help looking at the sculptures in the corridor known as the Chiaramonti Gallery. Suddenly one piece caught Jeong's eye: a goddess carved with two baby angels. Perhaps it was because his eldest daughter was pregnant with twins. There were statues

of Hercules, Zeus, Athena, Roman emperors, and so on, yet at that moment why did Jeong think of Korea's pensive Maitreya bodhisattva (Mireuk banga sayusang)? As he marveled anew at the insight of the German philosopher Karl Jaspers, recalling the praise he offered after seeing the *banga sayusang* carved by a Korean artisan at Kōryū-ji in Kyoto, Japan:

"I have seen the statues of the ancient Greek gods, and I have also seen superb sculptures made in the Roman era. Yet in all of them there still remained earthly, human traces that had not been fully transcended. But in the Maitreya pensive bodhisattva, the highest ideal of human existence, perfected in full, was expressed without remainder. (Omitted) I have lived for decades as a philosopher, but I have never before seen a work of art that so truthfully embodies human existence in a peaceful form."

Karl Jaspers's candid confession seemed to speak for Jeong's own thoughts. With little emotional response, Jeong took in the corridor sculptures and then went on to the Raphael Rooms, to meet fifty-four Athenian luminaries including Plato, Aristotle, Apollo, Socrates, Pythagoras, and Euclid in Raphael's *School of Athens*.

Gazing at Elba

The express train from Termini Station, said to have been a public bathhouse in Roman times, took two hours to reach Follonica, a small coastal town in Tuscany. The station plaza was quiet. The palm fronds, like peacock feathers, looked fresh and vibrant.

"Sweetheart, perhaps it's the feel of the word 'Tuscany,' but unlike Rome, this place feels warm and familiar."

"I feel the same. Did you see those endless wheat fields on the way? They reminded me of the countryside where we live."

"I also have the feeling that Mr. Willi guided us here."

The bungalow they had reserved at Golfo del Sole was about a fifteen-minute drive from the station. In Italian, golfo means "gulf" and sole means "sun," so it was a bungalow on the "Gulf of the Sun." The public parking lot behind the station was named "Tiananmen Victims Square." The "Tiananmen Incident" referred to the tragic event of June 4, 1989, when Chinese martial law troops deployed tanks to forcibly disperse students, workers, and citizens demonstrating for democracy in Tiananmen Square, firing upon them and causing many casualties. Because of the Italians' strong sense of human rights, Author Jeong felt himself growing even more familiar with Tuscany. Perhaps it was a sentiment shared only by the people of Gwangju, who had directly or indirectly experienced the noble fury of the May 18th Uprising.

After unpacking at the bungalow, Author Jeong and his wife walked up along the seaside promenade. When sweat began to bead on their foreheads, the path came to a dead end, and they spotted a medieval relic, a torre, meaning watchtower or tower. Next to the Torre Mozza Hotel, built adjoining the watchtower, stood a small café. Upon entering, they had a much better view of Elba Island, elongated like a sweet potato. It was the island where Napoleon had lived in exile. When they asked how to get there, the café manager explained that one could take a ferry from the port of Piombino to the north and disembark at Porto Ferraio on Elba, but warned that the ferry schedules had to align well to avoid wasting time.

Author Jeong's interest in Napoleon was not merely due to his dramatic rise from rags to riches. He was curious about the charm that had captivated the artists of his time. Beethoven, too, had been enchanted by Napoleon. This was when Napoleon's valor was shaking all of Europe. Beethoven heard stories of Napoleon from the French ambassador stationed in Vienna and his secretary, the violinist Rodolphe Kreutzer, and was so stirred that he could not contain himself. Having just been moved by Plato's *Republic*, Beethoven wished to praise Napoleon as the hero of the age. Thus he composed his *Symphony No. 3, the Eroica*. Yet the bond between Beethoven and Napoleon ended there. Just as Beethoven was about to send the score of his Third Symphony through the French Embassy, news spread through Vienna that Napoleon had crowned himself Emperor. Beethoven, who had hoped Napoleon would become a hero of the people, tore up the manuscript copy he had intended to send and cried out:

So he is no more than a common mortal! Now, too, he will tread under foot all the rights of man, indulge only his ambition; now he will think himself superior to all men, become a tyrant!"

In any case, it was not only Beethoven who helped make Napoleon a legend; novelists also played their part. Stendhal often made Bonapartists his protagonists. In his masterpiece *Le Rouge et le Noir* (The Red and the Black), he defended the Napoleonic era through his characters, who declared they would rather fight in a red military uniform than wear a hypocritical black cassock. Victor Hugo, whose father had been a general in Napoleon's army, also depicted the valor of Napoleon's forces in his novel *Les Misérables*.

Napoleon was born on the remote French island of Corsica. To escape poverty, he entered the military academy at Brienne at age ten and became an artillery officer at sixteen. Eight years later, his victory against the British at the Battle of Toulon earned him a special promotion to brigadier general, making him a hero of the French Revolutionary Army overnight. After suppressing forces opposing the National Convention with cannon fire, he was appointed commander of the Italian campaign. In his early thirties, he ascended to the throne as Emperor of France, conquering half of Europe with unstoppable momentum and establishing France's systems of education, religion, culture, and law. However, his reckless Russian campaign failed, and the ensuing aftermath of war led to a coup. Napoleon was exiled to the island of Elba, and Louis XVIII, a relative of Louis XVI, returned to Paris. But Louis XVIII acted like an absolute monarch in the manner of Louis XIV and lost popular support. The people longed for Napoleon, and dreaming of a comeback, Napoleon escaped from Elba and reappeared as a hero of the masses. Soon after, seeking to secure his political footing, Napoleon waged

a fateful battle at Waterloo against the allied forces led by British General Wellington and the Prussian General Blücher. But Napoleon was defeated in bitter futility, and his magnificent era came to an end. He was exiled once more, this time to the forsaken island of Saint Helena in the South Atlantic, where on the stormy dawn of May 5, 1821, at five o'clock, he closed his eyes forever.

Author Jeong suddenly recalled Napoleon's murmured words from his second place of exile on Saint Helena: "My life is like a novel! When I die, a wave of pity for me will surge." Napoleon's prophecy was being proven in the years after his death: over 600,000 novels, biographies, studies, essays, and papers have been written about him.

Gazing at Elba Island, Author Jeong and his wife ate gelato. They were coming to realize that Italy truly was a nation of food. The variety of wheat-based foods, breads, spaghetti, and other dishes, was remarkable, and after every meal, gelato was an essential dessert. It was a perfect match for Author Jeong's palate, as he loved noodles and sweets. After their meal, they set out for the old castle town of Massa Marittima, about forty minutes by car from Follonica. Both Follonica and Massa Marittima were small towns (*comuni*) in the province of Grosseto.

Massa Marittima, designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site, was about the size of a Korean township, yet it contained hotels, restaurants, a piazza, a cathedral, caf  s, clothing shops, and antique stores. All the alleys, paved with smooth stones and steps, led upward toward the fortress. When they entered an antique shop, the owner said that the Jeong couple were the first Koreans to visit. Since group tourists did not come here, it was only natural. The owner said:

"Besides here, there are many tranquil old castle towns throughout the Tuscany region."

"Even before the period when the Republics of Pisa, Siena, and Florence were vying with one another, people must have built fortresses on mountain peaks and formed villages there, since such locations were easier to defend against enemies."

After climbing up to the fortress and descending through the alleys, they reached the Piazza del Duomo, where the Cathedral of Massa Marittima stood tall. Said to have been constructed in the twelfth century, the cathedral was itself a museum. Upon entering, frescoes painted in the medieval period captured their attention right away. The fresco of Mary holding the infant Jesus was well preserved. A marble sarcophagus bearing the inscription "Gregorius" was intricately carved, and the description noted it had been made in 1324. On the street, they had seen a sculpture of a lamb bearing a cross on its back, and the same image was carved in relief on the cathedral's

marble wall, as if it were the emblem of the old castle town of Massa Marittima.

The most famous Catholic saint from Massa Marittima was said to be Bernardino, who was active in the fifteenth century. He entered the Franciscan Order in 1402 and worked as a preacher, devising the monogram "I.H.S." - the first three letters of Jesus's name in Greek rendered in Roman letters. He greatly influenced the reform of the Franciscan Order and earned the title "Doctor of the Assumption" for his studies on the Virgin Mary. It was easy to see why the local people took such pride in him.

When they returned to the piazza, retired elders were engaged in heated debate. One old man was delivering a passionate speech, apparently discussing Italian politics. It seemed that Italian elders, like Koreans, had a keen interest in politics. One of them gestured for Author Jeong to join the discussion. But Jeong declined and headed down below the old castle of Massa Marittima. He had once read an article about a peculiar fresco discovered in 2000 on the wall of a communal well. A net had been installed to protect it from bird droppings, and upon actually seeing it, the fresco was indeed quite explicit. Estimated to have been created around 1265, the mural featured a tree with abundant branches at its center, from which hung twenty-five phalluses and testicles. People called it the "Tree of Fertility." Author Jeong could not help but laugh at the thought of women coming to draw water from the well and praying for fertility upon seeing the male organs. Moreover, one woman in the fresco appeared to be reaching up with a stick as if to pluck a phallus. Such a depiction of phalluses and testicles hanging in clusters was unprecedented in medieval Western art. Since the fresco dated from a period of competition between the Holy Roman Empire and the Papacy, its precise intent and meaning remained a mystery to this day. However, in Author Jeong's view, it seemed more plausible to interpret the mural as a prayer for fertility and abundance rather than as a political statement.

Sculptor Giacometti and Composer Willi

Early in the morning, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park set off for Pisa. It was a two-hour journey by local train from Follonica. The seats were sparsely occupied and raindrops brushed across the windows. The train headed north toward the coast. The endless wheat fields of Tuscany kept appearing in the clouded windows. The train sped past station after station. Each time the station announcements came on, Italian struck them as beautiful. Like Chinese, its rising and falling tonal contours were unmistakable.

"Livorno Centrale!"

Centrale means "central," so it meant Livorno Central Station. Before long, an announcement came that the train would be arriving at Pisa Station.

"Doesn't Pisa seem like a bigger city than you'd expect?"

"So many elegant old buildings, too. They say it's the second largest city in Tuscany after Florence."

Emerging from the station building, a statue stood in the square. It was like one they'd seen in Rome of Italy's first king, Victor Emmanuel II. The weather was still overcast and chilly, a stark contrast to the warm weather in Rome or Follonica. A short walk up the narrow street led to a cluster of caf  s. These caf  s had become landmarks in their own right. The one Author Jeong and Mrs. Park entered was Caff   Salza, which had opened its doors in 1898. Like Rome's Antico Caff   Greco, the walls were adorned with famous paintings. The warm cappuccino tasted even better in the chill.

After about twenty minutes of leisurely walking uphill, the Leaning Tower came into view. Street vendors trailed after them, carrying souvenirs and urging them to buy. Most of them were black and appeared to be refugees. One of the reasons to feel warmly toward Italians was the attitude of the shopkeepers. They didn't chase away the vendors; rather, they treated them kindly, like neighbors. It seemed like something anyone could learn from. Virtue is nothing other than the spirit of giving and sharing with neighbors in need.

The Leaning Tower of Pisa. In Piazza del Duomo there are the Leaning Tower, the cathedral, and the round baptistery, but the Leaning Tower was

the first structure to catch tourists' eyes. It was a bell tower selected as one of the Seven Wonders of the World. In 1173, architect Bonanno Pisano began construction, but when it reached the third floor (10 meters high), the ground subsided and work was halted. This was because the soil near the sea was soft, sandy earth, and because the tower's underground foundation was only 3 meters deep. Construction resumed and was completed in 1350, but the 14,500-ton marble tower began to tilt by about 1 mm each year, and by 1990 it had become a bell tower leaning at a 5.5-degree angle.

Tourists who wanted to climb the Leaning Tower stood in line, waiting their turn to enter. Forty people were admitted every 15 minutes. When it was Author Jeong and Mrs. Park's turn, a female security guard scanned them with an electronic detector. The marble staircase was spiral. It was remarkable that despite four earthquakes since the late thirteenth century it had not collapsed. A scholar who studied the Leaning Tower once remarked:

"The tower leaned because of the soft ground, but the sandy soil absorbed the shock of the earthquakes, so the tower didn't collapse. Structures are most vulnerable to the vertical jolting of an earthquake."

Another reason the Leaning Tower became famous was probably because of Galileo Galilei, a native of Pisa. Galileo, an astronomer and physicist, had discovered a flaw in Aristotle's mechanics. Aristotle had argued that heavier objects hit the ground before lighter ones, but Galileo, through experiments from the Leaning Tower, proved that both heavy and light objects fell at the same rate, demonstrating that weight had nothing to do with the speed of fall. Later, Galileo advocated heliocentrism, leading to his trial in Rome. He was pardoned after promising to renounce his theory, but as he left the courtroom, he remarked, "And yet it moves. . . ." as he could not bring himself to betray his own conscience.

The marble steps were worn smooth from countless feet. It occurred to Author Jeong that if there's anything that becomes more beautiful the more it's stepped on, it's a staircase. Finally, upon reaching the eighth and final floor, bells hung overhead. Beyond the bells, a panoramic view of Pisa's cityscape spread out before them. Author Jeong speculated that the Leaning Tower likely served not only a religious function but also as a watchtower for spotting invading enemies.

Author Jeong and Mrs. Park were forced to descend the bell tower, swamped by tourists. While descending, Author Jeong thought of the phrase *seongju goegong* (成住壞空), the idea that all things arise, abide for a time, decay, and return to emptiness (空 *kong*).

"The Leaning Tower of Pisa, too, will surely come to that in the fullness of time."

Restoration work that began in 1990 was completed in June 2001, and they claim the tower no longer tilts, but wouldn't it be more humble, and more accurate, to say that human effort has merely postponed the moment of its return to emptiness?

The doors of Pisa Cathedral, built in the shape of a Latin cross, were made of bronze. Stepping through the massive bronze doors, they saw a mosaic *Christ Enthroned with the Virgin and Saint John* adorning the half-dome above the altar. This apse mosaic is associated with Cimabue, and the work is dated to 1302, often treated as his last. The Virgin Mary and Saint John the Apostle pray quietly on either side of Christ. To the left of the altar is a pulpit sculpted by the Renaissance master Giovanni Pisano, depicting key scenes from the Old and New Testaments, including the *Last Judgment*. Inside the elliptical dome is the *Assumption* (1627–1631), depicting the Virgin Mary seated on a cloud, escorted by angels, ascending to heaven with saints. The guidebook explains that this work was completed by the Pisan painter Orazio Riminaldi and his brother Girolamo using the encaustic technique, mixing pigments with beeswax. They likely chose this theme because the cathedral's original name was the Cathedral of the Assumption of the Virgin Mary. However, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park were unable to enter the round baptistery, which they had planned to visit last, as it was under renovation, and turned back.

After a spaghetti lunch at a street restaurant in Pisa, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park took the train back to Follonica Station and headed to the ancient hilltop town of Vetulonia. They wanted to see as many such towns as possible in Tuscany. Vetulonia was a fortified settlement in a region where the Etruscans, forerunners of the Romans, had built their civilization around 2500 BCE. Like the others, Vetulonia was located up a winding mountain road. Since it was Monday, the museum was closed. They had no choice but to walk up the slope to the Vetulonia citadel, which had something of the air of a museum itself. Perhaps out of regret, they recalled the Etruscan artifacts they had seen at the Vatican Museums, the Egyptian-looking figures with their large eyes, carved on marble sarcophagus lids, jars, and bowls, which had fascinated them. The souvenir shop was likewise locked. Through the shop window, among the Etruscan replicas, figures of people and animals — elongated bronzes reminiscent of Volterra's *Ombra della sera* — they could see imitations of Giacometti's slender sculptures. Author Jeong was unable to purchase a bluish bronze Giacometti reproduction and only took a photo. Alberto Giacometti (1901–1966), born in Switzerland and active in Paris, was famous as "the modern sculptor who made Picasso jealous," "Sartre's friend, the artist who embodied existentialist philosophy in sculpture," and "the artist who left behind the world's most expensive sculptures."

Giacometti was a sculptor with whom Author Jeong had a small karmic connection (*inyeon*). When Jeong was working at Saemt'ŏ Publishing, he had used a photo of Giacometti's *Walking Man* on the cover of Venerable Beopjeong's *Standing People*.

When Author Jeong asked their guide, Mr. Guster, he said that the nineteen-year-old Giacometti had been deeply inspired by Etruscan artifacts after witnessing the sudden death of a companion during a trip to Italy. A light went on in Author Jeong's mind.

"Mightn't Giacometti have been inspired by the Etruscan artifacts, especially the vivid, realistic eyes of the figures?"

Among Giacometti's wire-thin, elongated sculptures, aren't the eyes, where an intense gaze is felt, the most meaningful part? Giacometti himself asserted, "It is the gaze that distinguishes the living from the dead." Indeed, Giacometti reportedly began with the eyes, believing the gaze was paramount in his drawings and sculptures. Sartre, in his preface to the Giacometti exhibition catalog, explained, "It is the gaze that represents the human face, the part where human consciousness becomes visible," further solidifying Author Jeong's intuition. Author Jeong wanted to define Giacometti's sculptures as the aesthetic embodiment of emptiness. That his elongated figures were all pared thin as wire came, Author Jeong believed, from emptying and stripping away in order to approach the essence. At this point, Author Jeong felt that Giacometti, like Mr. Willi, resembled an Eastern Seon master. The soliloquy "I walk today. Tomorrow I will have no choice but to walk again" surely found its expression in *Walking Man*, enough to call to mind a wandering cloud-and-water monk (*unsuseong*, 雲水僧), forever on pilgrimage.

Like any other hilltop town, the church of Vetulonia stood in the center of the village. It was only after seeing the fifth- and sixth-century walls atop Vetulonia that Author Jeong finally broke free of the reverie Giacometti had evoked. The fifteenth-century *cappella* (prayer room) was impressive. Countless people, weary of hard lives, must have knelt before the statue of the Virgin Mary in prayer. Just then, a few flowers blooming along the walls were sending their fragrance into the air.

In Search of Dante's House

The train was passing through Pisa station. It was still an hour and a half to Florence. Florence was the city of fortune where Mr. Willi had met his musical mentor, Olivier Messiaen, at the Teatro Comunale. For Author Jeong, however, Florence called to mind two things before anything else: Dante, author of the *Divine Comedy*, and the Medici family, patrons of the Renaissance masters. The name Medici derived from *medico*, meaning "physician." Having first amassed their fortune in the pharmaceutical trade and then built great wealth through banking, the Medicis were a distinguished house that produced three popes and numerous rulers of Florence from the fourteenth to the seventeenth century. Lorenzo de' Medici, the godfather of Renaissance art, was without question the most extraordinary figure among them.

Until the first half of the thirteenth century, Florence had been a very small city compared to Milan or Rome. It was the economic prosperity of its merchants that launched the city's spectacular rise. After the Crusades, Florentine merchants of the fourteenth century imported wool from England and Belgium and exported fine woolen cloth. As a result, Florence grew wealthy, and its banking branches spread across all of Europe. Trade flourished to such a degree that the Florentine florin became a common currency throughout Europe, much like the euro today, and a banking system of free remittances and bills of exchange was firmly established. Florentine banking reached full bloom under Cosimo de' Medici in the fifteenth century. Political turmoil came to an end as well. Cosimo instructed the people of Florence to collect and create everything they could. This was the very spark that ignited Renaissance art. As Cosimo himself once said:

"I know well the temperament of Florence. If the day comes when we Medicis are driven out, it will not take even fifty years. But objects endure."

What Cosimo left behind was not merely buildings, paintings, sculptures, and ancient manuscripts. He gave his own villa to the humanist Ficino so that he could study the Greek and Roman classics, funded the reconstruction of the Basilica of San Lorenzo, and became the foremost

patron of Renaissance artists. It was also Cosimo who founded the Academia Platonica, making Florence the center of classical scholarship. Under Medici patronage, the University of Florence published the first printed edition of Homer.

In this way, Cosimo, as ruler of the republic, laid the foundations of Renaissance art. His grandson Lorenzo restored the monarchical system and wielded his political acumen to make the economy flourish further still; with that power, Renaissance art entered its golden age. Lorenzo is especially renowned for discovering and sponsoring the universal genius Leonardo da Vinci and the great Michelangelo. While Cosimo had founded the University of Pisa and cultivated leading scholars, Lorenzo's passion lay in the education of young talent. He built a school beside the Medici Palace, lent it his collection of ancient busts and paintings, and commissioned students to carve statues in the school garden. It was there that he happened upon a boy sculpting the head of an old faun. The boy was Michelangelo. Impressed by his skill, Lorenzo adopted him into the Medici household and allowed him to devote himself entirely to sculpture and painting. Leonardo da Vinci, born in the town of Vinci, likewise received Lorenzo's patronage. Working with remarkable skill at Verrocchio's workshop in Florence, the twelve-year-old Leonardo caught Lorenzo's eye. When Ludovico Sforza, Duke of Milan, sought a sculptor for an equestrian statue honoring his father, Lorenzo recommended Da Vinci, giving the young artist the opportunity that would introduce his genius to the world.

The moment they stepped off at Florence station, a few raindrops began to fall. They stopped at the Mercato near the station. Leather goods shops lined both sides of the alley. Since the rain threatened to grow heavier, they had no choice but to buy an umbrella. When they opened it, a photograph of a cathedral was printed across the canopy. Florence has twelve churches, and several among them had been built with Medici patronage. Nearly every landmark and treasure in Florence, it was clear, was connected to the Medicis in one way or another.

Umbrella in hand, the first place they visited was the Cathedral of Santa Maria del Fiore, Florence's most iconic landmark. Also known as the Florence Duomo, the complex comprises the Baptistery of San Giovanni and the bell tower, a work of Giotto. Arnolfo di Cambio (1245-1302) drew up the original plans in the late thirteenth century, and the cathedral was completed when Filippo Brunelleschi (1377-1446) raised the immense octagonal dome, making it the largest church in the world at the time. Giotto di Bondone (1267-1337) devoted his life to building the bell tower, and Andrea Pisano (1270-1348) labored on its completion until the Black Death

took him. The sheer devotion of these men left Author Jeong and his wife awestruck.

The cathedral's facade was a true Gothic spectacle, its pointed spires thrusting skyward as if carrying the prayers of the faithful up to heaven. The geometric inlays of black marble set into white seemed certain to move any pilgrim to wonder. Giotto's bell tower, compared to the Leaning Tower of Pisa, was less ornate and more restrained. If Korea's Dabotap was Pisa's tower in its elaborate beauty, then Giotto's bell tower was like the Seokgatap in its quiet dignity. Since even with tickets one would have to wait an hour or two, Author Jeong and his wife turned instead toward the Basilica of Santa Croce, where a statue of Dante stands before the entrance.

Santa Croce's nickname is "the church of genius tombs." It houses the sarcophagi of Dante, Michelangelo, Galileo, and Machiavelli, among others. But the Jeong couple's purpose in going there was solely to see Dante's statue; they had no other aim. As if on cue, the rain stopped and the sky was clearing to blue. What had Dante looked like in life? They were burning with curiosity. On the way, they paused at the Piazza della Signoria in front of the town hall, where they spent a long while admiring and photographing Michelangelo's masterpiece, the *David* (a replica). The model for the *David* was said to be Giuliano de' Medici, famed for his beauty and dead before his time. Art historians describe the figure as the young David, around twenty years old, facing Goliath. Whatever the case, the tense expression on the young man's face, the veins visible on the back of his hand, the innocent rendering of the male anatomy: the realism of it all inspired a sense of awe.

After a lunch of spaghetti, Author Jeong and his wife at last stood before Dante's statue. Four lions seemed to stand guard for him on the pedestal. A single eagle perched beside the hem of Dante's cloak, its sharp beak thrust upward. Dante's expression, with his aquiline nose, was unexpectedly cold. There was something critical and rational about it. It seemed to reveal the Florentine temperament. The people of Florence were known for their fierce independence and sharp critical spirit. And yet it was precisely this temperament that had driven the advancement of learning and art.

Before long, they unfolded a map and set out in search of Dante's House, his birthplace. After winding through several alleys, they found it. Visitors were surprisingly few. The unadorned brick building had the look of a fallen noble's home. Dante lost his mother at eight and his father, who had worked in lending and money-changing, at sixteen, leaving the boy to take on the role of head of household. Precocious as he was, Dante fell in love at first sight with Beatrice when he was just ten years old. Nine years later, he encountered Beatrice again by chance near the Ponte Vecchio, but by then both were married. From that day, Dante wrote love poems for Beatrice until

her sudden, untimely death, and he published them as *Vita Nuova* (1295). Five years later, Dante joined the Guild of Physicians and Apothecaries of Florence and distinguished himself with his eloquence. He became one of the three highest-ranking officials in the Florentine government. But it was from this point that Dante became entangled in political strife. While away in Rome, he was charged with bribery and various offenses, tried in absentia, and found guilty. He abandoned all hope of returning home and wandered in exile until the day he died. The *Divine Comedy*, Dante's greatest masterpiece, was written during this period. Composed of three canticles, *Inferno*, *Purgatorio*, and *Paradiso*, the work was all the more celebrated for being written not in Latin but in the Tuscan vernacular. The literary critic Harold Bloom once said of Dante's life: "The life of Dante Alighieri is like a rough, turbulent poem. 'Paradise' is beyond his reach, and he is closer to 'Hell' than to 'Purgatory.'" That assessment seemed exactly right.

Climbing to the fifth floor of Dante's House, they noticed Dante's bed and a bronze statue of him. The bronze had been donated on June 16, 2016, by the Russian sculptor Stepan Mokrousov to commemorate Dante's 750th anniversary. Then I was stopped short by three posters explaining the *Divine Comedy*. The original title was *La Comedia*! A passage from the *Inferno* that I had never understood in my school days suddenly made sense just from seeing the original title. In the fourth canto of the *Inferno*, Homer, Aristotle, Socrates, and others are consigned to Hell simply because they were born before Christ and never received baptism. The very idea of it was a *comedia*. From the fifth floor, Giotto's bell tower was visible. Dante's House had been right there the whole time; they had wandered for nothing.

At length, Author Jeong and his wife wished to savor the Renaissance treasures left behind by the Medici family at their leisure. The republican government building commissioned by Cosimo had become the Uffizi Gallery, and they longed to encounter the spirit of the Medicis, who had aspired to make their city a great power of culture. At the very least, the Uffizi did not display the plundered artifacts of weaker nations, as did the imperialist British Museum or the Louvre. They would also cross the Ponte Vecchio to visit the Pitti Palace. After all, it was said to house the works of Michelangelo, Da Vinci, and other geniuses of the age.

From Cinque Terre to Siena

Cinque Terre means "five villages." The settlements had been built like nests on steep hillsides by Christians who crossed the Mediterranean to escape religious persecution. Author Jeong and his wife decided to visit Manarola, the most beautiful of the five, and followed Mr. Guster out of their lodgings. Even in Italy, local trains showed their character just as they did in Korea. It was twenty minutes late. After feeding their tickets into a validation machine that looked like a vacuum cleaner, they boarded. The inside of the local train was noisy with chatter. Italians, it seemed, shared a temperament similar to that of Koreans. Still, the local train was reasonably fast.

Before long, the car fell quiet. The ponytailed young men in the seats ahead, their arms and necks covered in tattoos, had gotten off. The train passed through Forte dei Marmi, where Europe's largest marble quarry came into view. Marble had been quarried there since the Renaissance, so Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo must have used stone from this very place for their sculptures.

Author Jeong and his wife hurried off at La Spezia to transfer trains. A train bound for Cinque Terre was stopped at the station. Perhaps because Cinque Terre had been transformed into a tourist destination, travelers poured onto the connecting train. Mr. Guster explained kindly.

"If you get off at La Spezia station and walk, you come to the sea. There at the pier, passenger ferries run back and forth to Cinque Terre. Near the pier, there is also the 'Manzoni Walk.' Alessandro Manzoni was an Italian novelist whose work, *The Betrothed*, published in 1840, is regarded as comparable to Dante's *Divine Comedy*."

Since he had never read Manzoni's novel, Author Jeong kept quiet and simply listened. Mr. Guster went on to explain *The Betrothed*.

"He is a central figure in Italy's literary tradition, regarded as a master of Italian serious literature and the classics. *The Betrothed* is so famous that Italians often say everyone has read it. I read it myself at seventeen, but the world of the novel was so hard to grasp that it was difficult to become absorbed in it."

Mr. Guster added that as a teenager he had attended a Gymnasium in Switzerland, and that to graduate one had to read all the masterpieces of European literature. In other words, even though it was considered difficult for its time, he had read *The Betrothed* because he graduated from the Gymnasium. Manarola station was in the second of the five villages. The station stood on cliffs above the shore.

Author Jeong and his wife followed the kind Mr. Guster up the sloping path into the village. They wanted to see the church first. They felt that the sweat and tears of the residents who had turned these barren hillsides into terraced fields must have seeped into the church. Standing in the churchyard, they could take in the terraced fields and the sea in a single glance. The church was modest, but Schumacher's words came to mind: "Small is beautiful." The church was like a flower the settlers had made bloom with their tears. Looking up at the bronze bell hanging in the tower, they sensed a weighty vow within it, a promise not to forget the years of hardship.

On both sides of the sloping path down to the sea, black-and-white photographs of settlers carving out lives in these cliff-like mountains were on display. Author Jeong thought that these photographs were what one truly ought to see in Cinque Terre. As they climbed and descended the narrow coastal paths, they came upon a hillside where the deceased had been given wind burials. It was strikingly similar to what he had seen on Wando in Korea. It was a funerary custom created by settlers in rugged terrain where there was simply not enough land to bury the dead. The alleys ran like a maze. Climbing up through them without any plan, Jeong saw the sea once more spreading out below the cliffs. On the gate of one of the houses, he noticed a nameplate bearing a familiar name. "Noticed" was too mild: he had made a discovery. Author Jeong cried out.

"The poet Montale stayed at this house!"

Eugenio Montale was a leading Italian poet from Genoa who received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1975. Jeong had cried out because he had once been deeply moved by Montale's poetry collection *Cuttlefish Bones*, published in Korean by Minumsa.

The house Montale had used as his study, however, felt abandoned and forlorn, as though no one lived there any longer. When he won the Nobel Prize, every place he had ever stayed must have buzzed with excitement. As if consoling the poet's spirit, Author Jeong murmured lines from the poem "Mediterranean," which seemed to have drawn inspiration from Cinque Terre:

*Old friend, I was drunk
 on the sounds that burst forth
 from your lips, a blue bell
 opening and closing again.
 The house where I lived each passing summer
 was, yes, yes, near you,
 where the sun blazed
 and mosquitoes formed clouds in the sky.
 O sea, today as then
 I grow numb before you.
 How could I ever receive
 the sublime counsel your breath imparts?
 The faint beating of my heart
 is no more than a moment of your breathing.
 Your stern law
 is lodged deep within my heart,
 urging me to be broad, various, and firm.
 As you hurl all the rubbish from the abyss
 onto the shore's starfish, cork scraps, and seaweed,
 so I too must wash away all impurity:
 that is what you first told me.*

It was something of a stretch, but Author Jeong and his wife chose Siena as their second destination. They needed to bring their Italy trip to a close and go to Vienna the next day, since Chairwoman Kwon was waiting for them there. Having heard so much from Mr. Guster about Siena's history and culture on the way to Florence, the city did not feel unfamiliar. On the ride to Siena, home to the Piazza del Campo that Mr. Willi loved, Author Jeong turned his attention to an Italian travel guide.

"Located on a hill 320 meters above sea level, roughly 50 kilometers south of Florence, between tributaries of the Ombrone River. The Chianti hills are celebrated for their wine. Papal and Spanish forces vied with each other for control of Siena. After 1559, it became part of the Duchy of Tuscany. Siena's Renaissance reached its zenith in the fourteenth century, and in the first half of that century a Sienese school of painting emerged in conscious relation to the Florentine school. Because the city was slow to develop as a modern metropolis, many old buildings remain. Landmarks include Siena Cathedral, which rivaled Florence Cathedral, the Piazza del Campo where the Palio horse race is held, and the city hall with the Torre del Mangia."

After transferring to the train bound for Siena, Author Jeong dozed off. When he woke, the train was passing through broad pastureland, with scattered groves of trees dotting the endless meadows.

"Mr. Willi must have lived in one of those forests of absolute silence, composing in his mind."

It was enviable that primeval forest management had been enshrined in law so that animals could live there. Before long the train was running through mountain country. It looked for all the world like Daegwallyeong Pass in Korea's Gangwon Province. Siena station was nestled in a gorge.

Stepping off at Siena station, the sky was as blue as the sea at Cinque Terre. Through deep green leaves, an old castle was visible in the distance, and here too, as in Cinque Terre, a church bell tower rose high. To reach the city quickly from the station, one had to take escalators. It felt like rising some ten floors at a Korean department store. It was a city formed on unusual terrain. Passing through a gate like a triumphal arch, they emerged at once into Siena's center, the historic district designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The streets were narrow, overflowing with travelers. Walking through an alley, they came upon the building where the Sienese novelist Federico Tozzi had lived. A little later, in a small piazza, they met a street artist drawing on the paving stones. Thinking of his younger daughter who did illustration, Author Jeong pulled a coin from his pocket.

At last they stepped into the Piazza del Campo, Siena's center, said to have been laid out in the thirteenth century. The piazza was shaped like a seashell and every year since the fourteenth century it had hosted the Palio. Representatives from each district, dressed in fourteenth century traditional costume, paraded with their local banners and then competed on horseback without saddles in a race so fierce that riders falling and dying was possible. That Mr. Willi, who lived in absolute silence, liked it struck Author Jeong as more than a little puzzling. In any case, it seemed to reflect the rough temperament of the people of Siena.

After viewing the Torre del Mangia, said to have been built high like an observation tower to ward off the Black Death, Mrs. Park bought an apron from a street vendor, thinking it would be useful for her pottery work. Together they then hurried after Mr. Guster to the Santa Maria Cathedral. The cost of the tickets did not feel wasted. The entire interior of the cathedral was a treasure. They could not take their eyes off the pulpit carved with lions, the black and white marble mosaic patterns, and the biblical scenes. In a side room, the Piccolomini Museum, there was even a musical score written by Handel.

Mr. Guster explained that construction of the cathedral had begun in the twelfth century and was completed in the mid-fourteenth. It was a structure

completed over the course of two hundred years. Giovanni Pisano's sculptures had become cultural symbols of their cities wherever one went, and Author Jeong could not help recalling again and again, trite as it might be, the saying: "Life is short, art is long." On the way down from the cathedral, they passed the house of Cesare Brandi, a historical critic, novelist, and poet. Born in Siena and having died there as well, he could be considered a local writer. Crossing the Piazza del Campo once more, they walked briskly to catch their train. The train was smaller than the one they had taken on the way in, with only two cars, and the 5:38 departure was again delayed.

The Eternal Child, Schiele

It was the morning of their departure from Italy to Austria. As they finished checking out at the resort reception and gathered their luggage, Lionel, a waiter from the restaurant, came running. Over fifteen days of crossing paths, he had grown fond of Author Jeong and his wife. He was the young man who, whenever they ordered, would bring the menu and spend a good ten minutes patiently guiding them through it. Author Jeong gave him his business card. With halting English and expressive eyes, they had shared many warm conversations.

To reach Austria, they followed Mr. Guster's directions: take the train from Follonica station to Roma Trastevere, transfer, and get off at Fiumicino Airport station. They needed about three hours of margin to catch their Lufthansa flight to Vienna. But when they arrived at the airport, the departure time had been delayed and the gate changed twice. Had this happened at Incheon Airport in Korea, voices would have been raised and complaints would have flown. Here, everyone stayed quiet.

At last they boarded, and in the Austrian newspaper tucked into the seat pocket, a photograph of North Korean leader Kim Jong-un dominated the front page. It was proof that even in Europe, the North Korea-U.S. talks drew keen interest. Author Jeong hoped the stalled second round of negotiations would go well.

The flight from Fiumicino to Vienna took just over an hour and a half. Emerging into the arrivals hall, they found Chairwoman Kwon of IMK waiting to greet them. Having visited at her invitation three years earlier, the airport felt familiar. The plan was to spend the night at an annex of Chairwoman Kwon's office on Beethovengasse. The street must have taken its name from the building where Beethoven had died.

The next day, however, they were to visit Krems, a city older than Vienna and similar to Kyōngju in Korea. Krems lay about an hour's drive from Vienna. Author Jeong and his wife had stopped there three years ago as well. A hillside town clustered around its cathedral. A pastoral city where

the Danube glinted in the sunlight beyond the vineyards. Atop the hill stood Stift Göttweig, a monastery designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

The night passed like a flash of lightning. Chairwoman Kwon waited outside with the same bright disposition as the day before. They were headed to Dr. Werner's house in Krems. Since they were married, it was of course Chairwoman Kwon's home as well. Dr. Werner had originally been a public physician in the Krems area. After retiring, the local farmers had prevailed upon him to stay, so he settled into a house along the Danube.

Dr. Werner came outside to welcome them.

"Our house was originally monastery land. I'm not sure if we'll run into the priest who granted us this precious plot today."

Author Jeong and his wife went inside for a cup of black tea, then stepped back out to stroll through the garden. After that, they followed Dr. Werner up to Stift Göttweig to see the church. By good fortune, they happened upon Father Maurus, the monastery's chief steward and the very priest who had allotted Dr. Werner his plot of land. The priest had a cast on his foot. He explained:

"Stift Göttweig was founded in 1403, but it burned to the ground and was rebuilt in 1718. Krems is a major white wine region. The soil is a mix of sand and limestone, ideal for growing grapes. Every household here has its own wine cellar. In 2006, Krems celebrated its millennium."

Dr. Werner had a cast on his finger, and Father Maurus had one on his foot. The priest laughed cheerfully, saying they were both wearing casts, "medals of honor earned on the job." Calling injuries medals of honor seemed fitting for such a hardworking priest.

Their next destination was Willendorf, where the Venus figurine had been unearthed. Dr. Werner drove slowly along the Danube, heading in the direction of Germany. On the way to Willendorf, gorges flanked the river, and their hillsides were lined with terraced vineyards. The Venus herself had been discovered while clearing land for a vineyard.

When they arrived at the site, the group first read the information panel about the Venus. The figurine was estimated to have been carved during the Paleolithic era, between 24,900 and 23,900 years ago, and measured roughly eleven centimeters. She had curly hair, her hands resting on large breasts, and her belly swelled like that of a woman in the final stage of pregnancy.

Were voluptuous women the ideal in Paleolithic times? A symbol of fertility and abundance?

But Author Jeong did not want to impose modern interpretations. The figure resembled the ample builds of Western women he had frequently passed on the street.

By the time they returned to Dr. Werner's house, darkness had already fallen. Only the warm sound of the Danube flowing reached them. Perhaps because it was monastery land, the air felt pure. The next day they would head back to Vienna, but the place Author Jeong truly wanted to see was the Egon Schiele Museum. It was in Tulln, a small town between Vienna and Krems, so a visit would not be difficult.

The following day, Chairwoman Kwon took over from Dr. Werner as their guide. Before staying behind in Krems, Dr. Werner presented Author Jeong with a replica of the Austrian Venus figurine. Author Jeong asked Chairwoman Kwon if they could stop at the Schiele Museum on their way to Vienna. Schiele, with his elongated neck, bore a certain resemblance to the Korean poet Yi Sang. The thought of visiting Tulln, the city of Schiele's birth, and encountering his paintings before meeting Mr. Willi set his heart racing. Until high school, Author Jeong had been an aspiring painter in the art club.

The turbulent arc of Schiele's life ran roughly as follows.

Born in Tulln as the son of the stationmaster, Schiele moved with his parents to nearby Krems at the age of eleven and transferred schools. When his father died of syphilis, his maternal uncle, a railroad company employee, became his guardian. Recognizing the boy's talent for drawing, his uncle sent him to the Academy of Fine Arts in Vienna in 1906, at the age of sixteen. But Schiele rebelled against the academy's traditional conservatism and dropped out. As fortune would have it, he met Klimt in 1907 and took him as his mentor. Klimt recognized Schiele's talent, purchased his works, and connected him with patrons. After three years at the Vienna Academy, Schiele joined discontented fellow students in forming the Neukunstgruppe, a new art group. In 1909, Klimt included Schiele in an exhibition where the young painter encountered the works of Edvard Munch, Jan Toorop, and Vincent van Gogh, experiencing an aesthetic awakening. From that point, Schiele began to explore not only the human form but human sexuality. He first participated in group shows in cities like Prague, Budapest, and Cologne, then from 1913 held solo exhibitions in Munich and Paris. Schiele's private life, as is well known, was troubled. In 1911, he began living with seventeen-year-old Wally in Vienna; she was said to have modeled not only for Schiele but for Klimt as well. They left Vienna for his mother's hometown of Český Krumlov in Bohemia (then known as Krumau), but were driven out when the townspeople denounced him for painting nudes of adolescent girls. Yet Schiele maintained that even erotic works possessed a sanctity. They moved next to a cheap studio in Neulengbach, thirty-five kilometers west of Vienna. There, however, Schiele was arrested on charges of seducing a minor. Police seized hundreds of drawings and paintings,

labeling them pornographic, and put him on trial. He served twenty-one days in custody and three days of imprisonment. The judge, who went so far as to burn one of Schiele's drawings in open court, dismissed the charges of seduction and abduction but found him guilty of exhibiting obscene images. Schiele then parted ways with Wally and in 1915 married Edith, the daughter of a locksmith. But the First World War disrupted his work. Just three days after his wedding, he left for Prague to serve in the military. Returning to Vienna in 1917, Schiele devoted himself entirely to painting. Within a year, fifty of his works were featured at a 1918 Vienna exhibition. The exhibition poster caused a sensation: Schiele had parodied The Last Supper, placing himself in the seat of Christ. That was as far as his life would go. Heaven called him home. In 1918, the Spanish flu struck twenty million across Europe. Schiele's wife, six months pregnant, died that autumn, and three days after her death, Schiele closed his eyes at the age of twenty-eight.

Like Dr. Werner's house, the Schiele Museum stood on the banks of the Danube. Perhaps because the town was small, they found it easily. A bronze statue of Schiele stood at the entrance. It was still morning, so there were few visitors. Author Jeong and his wife took in Schiele's works displayed on the first and second floors. The early landscapes and portraits carried an Impressionist quality. But the later works grew darker in tone, asymmetrical, with exaggerated sexual expression. One could call these Expressionist pieces grotesque and decadent. But could such a judgment be the final word on paintings that projected a melancholy genius's inner world without pretense? Leopold, who owned more of Schiele's works than anyone and understood him most truly, had called Schiele "the eternal child," declaring: "What is different about a child's way of seeing? Children's drawings are a reflection of reality." How difficult it is to live in this world and remain a child, free of prejudice and preconception! Author Jeong and his wife learned that the Leopold Museum in Vienna was holding an exhibition commemorating the centennial of Klimt's and Schiele's deaths. Their timing in visiting Austria, they felt, could not have been better.

Reunion with Composer Willi

Back in Vienna after their stay in Krems, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park spent several days resting at the annex on Beethovengasse belonging to Chairwoman Kwon. They shook off the fatigue of their Italian travels by visiting the Leopold Museum to see the exhibition commemorating the centennial of the deaths of Klimt and Schiele.

That afternoon, they were to meet composer Herbert Willi at the Wiener Konzerthaus. It was the same Mr. Willi whom Author Jeong had visited over four days and three nights beginning September 15, 2015, in the Montafon valley with its views of the Alpine snowfields. When Chairwoman Kwon mentioned that a Korean novelist who wrote from a Buddhist worldview existed, Mr. Willi's curiosity was piqued and he had insisted on meeting Author Jeong, prompting the visit.

Author Jeong still vividly remembered staying at the guesthouse beside Mr. Willi's two-story home and spending three days in long conversation with him. As if they were old friends of the soul, they compared Mr. Willi's philosophy of composition with Writer Jeong's literary outlook and spoke together at great depth. For that reason, Writer Jeong felt that he could say he knew Mr. Willi better than anyone else. If he were to introduce the man who had recently become his friend, it would be something like this.

Chairwoman Kwon reported that Mr. Willi had completed a ten-movement work on the theme of Korean *jeong* and was searching for a venue for its premiere. When he showed the score to the brilliant principal conductor of the LA Philharmonic, Gustavo Dudamel, Dudamel declared he had found the sound he had been looking for and asked for the opportunity to give it a premiere.

What was music as Mr. Willi understood it? In an interview with a reporter from the Korean daily H, he had stated:

"The most important thing in my life and my composing is 'absolute silence.' When I walk through the Alpine forests for days or months in search of that silence and stillness, at a certain moment music begins to rise from a deep place within me, from inside my body. In that moment, rational

judgment and analysis disappear, and I shed the membrane of ego and reason that surrounds me. A new world opens, one connected to the infinite universe. That is when I compose."

After a light lunch at their lodgings, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park set out to meet Mr. Willi. The Wiener Konzerthaus was a ten-minute taxi ride away. Chairwoman Kwon was waiting at the entrance and led them to the office where Mr. Willi would receive them.

This reunion with Mr. Willi had been arranged through Chairwoman Kwon at Author Jeong's request. He wanted to revisit parts of Mr. Willi's philosophy of music, his life story, that had remained unclear from their conversations three years prior. They were sipping tea with Chairwoman Kwon in the small office when Mr. Willi walked in wearing a black short-sleeved shirt and jeans, grinning with childlike openness.

"It has been a few days since we arrived in Austria after traveling through Tuscany."

"When I couldn't find a breakthrough in my composing, I lived for about a year near Pisa and Florence. In any case, I drew tremendous energy from Tuscany. All music truly exists there."

"If I were to return to Italy, I would go straight to Tuscany. It was that wonderful. The ancient castles rising at the edge of vast wheat fields were especially striking. I felt as if the inspiration for a novel might surge up at any moment."

"The existence of primeval forests in Tuscany was a great fortune for me as a composer. They influenced the music I have composed recently."

After briefly exchanging recent news, they dove straight into conversation, with Author Jeong posing the questions and Mr. Willi answering.

"Your recovery from the incurable illness you suffered as a boy seems nothing short of a miracle."

"That's right. The incurable disease I had at seventeen or eighteen was healed by drinking the water an elderly priest at a monastery chapel gave me."

"I recall you made a similar confession three years ago."

"Looking back now, I believe it was not mere water but something possessing a divinity beyond itself."

At this point, Mr. Willi spoke carefully. He said he would not continue if Author Jeong found it hard to believe, but Author Jeong urged him on, leaning in to listen.

"So I prayed in the monastery and vowed to dedicate myself to the Lord. After that I enrolled in medical school, hoping to become a doctor. But I soon dropped out and entered seminary. Seminary life was not smooth,

either. In my second year, I asked a priest during a lecture, 'How does wine become the blood of Christ during Mass?' My classmates mocked me, and I took a leave of absence. In the end, after many twists and turns, I graduated from seminary, studied composition at the Salzburg conservatory, and then devoted myself entirely to creative work from the age of twenty-five to forty."

As their conversation flowed, Author Jeong felt a deepening affinity, above all, with the fact that Mr. Willi was a monist in the Eastern mold. Herbert Willi, believer that the self, nature, and the universe were not separate but one. A vegetarian who ate only one meal a day, like an ascetic Seon master. More surprising still was his confession that he might have been Korean in a past life. When he added that he would gladly eat three meals a day if they were Korean food, his confession did not feel hollow. Roughly two hours had passed.

"I'm sorry, but my schedule won't allow us to talk any longer. I have another engagement."

But Author Jeong was not sorry, for they had agreed to meet again the next morning at the same place. On the way back, a sudden downpour forced them to pause only briefly before the statue of Maria Theresa, the empress who had secured the stability of the Habsburg dynasty. Returning to their lodgings, they changed clothes. Author Jeong put on a modern-style *hanbok*, and Mrs. Park changed into a traditional *hanbok*.

They had dressed in Korean finery to see the ballet *Giselle* at the State Opera House. Chairwoman Kwon had procured the tickets, so all they had to do was show up. It was an embarrassing confession, but Author Jeong had never attended a ballet in his life. He looked up *Giselle* in a ballet dictionary and found the following:

Composed in 1841. With a libretto by the nineteenth-century French Romantic poet Théophile Gautier, music by Adolphe Adam, and choreography by Jean Coralli and Jules Perrot. The work depicts the love between the peasant girl Giselle and the nobleman Albert, singing of the pain of unfulfilled love and the eternity of love that transcends even death. A masterpiece of Romantic ballet, it premiered at the Paris Opéra. However, the Giselle we see today is not the 1841 original but a new production choreographed by Marius Petipa in Russia in 1860.

They arrived early at the State Opera House, which alongside the Burgtheater had become one of Vienna's great artistic landmarks. Women in kimonos caught their eye. Picking up a program for *Giselle*, they discovered that the dancer performing the role of the count was Japanese. The women in kimonos appeared to be fans who had traveled from Japan to see him.

Audience members gave thumbs up at the sight of Author Jeong's and Mrs. Park's *hanbok*. The moment they stepped into the second-floor seats, the scale took their breath away. Every seat across all six levels was full, and it was only a weekday. A theater this grand and an audience this devoted, Author Jeong thought, were what it took for a nation to claim its place among cultural powers.

The ballet *Giselle*, with its fusion of music and dance, was not in the least tedious, and its story came through without need for words. At last, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park truly felt they had arrived in Vienna, city of the arts.

The next day, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park returned to the Wiener Konzerthaus where they had gone the previous afternoon, this time to meet Mr. Willi again. He had promised to explain the background of the ten movements he had spent more than a decade composing on the theme of Korean *jeong*. When they entered the office, the wall clock read 9:40. Author Jeong and his wife listened as Mr. Willi described in detail the compositional intent behind each movement, from the first to the tenth.

"I composed the process of searching for music in ten stages. The theme of *Jeong* is absolute peace and absolute freedom."

Author Jeong was reminded of the Buddhist *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*, a series of ten images depicting the stages of seeking an ox, which represents truth. He sketched the ox-herding images on a notepad and showed them to Mr. Willi, who was fascinated and deeply sympathetic.

"The music I composed also flows from the first movement through the ninth in pursuit of absolute freedom and absolute peace, then in the tenth movement returns to the original silence."

"It is remarkably similar to the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*, which depict the stages of Buddhist practice in pursuit of awakening."

In the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*, one departs from the marketplace into the mountains in search of the ox of truth, and after finding it, returns to the marketplace in a state of *jeokmyeol*, silent peace, having forgotten even the ox. The structural arc was strikingly similar.

"I wish for my composition *Jeong* to have its premiere at Panmunjom on the Korean Peninsula, where true peace is needed most."

"When I return to Korea, I will do my best to make that happen."

Author Jeong, who was well acquainted with the Korean prime minister, resolved inwardly that upon his return he would watch for an opportunity and do what he could to arrange it.

What is *Jeong*?

Author Jeong now felt that Mr. Willi was like a friend. The many conversations they had exchanged the day before had given him a fair understanding of Mr. Willi's music. When Author Jeong mentioned that he would work toward arranging the premiere of *Jeong* at Panmunjom in Korea, Mr. Willi's face lit up with a smile of pleasure.

"It was when I stopped in Korea after watching the New Japan Philharmonic Orchestra give the premiere of my concerto in Tokyo. While traveling through Korea, lecturing and debating with fresh-faced students at the Korean National University of Arts, visiting Haein-sa, seeing Ihwajang where Mrs. Francesca had lived in Seoul, I heard three sounds. They were the highest pitch, the lowest pitch, and the longest tone I have ever perceived."

Author Jeong ventured his own interpretation of the three sounds Mr. Willi had heard in Korea.

"The highest pitch must be Korean *heung*, exuberance. The lowest must be Korean *han*, grief refined into resilience. And the longest must be Korean *jeong*."

"Why do you say that?"

"Since ancient times, Koreans have loved song, dance, and poetry. It is because they possess an abundance of *heung*. Korea has also endured countless invasions from China, Japan, and others, and so carries deep sorrow. Yet Koreans have a strength that overcomes sorrow through sorrow itself. That strength is called *han*. And perhaps because of that arduous history of foreign invasion, Koreans also possess a heart that helps neighbors without condition. That heart is called *jeong*. *Heung* is a joyful sound, so it cannot help being high. *Han* is tempered deep within the heart, so it cannot help being low. And *jeong*, which has no end, cannot help being long."

"Ah, I see. Through the *Jeong* I have composed, I want people to feel that the human being and the universe are one. Each movement will offer a small taste of *jeong*. From the first to the fourth movement, the orchestra

plays simultaneously. In the remaining movements, the orchestra is joined first by a soloist, then by two performers."

"Are you thinking of including performers from both North and South Korea in the section where two players join the orchestra?"

"Exactly. Because Korea is divided between North and South, I would love it if both sides performed *Jeong* together in pursuit of peace and freedom. One possibility would be to split the orchestra members half and half."

Mr. Willi was well versed in the history of the two Koreas. He understood that before 1945, although it was under Japanese colonial rule, Korea had been a single nation, and that it was divided by the United States and the Soviet Union.

"After 1945 came the division. The Soviet Union and the United States swiftly drew the 38th parallel. In the South, the Syngman Rhee regime was established with American military support as a democratic government; in the North, the Kim Il-sung regime was built with Soviet backing as a communist government. In short, the great powers decided everything as they pleased, without consulting Korea, a small and powerless nation."

"I do hope that *Jeong* will be performed at Panmunjom."

"I will do my best when I return to Korea, though I cannot promise anything. Relations between North and South have been a cycle of tension repeated again and again."

Relations between the two Koreas were like the weather, alternating between overcast and clear. Since the spring of that year, the relationship had been moving toward peace: the third inter-Korean summit was held in April, and North Korean athletes had participated in the Pyeongchang Winter Olympics held in the South. Yet the possibility of renewed conflict between the US and China, or between the US and North Korea, remained ever present, and the state of inter-Korean tension was impossible to predict. Author Jeong changed the subject.

"Mr. Willi, how do you understand the concept of *jeong*?"

"I understand it as the supreme concept, standing above both Christian love and Buddhist compassion."

"Ha ha ha."

"Is my view mistaken?"

"Not at all. But rather than comparing *jeong* with other concepts, I would suggest understanding it as something with absolute value in its own right. Nor do I think one needs to regard *jeong* as something lofty or sacred. Of course, Mr. Willi, the fact that you have expanded the concept of *jeong* into the philosophical realm is quite inspiring. In any case, *jeong* is clearly one of the most positive values that humanity possesses. In Korean, the word *jeong*

appears in a remarkable number of compounds: *bujeong*, a father's affection; *mojeong*, a mother's affection; *ujeong*, the affection between friends; and many more. Beyond that, there is 'beautiful *jeong*,' and there is even 'ugly *jeong*' — the affection that grows between people through quarreling. So one might also understand *jeong* through the lens of Hegel's dialectic of thesis, antithesis, and synthesis."

When Author Jeong mentioned Hegel, a light came into Mr. Willi's eyes. In that instant, Author Jeong realized that Mr. Willi knew the philosopher well. His intuition proved correct. Mr. Willi responded at once.

"I am fond of Hegel's dialectic. It astonishes me to learn that Korean has such a thing as 'ugly *jeong*.' There is no such expression in Europe. How 'ugly' and 'beautiful' can merge into one would be impossible to explain without Hegel's philosophy of thesis, antithesis, and synthesis."

Author Jeong, too, had been drawn to Hegel's philosophy in his university days, and hearing that Mr. Willi felt the same deepened the sense that their minds were in tune. Mr. Willi continued.

"Thirty-five years ago, while walking with my friend Rudi, a priest, in Italy, I told him something. People love to divide things, classical music, modern music, folk music, Eastern music, Western music, and so on. But for me, only one music exists. My music does not belong to any category; it is simply a single mass. For me there is no good music or bad music, only the question of whether it is fused or not. That is why I came to explain my music through Hegel's philosophy. Come to think of it, *Jeong* may be the very music I have been striving to realize."

Just then, Chairwoman Kwon entered the office. When they had parted the evening before, she had offered to translate for Mr. Willi if Author Jeong would write out "What is *jeong*?" and "What are the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*?" on A4 paper and bring them. Author Jeong said:

"Chairwoman Kwon, here is the piece I wrote last night. However, I will send the essay on the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures* by email after I return to Korea. I want to consult Buddhist reference materials to write it accurately."

"You have done well. Once you send the essay on the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*, I will have my son translate it into English and pass it along to Mr. Willi."

The manuscript Author Jeong handed to Chairwoman Kwon, titled "What is *Jeong*?", read as follows. It was, of course, a text that reflected Author Jeong's personal perspective.

What is *Jeong*?

Jeong is the warm and benevolent heart that Koreans possess. Just as the Korean word *nim* — used to address a truly beloved person — cannot be

translated as a mere "you," so too is *jeong* a word that defies translation. Yet Koreans sense and understand *jeong* instinctively. How, then, can one explain *jeong* to a foreigner? Rather than offering a dictionary definition, it seems more effective to reveal, one by one, what I believe to be the essence of *jeong*.

Jeong has the power to open the doors of the heart. *Jeong* does not compel, as religion does. Like a flower that blooms where it stands, it simply lets its fragrance be felt.

Jeong is love, a heart that bestows compassion. *Jeong* asks nothing in return. Like a spring that never runs dry, it simply offers its water to the thirsty.

Jeong is a gift of the heart, both given and received. Joy grows the more *jeong* is shared. And sorrow shrinks the more *jeong* is shared.

Jeong does not belong to God. In the Korean language, there is no expression for giving *jeong* to God. Nor is there any expression for God giving *jeong*. It exists only among human beings.

Jeong is a heart capable of saving a person. *Jeong* is the heart that forgives, the heart that considers others, the heart of compassion that makes a human being truly human.

Jeong is a heart capable of bringing peace to the world. Because *jeong* resides within the human heart, there is no need to seek it elsewhere. It is one of the simplest means by which peace in the world might be achieved.

Jeong is the homeland to which all the people of the world must return. For *jeong* is like a flower, like a spring, like a special gift; it exists only among human beings; it can save a person; and it is one of the simplest means by which peace in the world might be achieved.

When Chairwoman Kwon translated the piece into English on the spot and read it aloud, Mr. Willi responded as though he grasped it immediately.

"*Jeong* has the power to open the doors of the heart; it is love and a heart that bestows compassion. It is also a heart capable of bringing peace to the world. It does not belong to God. It exists only among human beings."

"That is correct. You have understood it exactly as I intended."

"I very much look forward to reading the essay on the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures* that you will send."

"Yes, I will send it without fail as soon as possible."

A sudden impulse struck Author Jeong like a flash of lightning: he wanted to write Mr. Willi's life in music as a novel. Just as Somerset Maugham had taken the painter Gauguin as the protagonist of *The Moon and Sixpence*. The very fact that they had met and spoken together was novelistic material, and confidence surged within him. In truth, when he first met Mr. Willi in September 2015, he had told both Chairwoman Kwon and Mr. Willi

candidly, "I understand you well enough to want to write about you, but I cannot promise, since it would mean returning to Austria."

At noon, Mr. Willi rose to his feet in a hurry. He needed to catch a train to Innsbruck. Declaring that the time spent with Author Jeong had made him happy, he extended his hand. Author Jeong was equally grateful. He and Mrs. Park followed Mr. Willi down to the entrance of the Wiener Konzerthaus to see him off. There, Author Jeong took two photographs with Mr. Willi, who was dressed in jeans and a red jacket.

Ten Ox-Herding Pictures

After parting with Mr. Willi at the entrance to the Vienna Concert House, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park did not immediately board a flight back to Seoul. This was because Chairwoman Kwon had urged them to travel on to Budapest in Hungary and Prague in the Czech Republic, both two or three hours away by car. Chairwoman Kwon had thoughtfully provided an IMK company car and sent one of the company's drivers to guide Author Jeong and Mrs. Park.

After returning to Korea, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park could not forget Chairwoman Kwon's kindness. For Author Jeong in particular, his impression of Prague in the Czech Republic did not fade easily. The road to Prague had felt as though it were the day he was to meet Kafka. During his high school years, when he had immersed himself in existentialist philosophy, the writers who moved Author Jeong most deeply were Kafka and Camus. Gregor, the protagonist of Kafka's short story *The Metamorphosis*, gave him the sense of being like a half-brother to Meursault, the protagonist of Camus's novel *The Stranger*. It was so from the very first sentences of the two works.

'One morning, Gregor awoke from troubled dreams to find that, lying in his bed, he had been transformed into a monstrous insect.' Opening sentence of *The Metamorphosis*

'Mother died today. Or maybe yesterday, I don't know. I received a telegram from the home.' Opening sentence of *The Stranger*

Gregor's transformation into a monstrous insect was also a rupture from the world, and the death of Meursault's mother likewise seemed a rupture from the world. For Gregor and Meursault, as beings existing in reality, these were absurd situations that they had no choice but to accept.

In any case, the Kafka Museum near the banks of the Vltava was bizarre and grotesque. It was not a hospitable space for visitors. It was exceedingly uncomfortable. It even gave one a sense of the uncanny. The entire museum was an homage to Kafka's novel *The Castle*. In the museum courtyard were installed bronze statues of the two enigmatic men who appear in the novel,

along with a chair designed in the shape of the letter K. K was the protagonist of Kafka's novel *The Castle*. *The Castle* was at once a symbol that rules over human beings and a space symbolizing a God that human beings cannot attain.

The Castle must have been a novelistic device giving form to Kafka's father, who possessed an authority like that of God. In reality, Kafka's father was indeed an absolute figure, almost like a god to Kafka. It is said that his self-made father constantly subjected Kafka to reproach and humiliation, saying, "I accomplished this much even under difficult circumstances, so why is it that you, who lack for nothing, can do no better than that?" *The Castle* begins as follows.

'One night, the protagonist K arrives at a snow-covered village. K, a land surveyor, says that he has come to work at the Castle near the village, but the villagers cannot believe what he says. The next morning, K climbs toward the Castle alone. But even when he asks people the way, they merely respond with cynical smiles. Feeling something strange, K searches for the Castle, but all his efforts are in vain. No matter how hard he looks, he cannot find the Castle. When he returns to the inn, two assistants are there. But they are not the assistants who had been working with K. They are unsettling figures of unknown identity. Amid this strange atmosphere and these encounters with unfamiliar assistants, K repeatedly tries to reach the Castle, but in the end all comes to nothing. Leaving behind the proposition that one's aim can never be fulfilled, the novel *The Castle* comes to an end. What, then, is K's Castle? Is it a god imagined by human beings? Is it a place that saves human beings? But the novel ends by showing the absurdity of a world in which such things cannot be reached.'

As soon as he stepped into the Kafka Museum, it felt eerie. It was as though Author Jeong himself had become K. The museum felt like the Castle that K had tried to enter. Unlike other museums, the interior was dark like a cave. It had been deliberately staged to create an atmosphere as ambiguous and melancholic as Kafka's life. There was not a single window, in order to shut out bright light. The displayed photographs and materials were only barely visible under small lamps.

The next day, Budapest in Hungary, which they visited by car, also left a powerful impression on Author Jeong and Mrs. Park. Mrs. Park was especially moved at the Liszt Museum, and Author Jeong at the Attila József Literary Museum. From the standpoint of Mrs. Park, who loved classical music, this was only natural. Attila was a poet for whom UNESCO had designated 2005 as the Year of Attila József, and moreover he was well known enough in Korea that his poetry collection *The Seventh Person* had been translated and read by Author Jeong.

Budapest was the city formed in 1873 by the union of Buda on the right bank of the Danube and Pest on the left bank. Its population was about the same as that of Daejeon in Korea, and its original forebears were the Huns and the Magyars, so its history was very deep. The IMK employee managed with difficulty to park the car in an empty space off a side road. But although Budapest was lined with old-fashioned buildings, it gave off a gloomy impression. It seemed as though the shadow of socialism still hung over it. Women dressed in clothes resembling mottled military uniforms occasionally caught the eye.

A search on a smartphone immediately brought up the Liszt Museum on Sugár Street. The present Liszt Museum is said to have been the music academy where Liszt taught his students. Upon entering the two-story building, the first thing they saw was a picture hanging on the wall with the words "DORÉ 1866." It was a picture that the artist Doré had painted of Dante in hell after drawing inspiration from Liszt's *Dante Sonata*, and then presented to Liszt as a gift. Since Liszt is said to have read not only Dante's *Divine Comedy* but also Goethe's *Faust* and to have composed the *Faust Symphony*, he was surely a composer who read literary works with deep devotion. Also on display in one room was a very small instrument, the so-called "piano harmonica," which he had used when teaching students. A notice announcing a concert on the door of the small hall right next to the exhibition room caught their attention. Mrs. Park paused for a moment in front of the notice. She seemed deeply disappointed that she had come to the Liszt Museum but could not listen to any music.

The second place the party visited was the Attila József Literary Museum. Attila József (1905–1937) was the poet most beloved by the Hungarian people. He was a worker-poet who had gone from being a pig-herding boy to a glass factory laborer. Attila's father left for America when he was three years old, so the young Attila was adopted by foster parents, and his mother, who worked as a laundress, suffered from cancer and died. The precocious Attila even attempted suicide at the age of nine. After drifting through many occupations, including day laborer, newspaper seller, newspaper delivery boy, dockworker, assistant seaman, guard at a corn farm, poet, and translator, Attila eventually gave up his life at the age of thirty-two by throwing himself in front of a freight train. Looking at the autobiographical statement he wrote in 1937 when entering a company, one can be certain that the seeds of poetry were already germinating at that time.

'In a third-grade reader, I read the story of "Attila," king of the Huns, and began to immerse myself in reading. Since my own name was Attila, it interested me all the more. I had heard that there was no Christian name

Attila, so the story of King Attila astonished me. From that time on, I began to question my own existence.'

They finally found the Attila József Literary Museum only after asking people for directions. After pressing the doorbell and stating their business, someone opened the door. When Author Jeong told a young curator that he had come from Korea, the curator smiled and held out two business cards. They were the cards of Kim Jaehwan, director of the Korean Cultural Center in Hungary, and Professor Kim Eunggyo of Sookmyung Women's University. He said that the museum had opened three years earlier and that Author Jeong was only the third Korean visitor, and he did not charge an admission fee.

On the first floor of the literary museum were displayed photographs of Attila filled with anger, handwritten letters, and other small materials. The curator told them that Attila's statue was on the bank of the Danube. The party drove up and down the riverside road two or three times in the car before finally finding the statue. Attila was sitting in a stooped posture, looking down at the blue Danube. He had taken off his suit jacket and was holding a hat in one hand, and his vacant expression made him seem as though he had lost all hope. Perhaps he was not looking at the Danube at all, but composing poetry in despair. Attila's "vacant expression," like a *hwadu*, did not easily disappear from Author Jeong's mind. That "vacant expression" gripped Author Jeong with a strange and powerful force.

After staying in Seoul and then arriving at Ibuljae, his mountain retreat in Hwasun, it was not until five days later that Author Jeong was freed from the afterimages and memories of his travels in the Czech Republic and Hungary. Only then did Author Jeong begin in the early evening to write a very brief account of the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures* that he had promised Mr. Willi. The manuscript was finished surprisingly quickly, in just one hour. What Author Jeong wrote on the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures* was as follows.

The Ten Ox-Herding Pictures: ten stages in which the oxherd seeks the ox
(truth)

1. Setting out to search for the ox (The oxherd enters the mountains in search of the ox, wandering from one mountain to another.)
2. Seeing the ox's footprints (After wandering in the mountains, the oxherd at last sees the ox's footprints.)
3. Seeing the ox (In the mountains, which are like their own mind, the oxherd sees the ox.)
4. Catching the ox (The oxherd grabs hold of the halter of the ox as it tries to disappear.)

5. Tending the ox (The oxherd tries to become close to the ox, like a friend.)
6. Riding the ox back home (The oxherd rides the ox, now grown close, back to the place from which they originally departed.)
7. The ox is forgotten and only the self remains (The oxherd is content and happy, thinking that together with the ox they have become one.)
8. Both self and ox are forgotten (The oxherd forgets even the thought that they have become one with the ox.)
9. Returning to the original place (The oxherd arrives at the place from which they had set out in search of the ox.)
10. Returning to everyday life and enjoying freedom (The oxherd becomes a free person and lives in peace while enjoying everyday life.)

P.S. Mr. Willi's *Jeong* closely resembles the stages of the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*. In Mr. Willi's case, the ox in the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures* would be music. And the final tenth movement of *Jeong*, which pursues absolute freedom and absolute peace, corresponds to the final tenth stage of the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*.

Only after emailing the manuscript to Chairwoman Kwon did Author Jeong pour himself a cup of black tea. At last, he savored its deep fragrance. The *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures* manuscript felt like a period placed at the end of his Austrian journey. He could not know when he might travel to Austria again, but he knew he would miss it from time to time. Just then, Author Jeong heard the cry of a scops owl from the mountain behind Ibuljae, its call as raw as if it were coughing up blood. Mr. Willi, back in Montafon, was perhaps listening to the song of a nightingale.

Vienna Streets

July 30, 2025.

Author Jeong and his wife arrived in Vienna and spent the night in Unit 401 of a six-story mixed-use apartment building attached to a hospital. Chairwoman Kwon said she had borrowed an apartment owned by an acquaintance and handed them the keys. There were two keys: one for the door to Unit 401 and the other for the main entrance to the apartment building. Unit 401 in that building was a place where the couple could stay and come and go as they pleased during their two-week stay in Austria.

The lodging was close to a tram stop, and Schubert's birthplace was nearby. They had also stopped there once when they came in May 2018. Schubert did not seem to be especially popular among Austrians. That time as well, it had been around ten in the morning, but the entrance was locked, and after knocking they had barely managed to get in, only to find that they were the only visitors.

Chairwoman Kwon said they could take the tram, but suggested that they walk into central Vienna and revive old memories. Since they had last come in 2018, it had truly been seven years. Yet before long, their forgotten memories of the city streets returned. Vienna had an unusually large number of churches. At eight in the morning they heard the clear sound of bells ringing from a church near the lodging, and cathedrals often came into view. They even went inside St. Stephen's Cathedral, one of Vienna's landmarks, and breathed in the sacred atmosphere unique to such a church. Chairwoman Kwon then explained why Vienna had so many churches.

"Viennese citizens pay a church tax. That is how the great cathedrals can be maintained. Of course, there is nothing like the tithe offerings of Korean churches, but some believers do make donations to churches according to their own wishes."

Though it was July, the weather was cool, like autumn in Korea. The party walked through central Vienna as if on a leisurely stroll. They passed the Vienna Musikverein Golden Hall and the Vienna Konzerthaus, where Mr. Willi had premiered his own works. Before long they went into Café

Imperial, which Mr. Willi had used as a meeting place with notable figures in the music world, and had tea there. Chairwoman Kwon said that Professor Sigmund Freud, who had deeply illuminated the world of the unconscious that Author Jeong so admired, had also been fond of Café Imperial.

"They say Professor Freud came here often. His birthplace is nearby."

Vienna was also a city of cafés. Whichever street they walked down, there were old-fashioned cafés with long histories. Chairwoman Kwon explained them one by one like a guide.

"Among the old cafés, Café Schwarzenberg and Café Demel are representative examples. Tomorrow let us go to Café Demel and have tea."

"Since we had tea today at the Hotel Imperial café, that would be a good place for tomorrow."

They had lunch at Sura, a restaurant run by a Korean. The sign was in Hangul, so it caught the couple's attention even more. But then something happened that surprised them. A Korean expatriate named Kang Seonduk, who had borrowed and been deeply moved by Author Jeong's books from Chairwoman Kwon, had already paid in advance for three days' worth of lunches. Chairwoman Kwon said Kang had worked for more than twenty years at a hospital in Austria before retiring as a head nurse, and that her hometown was in Jeolla Province. Not only that, but Ms. Kang's younger brother, an Oriental medicine doctor, had sent along pills of *gyeong ok go*, saying they were good for recovering from travel fatigue, and through Chairwoman Kwon they were presented as a gift to Author Jeong. On the spot, Author Jeong handed Chairwoman Kwon two folding fans as gifts.

"These are folding fans I received by asking painter Kim Yangsu for them before coming from Korea. One is for you, Chairwoman Kwon, and please give the other one to Ms. Kang Seonduk."

The fan given to Chairwoman Kwon was painted with a scene of azaleas in full bloom. Author Jeong found himself admiring Koreans like Ms. Kang Seonduk who had come to Austria and in their own ways made successes of themselves.

The next day.

At around ten in the morning, Chairwoman Kwon came again to the lodging, and they decided to walk through Vienna. It was only on the second day that the name of the church nearest the lodging finally became familiar to them: Votiv Church. The nearby park and café also bore the name Votiv.

The party passed Votiv Church and went to City Hall. Hearing what Chairwoman Kwon said, Author Jeong and his wife felt a twinge of envy.

"Among the mayor's policies, the first is arts policy. Living here, I always sympathize with the mayor's policies."

The City Hall building, fitting for a city of churches, had been designed in a church style. A traveler might easily mistake it for a cathedral. Yet the square in front of City Hall resembled a performance venue. A giant screen and fixed seating had been installed there.

"How enviable. It truly is a city of the arts."

"From the last Friday of July, when students begin their vacation, through August, and also on special occasions, they show orchestral performances, opera, vocal music, theater, jazz, musicals, and even vanishing Austrian circus acts free of charge at night. Citizens gather in enormous crowds to watch."

"At Seoul City Hall Plaza or Gwanghwamun Plaza in Korea, there are demonstrations and rallies that cause serious traffic congestion, so it is enviable to hear of citizens gathering instead to enjoy the arts."

Chairwoman Kwon next led the couple to Café Demel, where Mr. Willi had often gone to meet people connected with the music world. But when they saw people lined up waiting, they simply passed by. Author Jeong said, "Mr. Willi seems to like old cafés."

"Actually, Mr. Willi told me to show you the cafés he used to frequent."

"For what reason?"

"I think he wanted to help with your writing."

This time they went into Café Schwarzenberg. Chairwoman Kwon entered first and found them a seat. The outdoor tables in front of the building were already full. Inside the café it was a little dim, but there was no helping it. At the table right next to them, a middle-aged woman who looked like a professor was quietly tutoring a young student in the basics of vocal music.

"This café, too, was a place where Mr. Willi would meet conductors and performers and discuss performances."

"Then the café manager must know Mr. Willi well."

"Of course. Mr. Willi is a well-known figure in Vienna."

According to Chairwoman Kwon, Café Schwarzenberg had opened in 1861. Later, in 1902, it took the name Café Schwarzenberg, and it served mainly as a meeting place for people in the financial world. She said that the architect Josef Hoffmann had been a regular patron, though to be honest the architect's name meant little to Author Jeong.

In any case, for two days now, the party had been leaving the lodging around ten in the morning and spending the entire afternoon wandering through the streets and alleys of Vienna. If they had walked five or six hours in Seoul, they would have been badly stressed by exhaust fumes and noise, but in Vienna there was far less of that kind of fatigue.

"Even though we have walked quite a distance since morning, I do not feel tired."

"That must be because of your artistic sensibility, Mr. Jeong."

"Just as there are forest paths in the mountains, Vienna seems to have forest paths of music. There is clearly something in Vienna that keeps a person from growing weary."

Mrs. Park, who loved classical music, joined the conversation.

"Johann Strauss, Mozart, Wagner, Schubert, Beethoven, Klimt, Schiller, Freud, and Mr. Willi all seem as though they must have drawn inspiration from Vienna's streets and cafés."

Before they knew it, the party had walked as far as the square in front of Parliament. There, young people who looked to be Iranian students were holding placards and demonstrating against what they described as Israel's atrocities. The party could not simply remain indifferent, so for a moment they offered silent support. It seemed to be a protest that had been properly reported to the police. Only one male officer and one female officer stood nearby watching, and the demonstration was entirely peaceful. The method of protest was to bring out aluminum pots and frying pans to bang on with spoons and chopsticks to make metallic noise. Mrs. Park asked Author Jeong,

"Why did they bring pots with them?"

"Perhaps it is a protest telling Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu not to take away their right to survive."

In the square across from them stood the statue of Empress Maria Theresa of the Habsburg Empire that had once dominated Europe. Come to think of it, Vienna was a city of statues no less than of churches. There were statues standing in every park and square. Even during their walk, the party had already seen statues of Mozart, Goethe, Schiller, Emperor Franz Joseph I, and many others.

The party sat for a while on a bench in the courtyard of a theater building built by Emperor Franz Joseph I, where Mr. Willi's *Brother of Sleep* had been performed many times, and rested. After that they went as far as the front of the Theater an der Wien, where Mr. Willi's work had been premiered. Chairwoman Kwon explained that it was a historic theater opened in 1801, where Beethoven had been invited to serve as music director, had premiered his *Fidelio*, and had staged his major works. The doors were locked, perhaps because it was closed, so Author Jeong and his wife could not go inside.

Since the next day they would have to ride the train for six hours to Bregenz Station in order to meet Mr. Willi, the party headed back to the lodging a little earlier than the day before.

"Mr. Willi is waiting so eagerly his eyes are about to fall out."

In response to Chairwoman Kwon's remark, Author Jeong joked,

"We'll go and check if his eyes really popped out or not. Hahaha."

Instead of walking as they had the day before, the party took the tram. Chairwoman Kwon got off first in front of her lodging near the building where Beethoven had died. Author Jeong and his wife got off at a stop just past Schubert's birthplace.

Montafon Revisited After Ten Years

The train that left Vienna Central Station at 10:30 raced without pause all the way to Salzburg Station. Broad meadows and pastures streamed endlessly past the window. In 2015, Dr. Werner had driven them to Montafon in his own car, but now that he had passed away, Author Jeong and his wife, along with Chairwoman Kwon, had no choice but to travel by train. At times a river would appear close by, then vanish again. The mountains still kept their distance. Chairwoman Kwon said,

“If the meadows are well maintained, the government provides subsidies. That is why people care for them as carefully as if they were tending their own gardens.”

“In Korea, farmers also receive a direct payment paid out by the state. But it seems they do not extend such payments to the meadows on the mountain slopes.”

It seemed to be a case of mutual flourishing between state and individual: private people raised their household income by tending the mountainside meadows well, while the state could show tourists an Austria of peaceful nature. Author Jeong had assumed the pastoral landscape simply came into being on its own, and he nodded at the realization that it was in fact a joint work of the state and the individual.

It was long after they had passed Salzburg Station. Rock mountains shaped like pyramids had drawn near before they knew it. As the mountains came closer, the meadows grew narrower. The grasslands, shrinking the farther the train ran, had in places climbed up onto the gently sloping skirts of the mountains. After the train emerged from two or three long tunnels, the city of Innsbruck came into view, home to the theological college from which Mr. Willi had graduated in his youth and the hospital where he had been admitted as a boy with an incurable illness.

“We still have three or four more stops before Bludenz Station.”

“So, there is no train that goes all the way to Montafon.”

“Montafon is a very remote place even within Vorarlberg. Mr. Willi said he would drive out to Bludenz Station to meet us.”

“He must be busy, and yet we are putting him to so much trouble.”

“When I told him we were coming by train, he was the one who first offered to come and pick us up in his car.”

“Hahaha. If he has been waiting for us so eagerly, that is understandable enough.”

The train’s final stop was Bregenz, the capital of Vorarlberg. When there were about two stations left, the party took their suitcases down from the rack. Then they stepped out into the passageway between the cars. None of the other passengers had come out yet. Chairwoman Kwon said with a smile,

“It is a Korean trait. When you see people hurrying and rushing, most of them are Korean. Look. Not a single Austrian has come out yet.”

“That is true. We are the only ones out here.”

A train crew member announced the upcoming station. Mrs. Park said,

“I’m not sure this is our stop.”

Only when the upcoming station came into sight did three or four Austrian passengers come out into the passageway. The party stood on tiptoe in the passageway to make way for them.

“If Dr. Werner were still alive, you could have gone comfortably by car. I am sorry.”

“Not at all. If I remember correctly, Dr. Werner drove for eight hours that time. But today the train takes only six, so in a way it seems to save time.”

“If you want to tour the Alps, a car is certainly better, but there is pleasure in traveling by train, too.”

The train that had left Vienna Central Station at 10:30 was due to arrive at Bludenz Station at 4:30 in the afternoon. That being so, in about another thirty minutes the train would be pulling into Bludenz Station.

“You must feel something special, returning to Montafon after ten years.”

“I met Mr. Willi once in Montafon in 2015 and twice in Vienna in 2018, so this is the fourth time, yet my heart is fluttering as though I were on my way to meet a friend.”

“And you too, Mrs. Park?”

“I want to hear Mr. Willi talk about music again.”

Mrs. Park, an ardent lover of classical music, spoke as she recalled the shock she had felt in 2015 when she heard Mr. Willi’s music at his two-story home. He had played them his own music recorded on CD, and she had been unable to tear herself away from it for the whole day, as though seized by a *hwadu*.

At last, when they got off at Bludenz Station, silver-haired Mr. Willi came toward them smiling. The station building was small and unadorned,

befitting a country station. He gave Chairwoman Kwon a light embrace. He warmly shook hands with Author Jeong and exchanged an affectionate glance with Mrs. Park. Instead of going into the station building, the party followed him straight to the parking lot and got into his car. Chairwoman Kwon and Mr. Willi exchanged the next few hours' plans in German and then Chairwoman Kwon explained them to Author Jeong and his wife.

"Mr. Willi says that first we should go to your hotel, unpack, and then come down into the village for a meal."

"It is not even six yet, so that sounds good."

"I booked the hotel online. It is higher up than Mr. Willi's house, and from there you can see the village and the mountain opposite all at once."

For Author Jeong and his wife, the 2025 journey was a special one. Chairwoman Kwon was covering their round-trip airfare between Seoul and Vienna, along with all of their lodging. To that same degree, Chairwoman Kwon earnestly hoped that Author Jeong would write a work taking Mr. Willi's life in music as its subject. Even so, it was not a binding obligation. The timing of the writing, its structure, and its content were all to be left entirely to Author Jeong's own wishes. The method he had in mind was simple. Rather than displaying his own imagination, he meant to write down just what he had experienced, including the conversations he had exchanged with Mr. Willi. It would not be wrong to call it a kind of autobiographical novel.

Before long, the car passed through the village of St. Anton, where Mr. Willi lived, and stopped at the crest of the mountain road. The hotel where Chairwoman Kwon and Author Jeong and his wife were staying stood on high ground at about 1000m above sea level. Just beyond the parking lot in front of the hotel was a sheer, vertiginous cliff. There was no telling how skilled Mr. Willi was at driving, but watching him back into the space was enough to give one a sense of danger.

The lodging Chairwoman Kwon had reserved was Hotel Bergerhof. Mr. Willi waited in the hotel lobby while Chairwoman Kwon and Author Jeong and his wife received their room keys from the clerk at the counter and climbed the stairs to the second floor. Author Jeong and his wife had a room with a fine view. The massive peaks of the mountain opposite faced them directly. No sooner had Author Jeong and his wife set their suitcases beside the bed than they went back down to the hotel lobby, where Mr. Willi was waiting. Chairwoman Kwon came down from her own room after them.

The sun had not yet set. The remaining daylight, the final glow of the day, was gentle rather than strong. It fell impartially on the well-paved slope, the neat roads of the village, and the stream flowing through the valley, as well.

After parking his car in a lot beside the stream, Mr. Willi showed them the notable places in the village. In particular, in front of the Posthotel Taube, he said the owner was a friend and suggested they take a commemorative photograph. The dove design above the hotel's name was striking, too.

"Since Hemingway stayed and wrote here, I think this hotel will remain in your memory, Author Jeong."

"Hemingway came all the way here?"

"I heard it from a friend who knows the history of this village well."

Author Jeong could not know at once for what reason Hemingway had come all the way to Montafon, but he found it more than a little intriguing. In high school he had devoured Hemingway's novels *The Old Man and the Sea*, *A Farewell to Arms*, and *For Whom the Bell Tolls*, and had been captivated by the clarity of his short sentences and his descriptions of action. Perhaps for that reason, there were acquaintances who said that the shadow of Hemingway flickered through works such as *Gwangju Arirang*, Author Jeong's novel taking the May 18 Gwangju People's Uprising as its subject.

Then Mr. Willi led the party to a building beside the stream.

"This is the house where I took clarinet lessons when I was seven. It had a grand piano, something rare in Montafon. But the old teacher made me miserable. While teaching me how to play the clarinet, whenever I made a mistake he would punish me at every turn, pulling my ears and the like. It made me want to give up music. Fortunately, my father had taught himself to play various instruments, and I was happy I could take music lessons from him."

Mr. Willi said that his father, who had grown up a war orphan during the Second World War, could not only play many instruments but also compose, and was so deft with his hands that he could even repair Montafon's traditional wardrobes. Then the party followed Mr. Willi as far as the bridge over the stream.

"Watching the forceful waters of this stream, I conceived the second movement of *Jeong* (情)."

The stream, rising in the foothills of the Alps, was jade-colored, and though its volume was not great, it flowed with a lively brightness. To say that he conceived the second movement of *Jeong* while looking at this water meant, if one were to understand it through the *Ten Ox-Herding Pictures*, that like a cowherd discovering the ox's footprints, Mr. Willi had at last glimpsed the first clue to the music he had been seeking.

"Thinking of it now, I feel that your music, Mr. Willi, is a gift given by your father and by the natural world of the Alpine Montafon."

“My mother too was a war orphan, so she had no chance to study and knew little about music. But her interest cannot be left out either. After attending one of my premieres, she would say, ‘This piece will be performed many times,’ or, ‘This piece must wait a little longer for its time,’ and she was almost always right.”

The Italian restaurant Mr. Willi had reserved was about a ten-minute walk from the bridge over the stream. The streets were quiet, but inside the dim restaurant it was crowded with customers. The party followed the waiter to a table at the back of the restaurant and sat down. Author Jeong and his wife had wanted to order the spaghetti alle vongole they had often eaten while traveling in Italy, but it was not on the menu. With no other choice, Chairwoman Kwon ordered them a salty kind of spaghetti instead. While they ate, Mr. Willi spoke his own views on music, and Author Jeong listened closely.

“Music exists at the boundary between what is seen and unseen. A musician is one who makes that visible.”

He also spoke of the experience of fighting illness in his youth that had brought him to awakening.

“When I was seventeen and suffering from an incurable disease, I was treated so often that there was hardly any place left in my arms and legs for a needle. Then one day, all at once, I began to watch calmly the self that had left behind the pain of the body.”

As if to console him, Author Jeong said,

“To look objectively at yourself after leaving behind such extreme bodily pain, might that not mean that, having become no-self (無我, *mua*), you became one with the world?”

Chairwoman Kwon laughed and said it was difficult to interpret. But Mr. Willi and Author Jeong communicated without any real difficulty. Author Jeong expressed himself with only a few English words he knew, and Mr. Willi understood him at once.

Just then some Roma musicians came in. One played the violin, and another sang “*Bella Ciao*” in lively fashion. Mr. Willi then handed five euros to the musician holding his hat upside down.

“Here in Montafon, the Italian border is very close. So Roma musicians sometimes make their way all the way over here.”

The musicians went from table to table, playing the violin, singing, and collecting tips. To the strains of their violin, the Montafon night quietly deepened.

Deep Conversations with Mr. Willi 1

After spending a night at Hotel Bürgerhof, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park woke before dawn. The moon was still hanging above the peaks of Montafon, a half moon gone faint in the first light. Through the large window of their room, the mountain facing them, a ridge of the Alps, seemed close at hand. These were the mountains of the Alpine Montafon valley. Author Jeong, who had risen first, walked to the window and suddenly cried out.

“Sweetheart, look at that mountain!”

“What is it?”

“The painting on the folding fan by painter Kim Yangsu looks exactly like the mountain in front of us.”

The half moon floating above the bluish peaks washed with dawn, and the white stream running almost vertically down between the slopes to the right, looked astonishingly like the painting on the folding fan. Although Author Jeong had never told painter Kim Yangsu that he would be traveling to the Alpine Montafon and asked him to paint its scenery, the fact that the painter depicted Montafon's moon and mountains without knowing Montafon at all could only be explained as his inspiration. Besides, was not the title of the novel Author Jeong had already begun serializing *Montafon Moonlight*? It could only have been an intersection wrought in the unconscious of Author Jeong, Mr. Willi, and painter Kim Yangsu.

Mrs. Park slipped the folding fan into her handbag. Author Jeong was curious to see how Mr. Willi would react upon receiving the folding fan as a gift. Chairwoman Kwon, who had already been given a folding fan painted with azaleas in full bloom, might be less surprised. At the appointed hour of nine, Chairwoman Kwon also came down to the hotel lobby. Author Jeong, Mrs. Park, and Chairwoman Kwon stepped outside the hotel, where red geraniums were blooming vividly, and waited for Mr. Willi. To the left of the road stood a white church with a small bell tower. To reach Mr. Willi's house one had to go down the road to the right. Beyond the cliff on the

mountainside lay the village of St. Anton, where he lived. After Mr. Willi and Chairwoman Kwon exchanged morning greetings, Mr. Willi said,

“I’m not sure how the weather will turn out. Montafon weather is very fickle.”

“We’ll be doing nothing but interviews at your house all day, Mr. Willi, so it should be fine.”

Before long, the party drove down to the village of St. Anton in Mr. Willi’s car. About ten minutes later they arrived at his house, with its little garden. They immediately climbed the exterior wooden staircase to the second floor. To Author Jeong, the interior felt more familiar than it had on his 2015 visit.

The piano on the left side of the hallway leading to the living room stood where it had always been. High on the wall opposite the entrance, a new addition caught his eye: a mungnando (墨蘭圖), an ink orchid painting, a type of Korean painting. Its Chinese character inscription, Dahyang mali (茶香萬里), meant that the fragrance of tea travels ten thousand li.

On the left side of the living room stood a long cabinet that looked as though it had been made by Mr. Willi’s father, who had also been a carpenter, and on top of it the first thing to catch the eye was the ceramic owl Mrs. Park had given him in 2015. On the wall above the cabinet, the large, dreamlike, surrealist oil painting they had seen before still seemed to welcome Author Jeong and Mrs. Park. On the wall nearby to the right, the figure of Jesus nailed to the cross, carved by Mr. Willi’s grandfather, remained in place as well. In the living room and dining room hung two Korean paintings they had not seen before. One was a Korean painting depicting three pine trees, and the other was a miindo (美人圖), a portrait of a beauty in hanbok holding a fan. On the wall right beside the dining-room door there was another figure of Jesus, this one by Mr. Willi’s father, and in the dining room there was also a painting simply propped on the floor, as if there were nowhere to hang it. It showed musicians playing their instruments while a dancing boy (mudong) performed, reminiscent of Kim Hongdo’s genre paintings. Not only that, in a corner of the dining room there was also a doll of a woman in hanbok playing the geomungo.

Looking at this all, it was clear that Mr. Willi had a great fondness for things Korean. Although he had many devoted fans in Japan, the paintings and dolls in his own house had all, without exception, been brought from Korea. As he himself had confessed, there was no telling whether he really had been Korean in a past life. Perhaps because of the Korean paintings, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park felt at ease. Before beginning the interview, Author Jeong presented Mr. Willi with the folding fan he had brought. He said,

“This is a folding fan I received from painter Kim Yangsu in Korea. But the picture on it is remarkably like the mountains of Montafon. It’s astonishing.”

“Ah, I see. I would like to know the painter’s background in detail.”

“He used to teach at a university, but now he has gone down to his hometown of Jindo as a full-time painter who does nothing but paint. I will have Chairwoman Kwon write out his biography for you separately.”

The party sat at the round table in the living room and spent a while taking in the view beyond the large window. The village beyond the window was impeccably clean. Mr. Willi explained that because Europeans visited the Montafon valley, even at around a thousand meters above sea level, there were many hotels and guesthouses, all doing brisk business year-round.

Rain clouds were already hanging on the sharp peaks. The village on the slope across from them kept appearing and disappearing beneath avalanche-like banks of mist. It was as though the mountain spirit of Montafon were performing magic for Author Jeong and Mrs. Park. Suddenly Chairwoman Kwon turned to Author Jeong and apologized.

“There is something I must apologize to you for, Mr. Jeong.”

“What is it?”

“It was when I went to Korea in 2017 and visited your home in Hwasun. You gave me a book to pass on to Mr. Willi and signed it for him.”

“Did I? What book was it?”

“It was a very lovely Seon dongwha (禪童話), or Seon fairy tale, *The Fool Novice*. But when I returned to Austria, I left it in my room and completely forgot about it. I happened to come across it this time and brought it along.”

Before handing *The Fool Novice* to Mr. Willi, Chairwoman Kwon opened the book to the page Author Jeong had signed and showed it to him. Sure enough, Author Jeong’s inscription read as follows.

To Mr. Willi,

A single raindrop is the universe,
and the universe is a single raindrop.

August 4, 2017

Sincerely, Jeong Chanju

When Chairwoman Kwon translated Author Jeong’s inscription into German for Mr. Willi, he smiled and said,

“These are true words. I agree. My own life in music began, too, with the sound of a single raindrop I heard on the Inn River at Innsbruck.”

Mrs. Park said,

“So, Chairwoman Kwon didn’t give Mr. Willi this book even when we came to Vienna in 2018.”

“No, it is even better that Chairwoman Kwon brought it now. I wrote, ‘A single raindrop is the universe,’ as my own interpretation of the sound of raindrops Mr. Willi heard in his despair at seventeen. If there is time today, even though I have heard it many times, I would like to hear that story once again.”

At Mrs. Park’s words, Author Jeong answered that things had turned out for the better. Then Chairwoman Kwon, looking apologetic, said,

“As a gesture of apology, I will translate *The Fool Novice* into German and read it aloud right here.”

Chairwoman Kwon began to read *The Fool Novice* slowly and distinctly. Mr. Willi listened, resting his chin on one hand.

“The temple was already more than five hundred years old. The pillars of the Dharma Hall were deeply furrowed with wrinkles, and the places where knots had once been had rotted through, leaving holes like a *moktak* (wooden bell). In spring, chickadees sometimes raised their young in those holes. There were times when a monk plugged the holes up, saying the hall was too noisy, but thanks to the child, the chickadee mothers would always return to raise their chicks. On bright moonlit nights, the child secretly opened the holes again behind the monks’ backs.

The room where the monks studied was just as worn. Wild grasses sprouted and bloomed between the broken roof tiles. Yellow dandelions flowered about and sometimes purple thistles bloomed. Evening primroses opened their petals in the daytime and yawned, only to be caught by the child.

There were many mice in the ceiling of the monks’ old room as well. Their squeaking could be heard at all hours.

“Squeak, squeak squeeek squeak.”

At mealtimes the mice grew even noisier, because the smell of sannamul (wild mountain greens), ssukguk (mugwort soup), and songi (pine mushrooms) set out in the monks’ alms bowls spread through the whole ceiling. The monks never fed the mice, not ever. They said the act of stealing food in secret was the mice’s karma (eob, 業). They believed that only by working off that “karma of stealing food” themselves, as if doing homework, could the mice be reborn in bodies better than a mouse’s. So, sorry as they were, they said they could not help them.

“They must be hungry. Wouldn’t it be wonderful if, for just one day, we could set a table for the mice.”

It was precisely at this passage that light came into Mr. Willi’s eyes. After Chairwoman Kwon finished translating and reading the rest of *The Fool Novice* into German, Author Jeong offered a remark.

“The child's heart is precisely the Buddha's heart. I believe that your heart, Mr. Willi, is the very heart of the foolish novice in the fairy tale.”

Mrs. Park said with a laugh,

“You are a foolish grown-up, Mr. Willi, a foolish composer. My husband is a fool too. He knows nothing but writing. Even now, he doesn't know how to use a bank card.”

“The title of the storybook gives me chills. *The Fool Novice*... Mr. Willi, you seem almost like a foolish novice who insists on silence. Your heart is like that of an innocent child.”

“That is right. I wrote the fairy tale because I wanted to say how important silence is. In the story, the child's silence may be the same thing as Mr. Willi's absolute stillness.”

At that moment Chairwoman Kwon brought refreshments out from the dining room.

“This is a cake our Frida made. It is called a Linzertorte. Linz is the city we passed through yesterday. According to the historical record, the Linzertorte is said to be the oldest cake in the world.”

Frida was Mr. Willi's second partner, and Author Jeong and Mrs. Park had also met her in 2015. They had eaten together at a Thai restaurant; she was a woman with one son, and because of work commitments she had not been able to join them for the Montafon folk play. Chairwoman Kwon said that when Frida heard Author Jeong and Mrs. Park were coming to Montafon this time, she had baked the Linzertorte herself and sent it over.

Deep Conversations with Mr. Willi 2

The Linz cake Frida had sent was cut by Chairwoman Kwon and shared out among Mr. Willi, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park. She also brewed coffee in the kitchen where the sink was and poured some into each person's cup. Mr. Willi, who ate only one meal a day, said that he did not need lunch himself but offered to cook for Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, but the couple felt the cake alone would serve as lunch. Author Jeong said,

“No, the cake alone will do for lunch.”

“I eat only once a day, but Korean food is so delicious I could eat it three times.”

“In that case, next time we come, we'll bring instant rice, kimchi, gim, and gochujang.”

In Mrs. Park's suitcase there were single-serving bowls of instant rice that could be heated quickly in the microwave, along with vacuum-packed spicy kimchi, savory gim, and hot gochujang in a tube. They had brought them from Korea to eat whenever they grew tired of European food. While they were eating cake, Chairwoman Kwon said,

“Now let's talk about something fun. Mr. Willi, what was the name of the girlfriend you had when you were in school in Montafon?”

“A girlfriend? From the time I was fifteen until I was seventeen, I would spend two months at a time in the hospital in Innsbruck and then come back to Montafon, so I wasn't in a position to have a girlfriend.”

“So it was a repeated cycle of two months in the hospital, then discharge, then home again.”

At Author Jeong's words, Mr. Willi said,

“From the age of fifteen, I thought, If this goes on, I'll end up on a road of death from which I will never come home again. It made me terribly sad. Still, I held onto a sliver of hope: I will overcome this illness. I will survive. In any case, I went back and forth between the hospital and home, and attended school only in form. Thanks to my homeroom teacher and my friends, I somehow managed to finish school. But because I was absent so often, I didn't have the chance to get close to my classmates one by one.

Even so, my classmates wrote me letters to comfort me. Even now, when I read those letters, my chest tightens and tears come to my eyes.”

“Were they saying things like, ‘We’ll pray to God that you recover,’ and so on?”

“Most of them said, ‘We feel terribly lonely without you. We miss you.’”

“In Korean terms it sounds like the equivalent of high school. What kind of help did your homeroom teacher and your friends give you?”

“In Austria, high school goes on until age eighteen, and the teachers and students treated me with tremendous understanding. One day my homeroom teacher said, ‘Graduation is not far off, so don’t come to school; stay at home.’ The students helped me too. Montafon was the countryside, so the school was small and there were not many students. There were thirty-six students in our year in all, four girls and the rest boys. The ones who helped me were the girls. Because I couldn’t come to school often, those four girls copied down what the teachers taught and gave it to me. I studied on my own from their notes. Thanks to them, I was able to keep up good grades without attending classes.”

Thanks to the kindness of those Montafon schoolgirls, Mr. Willi had been able to keep the grades he needed to go to university. Author Jeong asked another question.

“What did you do at home besides study? It must have been tedious at times.”

“I spent a great deal of time alone, both in the hospital and at home. So from a certain day onward, I began stopping by the bookshop in Montafon. It wasn’t because there was any particular book I wanted to buy. I would buy and read whatever book happened to catch my eye. Without any knowledge of books, I simply bought and read the ones my hand went to without my even knowing it.

At one time, too, I didn’t have a record player. Then one day I bought one, and after that I tried to collect as many records as I could. As I listened to and learned from all that recorded music, I wanted to hold fast to the belief that I would live a long, long time.”

Author Jeong thought that Mr. Willi’s unconscious purchases at the bookshop, and his urge to collect many records after buying a record player, were both perhaps ways of trying to sustain a faith in life itself, the faith that “I will live a long time.” His story was shot through with the desperate wish to escape an incurable illness.

“There were happy moments too.”

“So this isn’t a hospital story.”

“That’s right.”

Mr. Willi finished the coffee remaining in his cup. Then he propped his chin on his hand and let his eyes drift into the air. It was his habit whenever he summoned up some distant corner of his past. At such moments, tears would gather at his eyes when the memory was sad, while a smile would play there when it was joyful. This time there was a smile not only in his eyes but at the corners of his mouth.

"When I was seventeen, I spent a month in London, England. There was a girl among the students named Ulli. Her full name was Ulrike, but Ulli was her nickname. All of a sudden Ulli asked me, 'Hey, you know, I'm going to England for a month. Would you like to come too?'"

"She must have been one of the girls who was good at taking notes."

"No, someone else was the good note-taker. Ha ha ha."

Author Jeong said it as if he had guessed the answer, but Mr. Willi laughed and immediately waved his hand. Then he went on with the story.

"Ulli said that two of her relatives lived in London: she would stay with one, and I could stay with the other. We would live separately for a month, then meet at the airport on the last day, board the plane, and return to Montafon together."

"So that is how you ended up going to England."

However, on the promised last day, Mr. Willi did not get on the plane with Ulli. She never appeared at the airport. The next time Ulli turned up in Montafon was the day before the new term began. She had found herself a boyfriend and stayed in London until then before returning.

"Ulli's boyfriend drove a splendid car trimmed in wood. Every day he took Ulli around London in it, and in the evening he would bring her back to her relatives' house. In the end, Ulli later married that boyfriend, and I heard that she now lives in America. Ulli has a son, and his name is Amadeus."

"Ha ha ha..."

The moment Mr. Willi mentioned the name of Ulli's son, not only Author Jeong and Mrs. Park but even Chairwoman Kwon burst out laughing. Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart is one of the greatest composers Austria boasts of. How could they not laugh, when of all names Ulli's son was called Amadeus? As though the stopper had come out, Mr. Willi went on in high spirits.

"I have a souvenir I brought back from London. I discovered it while walking down a certain street—it was a lane lined with record shops. With the little spending money I had left, I bought a symphony by Anton Bruckner. I spent every last coin on it, thinking that one day I would listen to it all. There is still a symphony from that purchase that I have never listened to. Ha ha ha."

Since it was an incident from more than fifty years ago, it was something Mr. Willi could laugh about. Chairwoman Kwon and Author Jeong and Mrs. Park laughed along with him.

“Our house too is packed tight with composers' records. When I grow old, I suppose I'll have a vast amount of time. Then I'll have no choice but to listen to them all. Ha ha ha.”

Author Jeong thought this would remain in his memory as the day he had laughed most during his interviews with Mr. Willi. When they met in 2015 or 2018, Mr. Willi's musical world had been too profound, and the pain of his youth spent with an incurable illness had pressed on them too heavily for them to laugh out loud as they had today.

Again, as they went on talking, the story of Mr. Willi's youth returned, yet it did not cast Author Jeong and Mrs. Park into gloom. They had heard it several times since 2015, and so they had come to understand his unhappy adolescence with a certain objectivity. The story of how, by the Inn River in Innsbruck, he heard the sound of raindrops at the very moment thunder and lightning split the sky darkened with storm clouds, and how, even after hearing a despairing diagnosis at the Zurich hospital he had gone to with his father in hope, he nevertheless believed, “I will live”—these stories too they listened to calmly.

The interview with Mr. Willi ended at around three in the afternoon. After driving Chairwoman Kwon and Author Jeong and Mrs. Park back to the hotel, he said,

“I'll come back to the hotel at six this evening.”

Chairwoman Kwon and Author Jeong and Mrs. Park rested at the hotel. Even though it was already six in the evening, Mr. Willi was planning to guide them to the Posthotel Taube in the Montafon valley. Chairwoman Kwon explained that because Montafon had the phenomenon of white nights, it stayed light until nine p.m. As they rested, Author Jeong carefully noted down in his notebook the things he and Mr. Willi had said to each other.

When six o'clock came, Mr. Willi drove up to the hotel in his car. The party took the winding paved mountain road to the Posthotel Taube. When they arrived at the Taube, they went into the hotel café and ordered coffee and bread. There were only one or two other guests in the café. Chairwoman Kwon said,

“If it were ski season, it would be bustling.”

Just then Mr. Willi pointed to the open ground outside the building.

“The hotel owner is thinking of building a concert hall there and naming it after me.”

The hotel owner, too, was evidently a lover of music. Mr. Willi said he was the first person ever to propose building a concert hall in Montafon bearing his name. Yet Author Jeong could not help thinking it would be a long time in coming. Meaningful things, after all, are beset by that many twists and turns and are always slow to come to fruition.

The Figure of Jesus

The next day.

Author Jeong and Mrs. Park went once more to Mr. Willi's house. As soon as they entered, Mr. Willi sat down on the piano bench and explained to them the sound of raindrops he had heard on the Inn River in Innsbruck when he was seventeen.

"Now, the first raindrop fell with a soft tap into the flowing water of the Inn. In that moment I was able to hear something very unusual. It was a resonance, a sound at a fixed pitch. But I could not make sense of the resonance or the tone at all. Still, that resonance and sound seized me. Some time passed. Then I had the chance to play the piano. I began playing like this, trying to find that resonance and sound on the piano."

Mr. Willi pressed the keys as he spoke.

"Like this, pressing the keys one after another with my fingers, I worked for a long time to find the resonance and sound I remembered listening by the river. Then at a certain moment, I realized it was not one note but two. It was never a single note; it was two notes with two different characters. One was lower, and the other was higher. The lower note sounded like a cello, and the slightly higher one like a clarinet. It was like the sound made when a raindrop falls into the river, the sound of it springing back up again, and the sound of the raindrop entering the water. I'll recreate the sound of the raindrop on the piano now."

Mr. Willi simultaneously pressed the lower note, the C key, which he said a cello could make, and the higher note, the G key an octave above it, which he said could be expressed by a clarinet. Then he said,

"The piano sound I just played is the all-inclusive sound of everything contained in the exact moment when that raindrop fell. As you said, Author Jeong, one drop of water is the universe, and the universe is one drop of water."

"So your raindrop and my water drop are connected like that."

“What you just heard in the piano note contains many things. I would not claim it is everything. But, for example, just as the universe holds many stars, a single note can hold many sounds.”

Mr. Willi was deeply serious.

“In any case, after several months I found on the piano a note that contained the sound of a raindrop falling into the river, the sound of it bouncing off the water, and the sound of it being absorbed by the river. I found the sound of the cello and the clarinet in the piano.”

“A cello and a clarinet? Honestly, I don’t quite understand.”

“I had found that sound in which the cello and clarinet sounds had completely ripened together and were heard as one whole. For months, there were days when I forgot even to eat. I kept searching for that sound, searching and searching again.”

“How did you feel after discovering the sound of the cello and clarinet? Didn’t you at least dance?”

“I did nothing.”

Author Jeong and Mr. Willi smiled as they spoke back and forth.

“I was satisfied simply because I had found what I was looking for.”

“After you discovered that sound, how did the world feel when you looked at it?”

“*In dir etwas*, something within you. That was all I felt: there was something inside me.”

“Did you not feel you wanted to compose?”

“At that time, I had no thought of wanting to become a composer. Not the slightest. I had found the sound of the raindrop, so I simply felt relieved. Since I had found what I had been searching for, I thought only, ‘Now it’s done.’ What changed in me was that a different version of seeing this world had opened.” When lunchtime came, Chairwoman Kwon moved the instant rice Mrs. Park had brought, along with kimchi, gim, and gochujang, to the dining table. Mr. Willi mixed the microwaved instant rice with kimchi and gochujang and ate it with relish. But he did not touch the gim. He did not even try a taste. It seemed he felt some resistance toward the unfamiliar dark green sheet. Chairwoman Kwon said,

“People here in Montafon probably don’t know gim. It must feel burdensome to eat something they are seeing for the first time. Still, kimchi has become globalized, so Austrians eat it well too.”

Mr. Willi pronounced “kimchi” exactly. When they had taken a commemorative photograph at the entrance of the Posthotel Taube, too, he had made Author Jeong smile by saying “kimchi.”

After lunch, the party sat around the round table in the living room and spent about an hour listening to music. Mr. Willi put CDs of his own compositions into the stereo CD player and gave brief explanations.

“The opening of the first piece is played by a female clarinetist from Israel. She is a very famous musician.”

The opening of the piece began low and slowly, with a deep tone like a temple bell. Author Jeong said what he felt as he listened.

“It sounds like someone praying.”

“It is a drum sound, but yes, it is like that.”

As the CD listening was drawing to an end, Mr. Willi came out of his bedroom carrying a crucifixion figure of Jesus. The work on the living room wall had been carved by Mr. Willi’s grandfather, and the work on the dining-room wall by his father; Author Jeong and Mrs. Park wondered who had carved this crucifixion figure he had brought out now. Mr. Willi said,

“This work was carved by my great-grandfather.”

“Your great-grandfather, grandfather, and father, three generations, all carved crucifixion figures of Jesus. That is an extraordinary family tradition.”

“They were all people of deep faith. And they must also have been very gifted with their hands.”

“Seeing that you keep images of Jesus in the living room, dining room, and bedroom, Mr. Willi, I think your faith must be deep as well.”

“My father said it was made by cutting the hardest wood in the Montafon forest. If the wood was that hard, he must have broken several knives.”

If the wood had been soft, it would surely have been spruce; if it was hard, it must have been oak or beech. Since the material was said to be hard wood, it must, as Mr. Willi said, have been difficult enough to carve that knives would break against it.

“My great-grandfather is said to have carved as many as eight crucifixion figures of Jesus. One of them had gone to a certain wealthy man, and my father bought it back by adding a considerable sum of money to pieces of furniture he had made with his own hands. That was how exceptional my great-grandfather’s carving was.”

Indeed, even to Author Jeong’s eye, the carving was astonishing. The suffering expression on Jesus’s face, the even teeth visible between his lips, and the fingernails and toenails of his nailed hands and feet were all carved with vivid clarity.

“Whenever I see the figure of Jesus crucified, the Buddha’s extreme ascetic practice overlaps with it in my mind.”

“Ah, I see.”

“Jesus was resurrected, and Siddhartha attained Buddhahood. Thinking of it that way, perhaps suffering is an energy of blessing, like love opening through tears. Mr. Willi, your life in music also began when, in the suffering of an incurable illness, you encountered that raindrop.”

At the end of Author Jeong’s words, Mr. Willi closed his eyes. His expression seemed hesitant. Or perhaps the words “incurable illness” had summoned something within him. Presently Mr. Willi said,

“If you do not want to hear the story I am about to tell, I will not tell it. It is something that truly happened to me, but it is so mysterious and religious that I am cautious.”

“How could I, for any reason or on what grounds, deny what you’ve said happened to you? I want to hear it.”

Mr. Willi began his story, sadly, as though forcing himself to summon the memory. It was six months before he was discharged from Innsbruck General Hospital after receiving the doctor’s opinion that recovery was impossible. Mr. Willi’s health was at its worst. Because he had received radiation treatment for two years to treat the cancer that had spread through his whole body, he could not even swallow a drop of water properly.

To return to Montafon, Mr. Willi boarded a train at Innsbruck station. Since he deliberately did not want to meet anyone, he got into a carriage where no passengers were boarding. Once on the train, he deliberately went to the last carriage, thinking it would be quiet. But just as the train was about to move, a middle-aged woman climbed into that last carriage. As if she were a relative, she kept talking to him. When Mr. Willi did not answer, the last carriage sank into silence. About an hour passed before the woman began preparing to get off the train. It was two or three minutes before they parted. Then Mr. Willi, without knowing why, said to her,

“You have one daughter and one son.”

Mr. Willi told her the birthdays of her daughter and son and asked whether he was right.

“You are right. But you are sick with a disease that will kill you.”

The woman wrote down a telephone number and said,

“Call this number. You will be able to receive help.”

Mr. Willi was confused as to whether the brief conversation he had had with the woman was real or unreal. If he told anyone, they might be startled or laugh at him. So he said nothing, not even to his father, and kept his mouth shut. When he came home, Mr. Willi’s father, far from despairing, showed even greater resolve.

“Willi, now let us find our own path by which you can recover. I will spare no means or method to find that path. If necessary, I will sell this house and put everything in order to restore you to health.”

So after asking here and there, the place he went with his father was a hospital in Zurich. But after all the tests were finished, the female doctor's opinion was the same as that of the doctor at Innsbruck General Hospital. The cancer had spread from his joints to his esophagus. Since the cancer had spread throughout his body, she stated flatly that there was now no method of treatment. In that moment, stillness flowed through the hospital room. The air seemed to have turned into desolate silence. Then a voice that did not seem to be human came to him.

"Herbert, you will become healthy."

Mr. Willi could not know the reason either, but certainty arose in him. After returning home, he tried gradually to reduce the pills he was taking. It was the only method left to him. But he had become dependent on the medication and could not live even for a moment without taking it. When the effect wore off, the joints in his arms and legs hurt enough to drive him nearly mad. Still, Mr. Willi decided to reduce the number of pills by one every day. It was an attempt to stop taking them altogether once the pain in his joints and throughout his body disappeared. His effort had an effect. There was even a day when the pain in his body disappeared though he had taken no pills at all. Unfortunately, that condition lasted only for that day.

Pater von Lama

As he treated himself at home, Mr. Willi thought of the middle-aged woman he had met on the train a few months earlier. The memo with the telephone number she had given him came to mind. Mr. Willi found the memo and decided to call, as though he were finally doing homework he had put off. No name or surname was written on the memo. There was only a telephone number. Calming his trembling heart, Mr. Willi dialed. The person who answered was a man.

“A woman gave me this telephone number and told me I could receive help,” he said. “I know nothing about the person who has answered. My name is Willi, and I live in the village of St. Anton in Montafon.”

“I am Pater von Lama. When can you come to me?”

“As soon as possible.”

“Then come tomorrow.”

With a name like Lama, Mr. Willi thought, he must be a Catholic priest. He received the priest’s Innsbruck address over the telephone. The next day, Mr. Willi took the train from Bludenz station to Innsbruck. As he gazed through the train window at the distant mountains, certain houses appeared before him. There were benches, and he saw a house with a great deal of furniture. In one room of that house, a man was sitting in a chair before a large desk. Such scenes appeared for about ten minutes, then vanished.

“I was simply looking through the train window at the mountains in the distance, not thinking anything special at all, and yet those scenes appeared to me.”

In any case, once he arrived in Innsbruck, Mr. Willi called a taxi and went to the address the man had given him. He lived in a monastery. When Mr. Willi entered through the monastery gate, he saw a series of different rooms. Then the room he had seen from the train caught his eye. He went toward it. In front of the door, he hesitated, wondering whether to knock. Just then, he heard an old man’s voice.

“Come in.”

The moment he entered, Mr. Willi was certain it was the room he had seen from the train. The man sitting in the chair was an old priest. The priest was over ninety, and because moving about was difficult for him, he seemed to spend his days only in that room. For a while, Mr. Willi sat respectfully on a small chair beside the door, his two hands folded. Then the old priest told him to stand. The priest rose from his chair and came toward him. His build was almost the same as Mr. Willi's. The priest stretched his left hand over Mr. Willi's head and placed his right hand low on Mr. Willi's back. And then it happened. Mr. Willi fell into an unconscious state in which he did not know whether he was standing, lying down, or sitting. He only felt that his body was hot.

"Suddenly I existed alone inside a chamber of searing heat, though I did not know what sort of place it was. I felt I was certainly existing somewhere other than here. It was very bright there, and I was not alone."

Then he heard a gentle voice, like an echo.

"There is work for us to do. Will you go back and do yours? I have many matters to resolve. I must finish my assignment."

Only then did Mr. Willi return to reality. He saw the old priest, who told him to sit. The old priest then went outside, brought in a glass of water, and told Mr. Willi to drink it; then he repeated the same action twice more. As he did, the old priest said,

"God wills it, and your illness will be healed."

Each time Mr. Willi drank, it was so difficult that he appealed to the old priest.

"I cannot possibly drink it."

The first glass seemed like oily water, the second like vinegar water, and the third like salt water.

"You must drink it."

Whenever Mr. Willi said he could not drink it, the priest made the sign of the cross and urged him firmly. After he finally drank all three glasses and returned home, Mr. Willi deliberately tried not to take the pills he had been taking. Since the doctor's prescription had not cured him, he wanted to give even this a try. A month later, he called the priest again and went to the monastery. Again the priest gave him three glasses of holy water. Another month later, Mr. Willi visited the priest once more and, as before, drank three glasses of holy water.

That time, thinking that next time he would drink not oily water, vinegar water, or salt water but just plain water, Mr. Willi left the monastery to go home, then crossed to the small church opposite it. There he knelt and prayed.

"Lord, I offer myself to you."

He prayed that way in the sense that he had been born again, that he had received a new life. Mr. Willi confessed this to Author Jeong, Mrs. Park, and Chairwoman Kwon.

“If the One who gave me new life has a purpose, then I must be a conduit. If there is work for me to do, then I live only within that task.”

For Mr. Willi, who had lived in suffering beyond imagination, it was a natural conclusion. Author Jeong had heard several times about Mr. Willi’s painful youth. Every day he had blood drawn, and depending on the results, he went back and forth between the hospital and school. When he went to the hospital, he invariably received radiation treatment.

In the six-person hospital room, patients suffering from incurable illnesses died after undergoing surgery. Even a very strong laborer died. After waking from anesthesia, the laborer shouted in agony and cried out to Mr. Willi, “Never have surgery.” When the doctor asked whether he would consent to surgery, Mr. Willi answered “No” in place of his father; that situation had been nothing short of hell.

Author Jeong felt that Mr. Willi was like a Catholic monk.

“Hearing you say that you live according to God’s purpose, I can understand why you went to seminary, Mr. Willi.”

“But I do not say God. I do not often use the word itself. Because that word is so abused and misused in this world, I would rather dare to say the Creator.”

“In any case, it seems the priest’s influence was great.”

“Yes. The raindrop on the Inn River gave me the experience of crossing from this visible world into another world that cannot be seen. And after meeting the priest, I recovered my health and have lived a new life within the task given to me, within the work that is mine to do.”

“Then we should say that after meeting the priest, you were cured of your illness.”

“Yes, that is right. From then on, I did not go to the hospital. Meanwhile, I began to hear the sounds of nature. When I walked and looked at a tree, I heard the tree’s sound; when I looked at an object, that was the beginning of a history in which I could hear the sounds of things.”

“Hearing that, the woman you met on the train seems like an angel. Could she have been an angel transformed into an ordinary woman? In Buddhism, Avalokitesvara (K. Gwanseeum, C. Guanshiyin) Bodhisattva appears in many forms in order to fulfill someone’s wish. It is also said that Avalokitesvara has eyes that see all things in the world and ears that hear its sounds.”

At Author Jeong’s words, Mr. Willi only smiled. He neither affirmed nor denied them.

After the afternoon interview, Author Jeong, Mrs. Park, and Chairwoman Kwon returned to the hotel and rested again as they had the day before until six in the evening. This was because they were going to visit the log house in the Montafon mountains where Mr. Willi had lived in seclusion for five or six years while composing. Around six, however, the weather suddenly turned cloudy. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park took umbrellas and went down to the hotel lobby. Mr. Willi was punctual. He was already waiting in the hotel parking lot before 6:10. Prior to setting out, he said,

"I would like to show you the place where I composed. The log house we are visiting today is the villa of a wealthy family in Montafon. My father once made furniture for that house, so they are close to us through that *inyeon* (karmic connection). When I asked, they gladly lent it to me for several years."

"What pieces did you compose at that villa?"

"I composed the opera *Brother of Sleep* and *Encounter* there."

"Ah, in Korea it is known as *Sleeping Brother*, but it is *Brother of Sleep*."

"That's right. Since it means that sleep and the protagonist Elias are brothers, *Brother of Sleep* is more accurate. And after spending years notating the sounds of nature that came from the area around the log house, I was commissioned to write a piece for the Vienna Philharmonic Orchestra's 150th anniversary and composed *Encounter*."

As the car entered the mountains, rain began to fall in a steady drizzle. The log house where Mr. Willi had stayed to compose for five or six years was unexpectedly close. It seemed enclosed within the mountains. White veil-like rain clouds had descended all the way to the slopes and covered the spruce forest, but fortunately the log house stood clearly revealed. There were two buildings, divided by a single spruce tree. The upper building was a shed where firewood had been stacked neatly, and the lower building was a three-room residential log house. Mr. Willi opened his umbrella and went first toward the residential log house, then opened the wooden door. The party looked once around the inside of the log house, where there was a fireplace and a bed, and came back out. As Author Jeong was studying the stuffed rooster on the windowsill beside the entrance, Mr. Willi said,

"It is the mascot used during the Montafon festival. A rooster that survives the cold climate of the Alps symbolizes tenacious life-force."

Even though it was eight in the evening, the slopes of the Alps around Montafon were bright with the white-night phenomenon. Mr. Willi drove the party deeper into the mountains. When they arrived at a gorge and got out of the car, rain clouds wrapped around them. The cold droplets felt as if they might freeze Author Jeong and Mrs. Park at any moment. Yet Mr. Willi,

adapted to the Alpine climate, was untroubled in only a thin jumper and jeans, like the strong Montafon rooster they had just seen.

“This is the very place that gave me inspiration when I composed the opera *Brother of Sleep*. On that rock, young Elias came down from heaven and cried out, ‘What is my other half?’”

Mr. Willi stamped his foot vividly as he explained. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park felt their bodies slowly freezing, but because Mr. Willi was explaining with such sincerity, they could not bring themselves to say they wanted to get back into the car.

“The half Elias cried out for—is it not an invisible soul?”

“It is love.”

“Then the theme of *Brother of Sleep* is love.”

“Yes.”

Saying this was the last Alpine mountain village, Mr. Willi put the party back into the car and guided them all the way to the dead end of the road. There were a few houses there where cattle were raised. Mr. Willi explained that the mountain villagers made their living by producing cheese from the milk of cows they grazed. But Author Jeong and Mrs. Park had dressed lightly, prepared only for Vienna’s weather, and could think only of descending quickly. Seeing the two of them shivering, Chairwoman Kwon urged them to stay inside the car. Author Jeong, unlike Mr. Willi, grew anxious, worried that if he caught a cold the next stage of the journey might be affected.

The Basilica's Baroque Concert

Around eleven in the morning, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park went once again to Mr. Willi's house. They went later than on previous mornings because Mr. Willi had been considerate, thinking Author Jeong's party must be tired from having explored such places as the log house where he had composed *Encounter* and the deep Montafon valley that had inspired his opera *Brother of Sleep*. But perhaps because Author Jeong and Mrs. Park had breathed Montafon's pure air, they did not feel tired in the least.

Author Jeong, Mrs. Park, and Chairwoman Kwon entered the living room of Mr. Willi's house. As soon as they sat down, Mr. Willi suggested they go to Bodensee (Lake Constance), the largest lake in central Europe. He had already changed into outdoor clothes. He was dressed formally, though without a tie. It was the first time they had seen him in a suit since meeting him in 2015.

"You aren't wearing a jumper today."

Mr. Willi usually wore either a gray or red jumper with jeans. He spoke again.

"I am thinking of going with you and Mrs. Park to the 'Baroque Concert' at the Basilica Maria Bildstein in Bregenz, which begins at five this afternoon. The performance will be by Vienna's city orchestra, the Wiener Symphoniker. While the Vienna Philharmonic is a conservative orchestra that mainly plays the classical repertoire, the Wiener Symphoniker is an orchestra broadening its range of performance, approaching modern music and even K-pop in a popular way."

Mrs. Park, a classical-music enthusiast, was delighted.

"So that is why Chairwoman Kwon told us to come dressed formally. Thanks to you, Mr. Willi, we will be able to enjoy a Baroque concert and I'm sure it will leave us very happy. So, you must have been invited as an honored guest."

"At every Bregenz Festival, the Wiener Symphoniker has generally been in charge of the music. Of course, my own *inyeon* is deep with the Vienna

Philharmonic. But during the Bregenz Festival, I, too, have often advised on matters of music.”

Then, quite suddenly, Mr. Willi asked Chairwoman Kwon whether she could translate *The Fool Novice* into German and read it aloud.

“It is because I do not know Hangeul. You said *The Fool Novice* was written to comment on the importance of silence, didn’t you? I believe I have told you this, but absolute silence is the same as absolute stillness, so I would like to hear it once more in German.”

“I will translate into German and read aloud only the part I read quickly before.”

Chairwoman Kwon opened *The Fool Novice*, which lay on the living-room table. She slowly passed over the pages she had already read and then began to read aloud in German.

〈But the child could not lay bare his true feelings to the monks. Once, when he had spoken what was in his heart, they had only teased him.

“You really are a fool. You feel sorry for the mice? They ruin our practice every chance they get.”

“Then you can practice in the courtyard.”

“So you mean we should give the room to the mice.”

“Yes, only during practice time.”

“And what are we supposed to do when it rains?”

“Then you can play.”

“There could hardly be a bigger fool. Ho ho ho.”

There was only one reason the monks hated the mice. To enter deeply into their practice, there had to be stillness, but the mice always disturbed them. Yet they could not tell the child to catch the mice. They vowed not to kill even a single mosquito, after all. Besides, even the thought of catching mice was beyond the child.

The monks did not make the child do kitchen work either. Handling fire was very dangerous. The monks had once been startled out of their wits. They had told the child to stoke the fire in the furnace, but he put in so much firewood that the floor paper burned yellow. That day, the heated floor in the monks’ room grew so boiling hot they couldn’t sleep a wink.

They didn’t have the child clean the latrine, either. It was, after all, the place that needed to be the cleanest. Without so much as a door, the outhouse was no different from an observation deck. One would sit there, straining away, and look out at the scenery of the front mountain.

The mountain ahead would wash its face in the morning sun, and after the rain, it wrapped itself in a hem of clouds like a thin summer blanket. In the evenings, tens of thousands of dragonflies fluttered as if scattering gold

dust across the sky. Yet the moment the mountain fell into shadow, it would empty out completely, bare of a single speck.

The child found joy in every single day. Laughter never left that face from dawn to dusk. And there was one person who never once raised their voice to the child: Monk Geumgang. Even had he wished to scold the boy, he could not—he had already been observing mugeon, the vow of silence, for ten years. Mugeon is a practice in which one does not speak at all. To the other monks, Geumgang was a treasure of the temple itself.

‘I will become a great monk.’

But in the child’s eyes, Venerable Geumgang looked stifled. It seemed not that he was keeping silent, but that he could not speak because he had lost his words.

After eating breakfast with relish, the child climbed like a squirrel up into the zelkova tree beside the Dharma Hall. The squirrel there was not afraid of him, because the child always brought it something to eat. Up in the tree, they played together, and then, while imitating the squirrel, the boy slipped from a branch.

‘Since I fell from the tree, I should die.’

The child pretended to be dead. Then the monks gathered around as if some auspicious event had happened.

‘Since I’m dead, I must not breathe.’

As the child held his breath, his face turned red. The monks noticed at once, and while holding back their laughter, some clutched the bellies hidden inside their long robes. To tease the child, the monks winked at one another.

“The child is dead, so let us bury him.”

A sturdy monk lifted the child high in his arms. The child was still pretending to be dead. Even with his eyes shut, he knew where they were going. He could hear the cry of bush warblers and the sound of the stream water flowing. It was clear they were crossing the mossy stone bridge in front of the temple. The smell of moss was as fragrant as flowers.

After crossing the stone bridge, the monks stopped. They hesitated, unsure where they should go now.

“Where shall we bury the child?”

No monk answered. The child quietly opened his eyes and looked. In the distance, he could make out the figure of Venerable Geumgang. Unable to hold back any longer, the child spoke with his eyes still closed.

“Please bury me over there, beside the stupas of the great monks.”

“The dead person is speaking.”

The monks said this with little snickers.

“How frustrated must he be to speak?”

Venerable Geumgang, who had been watching the monks, opened his mouth.

“Yes, your words are right! Avalokitesvara Bodhisattva, Avalokitesvara Bodhisattva.”

Whenever we meet someone lost and wandering, we must show them the right road, just as the child with the unstained heart had done. Venerable Geumgang felt ashamed that he had kept his mouth shut for ten whole years, saying he would become a great monk.

“You are truly my teacher!”

In Venerable Geumgang’s eyes, the child appeared as Avalokitesvara Bodhisattva. Venerable Geumgang knelt before the child with palms joined and did not know how to rise. The young monks’ eyes widened in astonishment. The child slipped out of the monks’ hands and ran to the kitchen. This was to get lunch for the squirrel.

A little while later, the child found one of his shoes on the rock where he fed the squirrel. Someone must have brought it there. The child had dropped the shoe in the shade of the zelkova tree. It was something impossible to know.>

After Chairwoman Kwon finished reading *The Fool Novice* in German, Mr. Willi smiled. Even as he drove his own car toward Bodensee, he wore a happy expression, still moved by the lingering message of *The Fool Novice*. Bodensee was like a great sea touching Austria, Germany, and Switzerland. Passenger boats were crossing the lake. There was a floating opera stage on the water, and along the lakeshore were installed thousands of seats for spectators. But perhaps because the opera performance was on another day, the floating stage stood empty.

After a late lunch at a restaurant by the lakeshore, the party moved to the mountainside village of Bildstein in the city of Bregenz. They were going to meet Mr. Willi’s friend, the businessman, editor, and CEO Christoph Ganahl. His company building faced the Basilika Maria-Bildstein, and the view was very fine. The city of Bregenz and Bodensee could be seen at a glance.

On the wall of his office hung a facsimile of a musical score Mr. Willi had drawn by hand, as if it were a work of hyperrealism. On another wall was an abstract-style painting by Max Weiler, whom Christoph said he loved and respected most.

‘So Christoph the businessman loves Willi’s music and Max Weiler’s painting.’

‘Christoph, who loves art, reveres Willi and Max Weiler!’

Chairwoman Kwon introduced Author Jeong to Christoph, who had an intelligent look about him. And when she introduced Mrs. Park, Author

Jeong showed him photographs of her ceramic works saved on his phone. Christoph was startled and exclaimed again and again.

“Wunderbar! Wunderbar!”

Author Jeong had shown them because Christoph loved art, and he thought Mrs. Park's ceramics, too, would meet with his favor. When five o'clock arrived, the people waiting outside the basilica began to enter one by one. Author Jeong's party also entered, showing the tickets Christoph's wife had reserved. Inside the basilica, the first floor, the second floor, and even the area directly before the stage filled at once, with not a gap to be found. At last, the concert began. But the conductor's introduction of honored guests, including Bregenz Mayor Michael Ritsch and Mr. Willi, was so long it grew tedious, while the performance itself was brief, only about an hour and a half. The encore, which began after loud applause, was familiar even to Author Jeong, though he knew little of classical music: a Bach unaccompanied cello suite that seemed to pour sunlight down upon his head. As they left the basilica, Author Jeong said to Chairwoman Kwon,

“It feels like a song of encouragement, breathing life into our Austrian journey.”

“This worked out well. Christoph and his wife say they will buy us dinner, too. The restaurant is above the basilica.”

When the party entered the restaurant, Mayor Michael Ritsch had arrived first and was dining with acquaintances. Christoph introduced Author Jeong, Mrs. Park, and Chairwoman Kwon. Author Jeong exchanged business cards with the mayor. Of course, the mayor and Mr. Willi already knew each other, so they only shook hands warmly. When Author Jeong's party stood to leave after the meal, the mayor came over first and playfully offered his hand, saying, “Chanju Jeong!” Seeing that he had memorized Author Jeong's name so quickly, Author Jeong thought a politician's sociability was much the same in Korea and Austria. At that moment, grateful to Mr. Willi for the kindness he had shown all afternoon, Author Jeong murmured to himself.

“I do not know what *inyeon* Mr. Willi and I had in a previous life. He gave us his whole afternoon, showed us Bodensee, and let us enjoy a concert in the basilica. How could I be anything but grateful? If only I possessed the Buddha-eye, as the Buddha does, I could see Mr. Willi's past lives clearly!”

The darkness of Bregenz night was soft as a caressing hand. The lights of the Bregenz streets seemed like starlight descended from the sky. From the direction of Bodensee, a warm wind blew in gently.

Montafon Moonlight House

5:30 in the morning.

Above the mountain in front, a round waxing half-moon, bright only on its right side, hung in the sky. Its light flooded the valley. Dawn was breaking beyond the peaks, and the lights seeping from the houses along the valley slopes and in the basin looked like sparks clinging to a great lump of glowing charcoal. It was mysterious, as if those lights were answering the moonlight in the sky. At that moment, Author Jeong suddenly remembered Mr. Willi's pure figure — the moment when Willi bowed to the audience, in footage Jeong had watched in Mr. Willi's living room from the premieres of the Vienna Philharmonic's 150th-anniversary commemorative opera *Encounter* and *Brother of Sleep*, the opera commemorating the thousandth anniversary of the founding of Austria.

Back then, Mr. Willi had been an unspoiled country youth from Montafon. Montafon was a remote borderland backcountry village, as much as six hundred kilometers west of Austria's capital, Vienna. Cross just one mountain and you were on Swiss soil; go a little south and you were in Italy.

The Mr. Willi in the video was pure and innocent. No matter how carefully that silver-haired country youth had dressed himself, it seemed the aristocrats of Vienna and self-proclaimed intellectuals would have whispered among themselves on seeing him, "That poor country bumpkin has made it!" The loose suit that looked borrowed, the small frame, the quick little stride that seemed almost to run, the comic sight of him bowing deeply like a child with both hands on his belly, all this called to mind the British comedian Charlie Chaplin. And yet his blue eyes, now that he was nearly seventy, remained as clear as the jade-green waters of a Montafon valley stream.

As they had the day before, Chairwoman Kwon, Author Jeong, and Mrs. Park began their day at Mr. Willi's house. Author Jeong asked the questions, Mr. Willi answered, and Chairwoman Kwon interpreted. Mrs. Park took careful notes. At one moment, Author Jeong and Mr. Willi understood each other even without interpretation. It turned out that Chairwoman Kwon,

instead of interpreting into German, had kept speaking Korean to Mr. Willi. When Author Jeong pointed out to her that she was speaking Korean without interpreting, she laughed out loud. Mr. Willi and Mrs. Park burst into laughter along with her.

They spoke about the Max Weiler painting they had seen the day before in Christoph's office.

"Max Weiler's abstract-style painting is still lingering before my eyes."

"He is one of the modern painters representative of Austria. Weiler's painting is a familiar work, one I had seen even when I was suffering from an incurable illness."

With eyes that seemed sunk in memory, Mr. Willi spoke of his *inyeon* with Max Weiler's painting. In Montafon, he had a friend named Jerry, with whom he had played in his first band. Jerry was a multi-talented friend who could play any instrument at all. Even while hiking, if they entered a bar with a performance stage, he would play at once if someone asked him, no matter what instrument was there, piano, violin, clarinet, whatever.

That friend's uncle owned an apartment in Innsbruck. While Mr. Willi was ill, the uncle gave him permission to stay there for two months. One Max Weiler painting hung on the wall beside the bed in the room where Willi slept.

"When I lay in bed, the painting was by my head, so I had no choice but to see it often. However, after I came home, the pain of illness made me simply forget it. Still, that unfamiliar Weiler painting left a deep impression on me. It was my first encounter with abstract art."

"When I was in high school, I was so captivated by Van Gogh that, when I painted in the art club, I often tried to imitate him. Ha ha ha."

Mr. Willi met Max Weiler in person in June 1999. His friend Franz Endler had invited him to Bregenz, and they were traveling together. A few days later, Willi visited Weiler in Krems. At the time, Weiler was ninety, and Willi received from him an art book signed in his own hand. The aged painter passed away two years later, in 2001. Even after Weiler's death, Willi stayed in phone contact for some time with his wife, Yvonne Weiler.

Only then did Mr. Willi fall deeply under the spell of Weiler's paintings. What moved him especially was Weiler's artistic philosophy, which had consistently pursued abstraction. When Weiler first made his name as a painter in 1941, he mainly painted figurative works, but from 1958 onward he pursued abstraction. Mr. Willi even attempted to incorporate Weiler's style into his own composition.

"Looking at Weiler's painting style, which kept reducing and simplifying the painterly means of points, lines, and planes, I wondered what such reduction or simplification might be in music. If you take more and

more out of music, what essence remains? In the end I concluded that perhaps only a flowing melody and a rhythm pulsing like a heartbeat moving at regular intervals would remain. I realized that in music there is a limit to becoming abstract. Reduce it any further, and it is no longer music. Though in painting, of course, empty space can become part of the work, as in East Asian painting.”

“I remember your friend Christoph saying he loved and respected Weiler. Perhaps he found some intersection between your music and Weiler’s paintings. I think Christoph likes artists who strive to embody essence rather than phenomenon, whether in art or in music.”

“After seeing Weiler’s painting in my friend’s uncle’s apartment in Innsbruck, so many years passed, and then I encountered another Weiler painting in Christoph’s office. I can only marvel at this long, invisible *inyeon*.”

“I often tell my acquaintances that the arrow of *inyeon* finds its target even in the night.”

Mr. Willi struck the pose of shooting an arrow, as if to show he agreed. As had been the case every time, the time Author Jeong and Mr. Willi spent exchanging words passed very quickly. It was never dull or tedious at all. Looking at the wall clock, they saw that more than two hours had already gone by. Mr. Willi made a proposal.

“If we ride the cable car up, we will come to a quiet hillside. I secluded myself for a year in a log house there, too, while composing. Shall we go there now? The mayor of Silbertal in Montafon is a friend who likes my music.”

They traveled in Mr. Willi’s car. The Silbertal town office was smaller and more modest than a Korean village office. After getting out of the car, Mr. Willi said he would go inside the office and introduce them to the mayor. But before they could enter, the mayor was already standing on the steps in front of the building. The appearance of Erwin Heizle, mayor of Silbertal in Montafon, was the complete opposite of the big-city mayor of Bregenz whom they had met the day before. Wearing work clothes, he had been talking with a staff member when he greeted Mr. Willi. Mr. Willi introduced Author Jeong. The mayor then asked whether the place where Author Jeong lived was a tourist destination in Korea. When Author Jeong said that Hwasun-gun in Jeollanam-do also had many tourist sites, the mayor said:

“It would be good for Montafon and your region to conclude a tourism MOU.”

“I know the county governor where I live quite well, so when I go to Korea, I will suggest it.”

The mayor seemed busy; rather than having tea inside the office, he walked ahead and said they should go straight to the cable car. He bought the party's tickets himself at the ticket window, then guided them to the waiting cable car. As soon as they boarded, he began explaining Silbertal like a Korean tourism commentator.

"Silbertal means 'valley of silver.' It is a village with a history of flourishing in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries as a mining area for silver and copper. Among our village's attractions are the Montafon Mining Museum and the small St. Agatha Miners' Chapel, where miners prayed for safety. And the Neue Heilbronner Hütte and Wormser Hütte, located at 2,320 meters above sea level, are famous hiking destinations where visitors can fully enjoy the pure atmosphere of the Alps and taste local traditional cuisine."

It was an introduction that showed how much the mayor loved Silbertal. As soon as they got off the cable car, he led the party to a restaurant. On the way, Mr. Willi pointed to a small log cabin and said:

"Leaving the bustling village down in the valley below, I secluded myself for a year in this very log house. Living there, I again encountered absolute stillness."

The mayor paid for lunch and then returned at once. After the meal, the party also looked out over patches of well-tended pasture, drank a cup of coffee, and rode the cable car back down. It was not far from Silbertal to Mr. Willi's house. The party went straight up to the dining room with Mr. Willi's round table. Then Author Jeong proposed a name he had come up with for Mr. Willi's studio-home.

"It just occurred to me. How would it be to call your house 'Montafon Moonlight House'?"

"That would be very good."

Mr. Willi accepted it gladly.

"My studio is called *Ibuljae* 耳佛齋. It is written in Chinese characters: ear i (耳), Buddha bul (佛), and house jae (齋). It means a house where one hears the sounds of water and the wind and attains Buddhahood, truth. People from many walks of life come to Ibuljae, receive comfort, gain courage, and leave having been healed, so I think the studio lives up to its name."

At this, Mr. Willi suddenly wore a lonely expression and said:

"I am poor, and my house is small. Could I really welcome many people? And someone may come using my name to contrive some scheme."

For the first time, Author Jeong dimly sensed that Mr. Willi was a composer living in straitened circumstances. He was a composer representative of Europe and Austria, yet behind his stature and fame,

poverty lay in wait as a hard reality. Is not an artist a being like daybreak, calling forth the morning? And if poverty torments an artist, is there no way to resolve it? Author Jeong suddenly felt gloomy, too. In that moment, the thought surged up in him that if the novel he had written taking Mr. Willi as its subject succeeded, he wanted to help Mr. Willi first.

“If *Montafon Moonlight* succeeds, more than anything, I would like to help you first, Mr. Willi.”

At Author Jeong’s single remark, the mood in the living room turned solemn in an instant. Chairwoman Kwon, who had acted like Mr. Willi’s older sister, finally burst into audible sobs, as if reproaching herself for cherishing him yet being unable to become any great source of strength. Then moisture welled up in Mr. Willi’s large eyes. After a moment, Mr. Willi waved his hands, telling Author Jeong he did not need to help him, but Author Jeong promised that because the words had already left his mouth, he would certainly honor them. Author Jeong said:

“The roughly seven thousand pages of scores stored in your underground studio, Mr. Willi, will one day rise higher in renown than Mont Blanc.”

At Author Jeong’s words of comfort, the dining room regained a little of its liveliness. Author Jeong spoke again.

“Because you, Mr. Willi, are a being like the moon of Montafon, one day you will brightly illuminate the world, and the people of the world, too, will not forget their gratitude.”

In that moment, not only Mr. Willi but even Chairwoman Kwon and Mrs. Park’s faces brightened again like the moonlight of Montafon.

Montafon's Nature Sounds

It was the first time since coming to Montafon that they had visited the church with Mr. Willi around nine in the morning. St. Agatha Church stood by the road only fifty meters uphill from the lodging where Author Jeong and Mrs. Park were staying. The party went inside the church, and Mr. Willi said,

“During the war, the church building was destroyed, but the villagers had moved the sacred objects inside to safety beforehand, so they escaped damage.”

“By the war, you mean the Second World War, I suppose.”

“Yes. Both of my parents were war orphans.”

“That splendid processional cross is a treasure more than seven hundred years old.”

On an information board outside the church, an explanation of the Romanesque processional cross was written in German and Chairwoman Kwon interpreted it into Korean for them.

“One of the most important artistic and cultural treasures in Vorarlberg, this late Romanesque processional cross was made around 1225 to 1250. It was produced in a workshop in Limoges in southwest France, with gilded copper plates over a wooden core, enamel coloring, and jewel ornamentation. After an attempted theft in 1977, the cross was finally moved to a secure place for safekeeping. For several years now, a copy made by Beatrice Pfeifer has been on display.”

Outside the church was the cemetery where the villagers were buried, yet it did not look bleak; it looked warm and gentle. When Mr. Willi told him the height of the silver-colored mountain in front, the one he had seen through their lodging window, Author Jeong was more than a little surprised.

“Author Jeong, the rocky face of that peak alone rises a thousand meters. When I was about ten, in winter I used to follow my father up to that summit and then ski down. If I had not fallen ill, I might have become a skier.”

Mr. Willi's father appeared now and then in his stories, so the *jeong* between father and son felt unusually deep. The party got into Mr. Willi's car and headed for Kops Lake. On the way, they stopped briefly at the birthplace of Franz Josef Rudigier, Bishop of Linz, who had been close enough to Anton Bruckner to hear his confession. They got out of the car and, in the empty yard of the birthplace, stretched their arms and legs as if doing warm-up exercises. The bishop's birthplace stood in the last village on the mountain road up to Kops Lake.

The reason Mr. Willi had brought them to Kops Lake was clear. Standing on the Kops Lake dam and looking down toward the primeval forest below, he said,

"When I look at that primeval forest below the dam, I feel absolute silence. It is a place where one can experience absolute silence."

"So, this must be that primeval absolute silence untouched by the noise of the secular world."

To Author Jeong's eyes, too, the primeval forest seemed like a center into which the energies of the surrounding peaks gathered. Since he was scheduled to leave Montafon the next day, Author Jeong had resolved to ask as many questions as he could. What he most wanted to know was what sounds Mr. Willi heard from all these different parts of nature. Without hesitating, Author Jeong asked straightaway,

"What sound comes from the rocky peak across the lake?"

"That mountain seems to be rooted deep in the earth, just as its crystal-like rock rises high above it."

Mr. Willi closed his eyes and for a moment took the posture of listening to the mountain's sound. Then he said seriously,

"I hear the sound of a contrabass as large as the three-story building that manages the lake water."

The contrabass is the largest of the string instruments, giving a weighty, low register; but when Mr. Willi said it sounded like a contrabass as large as the three-story lake-management building, Author Jeong could not even imagine it. Then Author Jeong pointed to a wildflower blooming along the side path to the lake dam, a red willowherb flower, and asked,

"What sound comes from that wildflower?"

"It makes a sound lower than the low register of an oboe, and also the clean, clear sound of a clarinet."

"You said, Mr. Willi, that you could express the sound you just heard with colored pencils, didn't you?"

"Yes. That is why I used to carry colored pencils with me."

"It is marvelous that sound can be transformed into color."

“The oboe and clarinet are also instruments shepherds have carried and played since long ago.”

“Now that I hear you say that, the wild willowherb flower does seem to resemble a shepherd who once passed through here.”

Mr. Willi returned to the absolute silence he had spoken of a little earlier.

“When I walked through Montafon’s primeval forests, I felt absolute silence, and I realized that absolute silence also existed within me. It was only that my desires, afflictions, and stray thoughts prevented it from revealing itself.”

“This is the same principle in Buddhism, where the Buddha-nature (佛性) present in the other living beings we see also exists within oneself.”

“In order to wash away the desires, afflictions, and stray thoughts covering my inner being, I came often to Montafon’s primeval forests and walked and walked. So my music begins from primeval absolute silence.”

Author Jeong understood Mr. Willi’s words. When he tried substituting emptiness (*gong* 空) for absolute silence, understanding came more quickly. Absolute silence was not mere absolute stillness; just as music was full within it, emptiness, too, was not simply a vacant state. *Jingong Myoyu* (真空妙有)—True Emptiness, Wondrous Being. It was empty, yet full of wisdom and Buddha-nature (佛性); that state was emptiness. To put it in numbers, zero lay between 1 and -1. Zero was emptiness, something no one could explain as any particular thing, yet it was not nothing at all, because it was something that existed between 1 and -1.

After finishing their conversation about absolute silence at Kops Lake, the party went deeper into the mountains. Because Mr. Willi had obtained an entry permit in advance, they could go farther into the Alps.

“From here on, landslide danger is ever-present, so one cannot go in without a permit.”

As the car drove on, three or four lakes smaller than Kops Lake appeared.

“This part of Montafon is the middle zone of the Alps.”

“To think I am here in the Alps—it moves me deeply.”

“I used to come here deliberately and wait until the hikers and cycling groups had disappeared, then enter absolute silence for hours and receive inspiration.”

The party went into a restaurant overlooking a small lake and ate lunch. During the meal, Author Jeong again pointed to the valley water flowing down in white streams along the foothills of the Alps and asked,

“What sound comes from that place over there?”

“When two notes on a piano are struck at the same time, there are moments when an evil sound like the Devil’s voice arises. But the valley water has none of that sound at all; it has the energy of water that washes away anguish and affliction. It makes a sound like the bows of violins and other string instruments just barely touching the strings.”

Then, quite naturally, Mr. Willi began to speak of his symphony *Jeong* (情)*.

“I used the sound of that valley water in the second and sixth movements of *Jeong*. Absolute silence also appears repeatedly, and the theme of the tenth movement of *Jeong* is absolute peace and absolute freedom, the happiness and joy in which anything can be fulfilled.”

In 2018, at Mr. Willi’s office in the Wiener Konzerthaus, Author Jeong had explained to him the Buddhist *Ten Oxherding Pictures*, which depict truth in ten stages by using an ox as a metaphor, and Willi had not forgotten it. That was because the ten-movement progression of *Jeong* was quite similar to the *Ten Oxherding Pictures*. In particular, the theme of the final, tenth stage was the same in meaning in *Jeong* and in the *Ten Oxherding Pictures*.

After lunch, the party returned to their lodging. Each would rest in their room, then meet again at Mr. Willi’s house at seven that evening. They had made the arrangement because Mr. Willi said he had something he wanted to tell them.

Sure enough, around seven that evening, when Author Jeong and Mrs. Park and Chairwoman Kwon entered his living room, Mr. Willi briefly explained the four works in the Montafon series he had composed. The first was a concerto for trumpet and orchestra, titled *Eirene*, and he said its theme was the joy and peace of life. He added that he had composed it in 3.5-movement form, thinking of his younger sister Irene, who had died while hiking alone in the Montafon mountains. The first and second movements gather people for a journey and reach the third movement, while the remaining 0.5 movement is a piece in which they turn back before arriving at their destination. Chairwoman Kwon said,

“They say the search party looking for the missing hiker searched every corner, but in the end they could not find Irene. In the end, Irene could not return home, and Mr. Willi composed the piece while meditating on his younger sister.”

At Chairwoman Kwon’s words, Mrs. Park said one thing.

“Seen that way, mountains are compassionate sages, but at times perhaps they are not.”

The second work was a concerto for flute, oboe, and orchestra, titled *Geraume Zeit*, meaning a waiting room between life and death. Mr. Willi

had been contacted by a doctor he knew who lived about four hundred meters from his house. The doctor told him that his wife, Monica, seemed to have only a few days left to live and wanted to see Mr. Willi's score. Monica had always loved Mr. Willi's music very much. At this, Author Jeong said,

"In Buddhism, too, there is a world called the intermediate state between life and death. It is said that when a person dies, they remain in the intermediate realm for forty-nine days before going to the Pure Land or to hell."

"The theme of the third movement of the second piece is love, 'the Creator who is always with you.'"

Mr. Willi always called the one God of Christianity the Creator. It was because he believed that people's pure faith in God had become polluted and corrupted.

The third work was a concerto for clarinet and orchestra, titled *Ego eimi*, meaning "I am," a declarative phrase Jesus uses when revealing his divinity and identity. The theme of the work, he said, was "absolute silence before sound, and the resonance of being, the music, that emerges from within that absolute silence." The fourth work was a concerto for horn and orchestra titled *Aon*, meaning an aeon, an infinite span of time, and he explained that its theme was the "timeless eternity" felt within Alpine nature.

"I composed the fourth movement of the fourth work by referring to the words of a priest. That priest always told me to look at the steps I was taking."

"The priest's words are interesting. In Buddhism, too, monks tell us to practice *jogo gakha* (照顧脚下). It means to look always beneath your own feet. May I understand it that way?"

"Of course."

When difficult Buddhist terms appeared, Chairwoman Kwon interpreted haltingly, and Mrs. Park repeatedly checked the conversation between Mr. Willi and Author Jeong until she understood it herself, then recorded it in her notebook. And yet Mr. Willi and Author Jeong, even when Chairwoman Kwon's interpretation was not perfect, had already begun, from some point on, to communicate naturally.

Lonely Mr. Willi

It was the day they were leaving Montafon. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park and Chairwoman Kwon went to Mr. Willi's house by nine in the morning. Chairwoman Kwon's friend Silvia was scheduled to come with her car by two in the afternoon, so until then they could talk with Mr. Willi. In the living room, Mr. Willi had the large monitor turned on and showed the party a video of the mountainside, about three thousand meters above sea level, that had inspired *Ego eimi*, where the resonance of being, music, lived within nature's absolute silence.

"Even now, music is alive in the absolute silence of that mountainside, but as hikers' footsteps become more frequent, the music may hide itself somewhere else. The local government says it will build a bicycle road there, and I am worried."

Mr. Willi went over beside the large monitor, crouched down, and pointed with his finger to the mountainside where the music of *Ego eimi* lived. To be clear, he was not vaguely pointing toward the Alps; he was precisely indicating and explaining the exact spot where the music of *Ego eimi* lived.

Afterward, Mr. Willi led the party down to the basement. In the basement were the scores for *Brother of Sleep*, which Mr. Willi had written himself by hand. The scores were stacked neatly inside a long, narrow cabinet, piled nearly as high as Mr. Willi himself. Mr. Willi showed them one sheet of music, and the black notes looked like a swarm of ants. To Author Jeong, who had painted in the art club until high school, the scores looked like hyperrealist paintings.

"They look like hyperrealist paintings."

"I hear composers these days work comfortably on computers. But I still work on everything by hand with a pen."

"If facsimile copies of the scores were placed in frames and the music for those sections included on a CD, wouldn't they become avant-garde art, and perhaps an elegant product as well?"

"I'm not sure."

"If we discussed it with your businessman friend Christoph, I think a better idea might come to mind."

But Mr. Willi was hesitant about commercializing his scores. He seemed to listen with interest, then soon changed the subject.

"I would like to visit the place where you live, Author Jeong."

"Please come. We have a guest room where visitors stay. If you come, Mr. Willi, I will put a bed in there for you."

"No, no need to do that."

Chairwoman Kwon said,

"Mr. Willi does not show his scores to guests except on special occasions. I think he is showing them today as a gift from his heart to Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, since you are leaving Montafon this afternoon."

"I can feel Mr. Willi's warm heart. I, too, would like to express mine to him."

Author Jeong gave Mr. Willi the prayer beads he had been wearing around his wrist. It was a gift of the beads he had long worn together with his watch.

"This is my heart."

Mr. Willi, suddenly presented with the prayer beads, was delighted.

"On which wrist should I wear them?"

"Either wrist is fine. Wear them however feels comfortable."

Mr. Willi put the prayer beads on his left wrist. His wrist was slender, almost delicate. The beads slipped out from the end of his gray jumper sleeve and hung loosely on his wrist. Then Mrs. Park, too, readily gave Chairwoman Kwon the prayer beads she had cherished. Chairwoman Kwon, who had worked so hard interpreting for them all this time, smiled brightly and said,

"It seems I have received far too much in interpreting fees."

"Not at all. Compared with what you have given us, Chairwoman Kwon, it is far too small."

Before leaving Mr. Willi's house, Author Jeong once again spoke of *Jeong*. It had suddenly occurred to him what meaning *Jeong* might hold in a world stained by war. After the Second World War, peace had seemed to come briefly, yet in places across the earth, human dignity was being brutally destroyed by the madness of wars started by a few greedy leaders. Author Jeong said,

"You said the theme of the tenth movement of *Jeong* is absolute freedom and absolute peace, happiness and joy in which anything can be fulfilled. I think *Jeong*, in this age of greed stained by war, is precisely a musical

answer offered to twenty-first-century humanity longing for freedom and peace, happiness and joy.”

Mr. Willi showed no reaction, as though Author Jeong had said something rather out of the blue. Author Jeong asked Chairwoman Kwon,

“Has an Austrian musician ever received the Nobel Peace Prize?”

“As far as I know, I do not think so.”

“Why not? The message of *Jeong* is clear. The message of *Jeong* is different from the claims of politicians or human-rights activists. It is music that awakens human dignity through feeling. I believe music is one of the things that appeals most powerfully to humanity longing for freedom and peace.”

Mrs. Park said,

“It seems we need the ideas of Christoph, the businessman. Because he is a businessman, I suspect he may find a better way than we can to appeal to Austrian intellectuals about the value of Mr. Willi’s *Jeong*.”

Only then did Chairwoman Kwon show the skill of the businesswoman who had built the IMK company, rather than simply that of an interpreter.

“If Christoph were to take the lead and organize Austrian politicians, musicians, and intellectuals who love Mr. Willi’s music, he could promote the value of *Jeong* effectively.”

Mr. Willi still looked as if the idea had come from nowhere. Because Author Jeong had suddenly brought up the Nobel Peace Prize, he even covered his face with both hands, as if embarrassed. But Author Jeong had only spoken sincerely.

“*Jeong* is a musical alternative for freedom and peace offered to the people of the world. How sacred a thing that is. I hope *Montafon Moonlight* becomes a stepping-stone that lets people know Mr. Willi’s philosophy of music.”

Only then did Mr. Willi gather both hands over his abdomen and show Author Jeong respect and reverence. But at that moment, Author Jeong saw a lonely shadow flicker across Mr. Willi’s face. As the time when they had to part drew nearer, the shadow grew darker. Author Jeong murmured to himself,

“Ah, once all of us leave Montafon, Mr. Willi will become lonely again. Aren’t artists by nature lonely beings?”

Chairwoman Kwon spoke with someone on her cell phone, then said,

“My friend Silvia says she is outside. We will take Silvia’s car and go to Vienna by way of Salzburg.”

When they came down the wooden stairs from the second floor of Mr. Willi’s house, five or six grannies were passing by. The sky over Montafon

was covered with pale clouds. One of the grandmothers spoke to Author Jeong, whose clothing looked unfamiliar.

“Please don’t take Montafon’s sun with you.”

“Yes, I will take only Montafon’s clouds.”

At the grandmother’s wish for clear weather, Author Jeong replied that he would take “Montafon’s clouds,” and Mr. Willi, Chairwoman Kwon, and Mrs. Park all laughed. Still, Mr. Willi looked lonely and forlorn.

Silvia was Chairwoman Kwon’s friend, albeit about ten years younger. Solidly built and laughing easily, she had brought her dog with her. She often laughed loudly as she drove. Chairwoman Kwon introduced her. Silvia had lectured at a university, held doctorates in philosophy and education, and had even earned an airplane pilot’s license. Chairwoman Kwon said that a Korean high school student studying in Austria had once stayed at Silvia’s house. Then she brought up an old story: the student had nearly been expelled from school, but Silvia and Chairwoman Kwon had met with the principal and resolved the matter.

It was an incident that began with an Austrian high school teacher misunderstanding a Korean exchange student. It was a cultural difference between Korea and Austria. Whenever the Austrian teacher pointed something out, the Korean student lowered his head. Chairwoman Kwon said with a laugh,

“When an adult scolds us, we lower our heads, don’t we? But Austrian adults understand it as defiance if the other person lowers their head. You have to lift your head and look at the adult for them to think you are being obedient.”

“It is the exact opposite of us. Hahaha.”

“At that time, it was serious for us. Silvia and I went to the school. We met with the principal and I persuaded him. I told him, ‘When I was scolded by my father as a child, I lowered my head and showed that I was reflecting.’ So I pleaded with him to forgive the student, because the student lowering his head meant he was showing deference by self-reflecting, not in any way rebelling.”

Silvia also said,

“The principal understood Sonja’s words and persuaded the other teachers, so the Korean student who had been staying with me graduated from school with good grades and went on to university with the teachers’ recommendations. Now he has become a professor.”

She then proudly said that she still kept the Korean hanbok the student had given her as if it were a treasure.

The three-room lodging Silvia had reserved online stood in the countryside on the outskirts of Salzburg. Because of Silvia’s dog,

Chairwoman Kwon had booked a separate room. When they arrived at the lodging, it was six in the evening. That meant they had driven four hours from Montafon to their destination. Silvia moved about energetically, as if she were not at all tired. Their lodging's name was romantic.

Romantik Spa Hotel.

The reason Silvia had reserved a hotel on the outskirts was the difficulty of parking in downtown Salzburg. She asked Author Jeong and Mrs. Park for their understanding, explaining that during the Salzburg Festival it was extremely difficult to find parking in the city center and that she had therefore chosen accommodations on the outskirts. However, after hearing Silvia explain the hotel's history, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, along with Chairwoman Kwon, reassured her that it had actually been an excellent choice.

Since the hotel's history dated back to 1334, it was an astonishing 691 years old. Since first opening its doors, it had been operated continuously by the same family for twenty-three generations, making it the oldest hotel in Austria still run by a single family. Originally an inn operated by an organic farm, it had gradually evolved over the centuries into the small yet romantic four-star hotel it is today. Chairwoman Kwon also asked Author Jeong and Mrs. Park for their understanding.

"Tomorrow evening, we are scheduled to attend a music performance, one program of the Salzburg Festival, but I was able to reserve only two tickets online. It is such a popular performance that the tickets sold out early. Only you and Mrs. Park should attend, Author Jeong."

"Thank you, but I feel bad."

"Not at all. Silvia and I will stay outside. We often attend concerts in Vienna."

Silvia waved her hand, saying she could take her dog for a walk during that time. In any case, Salzburg was the city where Willi had studied composition and given himself to contemplation. Beginning in 1983, Willi studied composition under the Austrian composer Professor Helmut Eder at the Mozarteum University Salzburg.

Kairos im Kronos 1756 / 1956

When I drew back the curtains, light came pouring in. Suddenly I thought of Korea, the land where the sun rises. Perhaps the thought came to me because today we would spend one more night in Salzburg, then go to Vienna tomorrow for the day's appointments before returning home on a night flight.

Salzburg was a city known as the birthplace of Mozart, a sacred ground of music. Among the stories Mr. Willi had told them in Montafon, the story of an important nobleman in the music world, known as Karajan's right-hand man, naturally came to mind. That nobleman, who possessed one of Mozart's unfinished scores, had sent Mr. Willi a piece of mail bearing his seal. It had arrived when Mr. Willi was pressed for time, composing the requested work *Ego eimi* for performance during the Salzburg Festival.

For that reason, Mr. Willi could not open the mail right away. A few days later, he opened it and found, along with the nobleman's letter, Mozart's unfinished score. The letter asked him to complete the unfinished score. The Mozart score he had sent, about three minutes in performance length, was an unfinished score with neither beginning nor end. In his letter, the nobleman said he had entrusted Mozart's unfinished score to Mr. Willi because he had seen the record of Mr. Willi's life described in detail in an opera, and because the sums of the digits in Mozart's and Mr. Willi's birthdates were the same. Mozart's birthday was January 27, 1756, and Willi's was January 7, 1956, so the digit sums of both birthdates were both 29. The nobleman called himself a researcher of numbers.

Mr. Willi wondered whether he should grant the request.

"Of all Austria's many composers, it was an honor, and something I was grateful for, that he asked me. But because I was composing *Ego eimi*, it was not easy to agree at once."

Mr. Willi set it aside for another week. Then, at a certain moment, he had a presentiment that the composition might come of its own accord.

"At that time, in the fact that the digit sums of Mozart's and my birthdates were the same, I felt a fateful inspiration. In that instant, I thought,

'Perhaps it is all right for me to complete Mozart's unfinished score.' A kind of confidence or inspiration rose up in me. So I called him and told him, 'I will do it.'

Still, Mr. Willi attached one condition for the nobleman.

"Two hundred years from now, I hope some Austrian composer will complete Mozart's unfinished score in yet another way. Austrians have no choice but to love Mozart forever."

And so, for the first movement, Mr. Willi took inspiration from the fact that the digit sums of the two birthdates were both 29; it was not easy, but he made music using numbers. For the second movement, he inserted Mozart's unfinished score exactly as it was. For Willi, no alteration whatsoever was possible in the second movement Mozart had composed, and there was no way he could add his own music to it. In a word, there was not even one percent of room for Willi's music to intrude upon Mozart's. The third movement portrayed human beings in the realities of life, and the fourth movement concluded in Mr. Willi's own manner of composition: music from which the concept of time had departed, beginning in absolute silence.

"This is only my thought, but the identical number 29, the digit sum of both Mozart's and Mr. Willi's birthdates, feels like a secret code symbolizing Mozart's reincarnation, his resurrection. The nobleman who noticed this fateful number and approached Mr. Willi even seems to me like an astrologer draped in a black cloak."

"In any case, when I gave the completed four-movement work its title, I put the numbers into it. The title is *Kairos im Kronos 1756 / 1956*, and it was premiered by the Vienna Philharmonic. The principal player said, 'It felt as if we had played a Mozart piece.' Not only that, he also said that in the third and fourth movements he had discovered a commonality between Mozart's music and Willi's music."

"What was the commonality the principal player felt?"

It was one of Author Jeong's keen questions, asked in Mr. Willi's dining room while they were staying in Montafon. Mr. Willi answered cautiously but kindly.

"The age of Habsburg Empress Maria Theresa, when court music and dance music prevailed, and the modern age, when even jazz has appeared, have different historical backgrounds. So I cannot speak rashly. But I suppose that Mozart and I may share at least this: that we both saw music at the boundary between the visible and the invisible."

Mr. Willi, now as then, always said he "saw" music; he did not say he "heard" it.

The television in the lodging's living room showed that the festival streets of Salzburg were a sea of people. It reported that every hotel in the

city center was full of tourists gathered to enjoy the festival. Silvia, with sunglasses perched on her head, gave her morning greeting at the outdoor table.

“*Guten Morgen!*”

“Good morning.”

Chairwoman Kwon, too, greeted Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, translating as she did so.

“This morning, we are going to Hohensalzburg Fortress, built into the rocky mountain. It is the fortress Mr. Willi told us we must visit.”

“The concert is in the evening, so I would like to see the fortress at leisure.”

“The fortress has an excellent view, including a view of all of Salzburg. So take some commemorative photographs, sit on a bench and rest, and let’s return to the hotel around four.”

After breakfast, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, together with Chairwoman Kwon, rode in the passenger car Silvia was driving and entered a street close to Hohensalzburg Fortress. Silvia drove skillfully and found a relatively quiet parking lot. They would have to walk through one alley and then another to the fortress entrance, but that did not matter. Silvia’s dog suddenly relieved itself, but Silvia cleaned it up neatly with a black plastic bag.

At last, when the party climbed up to the fortress, they sat on a bench and looked down over the city of Salzburg. The Salzach River flowed through the center of the city, and Hohensalzburg Fortress rose midway along the city’s north-south axis. Whenever she had a chance, Silvia, like the professor she was, unpacked what she knew.

“When summer came, the Habsburg rulers would come from Vienna to Salzburg and spend the season here. Because there was an imperial residence, the city carries a sense of refinement and dignity, whether one notices it or not. Two hundred fifty million years ago, Salzburg and the Alpine region were the floor of the sea. As periods when the seawater dried and evaporated repeated, enormous amounts of salt settled and formed sedimentary strata. That is why Salzburg has salt mines. Beginning one hundred million years ago, the African continental plate moved north and collided forcefully with the European continental plate, causing Salzburg and the Alps, once beneath the sea, to surge upward.”

“Salzburg, I notice, is pronounced something like *Jjalzburg*. But salt, after all, is *jjada*, salty, in Korean, is it not? Since both *jjada* and Salz seem to begin with that same tense *jj* sound, one cannot help but sense a certain resemblance to Korean as well.”

Chairwoman Kwon said,

“You are a writer, after all. I have never once thought of *jjada* and ‘Salz’ together.”

“There is one other thing in Austria that made me feel a similarity between Korean and the language here. Shall I tell you? In Austria, a street is called a *Gasse*. In Korea, when we say, ‘Let us go somewhere,’ we say *gase*. So I see a similarity there.”

“My address is on Beethoven Gasse. It means the street where Beethoven passed away. Your powers of observation are remarkable, Author Jeong.”

“Shall I say I sense it instinctively, without trying? In India, cities or villages with a fortress are called *pur*. Jaipur, Jodhpur, Udaipur, and so on. In Austria’s Salzburg, too, *Burg* seems linguistically similar to *pur*, in the sense of a city with a fortress.”

Though India and Austria were geographically thousands of kilometers apart, it was also true that, in linguistic etymology and historical function, they displayed a surprisingly perfect parallel. Author Jeong had spoken only of what he himself had discovered, but if one looked carefully, there seemed likely to be many such similar words.

Unlike Montafon, Salzburg’s cathedrals were enormous in scale. The great cathedral in the city center, where the square lay, must have been where a cardinal resided. Mrs. Park, a classical-music devotee, asked Silvia,

“They say Mozart played the piano before Empress Maria Theresa when he was four. What was it that nurtured the musicality of Mozart, that child prodigy?”

When Silvia only smiled, Author Jeong said,

“Dear, perhaps it was the Salzach River flowing through the city and Hohensalzburg Fortress?”

“That is a vague answer, not like you.”

“Mozart must have loved the Salzach River, flowing unchanged then and now beyond time and space, more than anyone. Hohensalzburg Fortress too... Is there any material that nurtures sensibility more than love?”

Author Jeong had answered in an explanatory way, but in truth he was dissatisfied. It was because the answer felt closer to a supplementary explanation than to a clear answer. Like a *hwadu*, Author Jeong murmured to himself,

‘What was it that nurtured Mozart’s musicality?’

The party walked along the shade of the fortress wall. Every stone in the wall was sedimentary rock, bearing the dark green and deep gray of the deep seabed. Since Silvia had explained that Salzburg had once lain beneath the sea, the fortress wall itself seemed to be proving her words.

“A moment ago you told us Salzburg had been beneath the sea. It seems you were exactly right.”

“It is not only the fortress wall. Most of the walls of the cathedral in the city center are also made of stones cut from sedimentary rock.”

Suddenly Author Jeong let his imagination take wing. He imagined why Mozart had climbed up to the fortress like a man possessed, day and night, to conceive musical ideas. Perhaps Mozart, touching the sedimentary rock of the fortress wall that held the ancient sea, walking over the massive sedimentary bedrock inside the fortress, had seen the music living within it. So he guessed. Only then did Author Jeong feel the point of intersection between Mozart and Willi.

‘Just as Willi saw absolute silence in the ancient primeval forest, Mozart may have seen absolute silence in primeval sedimentary rock. If so, was not absolute silence the place where the music of both composers began?’

Yet Author Jeong could not assert this as fact. That was because he had heard there were no sentences or passages about absolute silence in the records or studies concerning Mozart. Mr. Willi had told him that Mozart, too, had never used the term absolute silence.

The party returned to the hotel at four in the afternoon. They needed a proper rest, because the concert was at eight that evening. While they rested at the hotel’s outdoor table, talking with Silvia, another burst of laughter broke out. It happened when Silvia introduced her husband.

“You will meet him tomorrow; my husband is 197 centimeters tall, and his name is Boris.”

“What? Did you say *borisu* (Bodhi tree)?”

“Hahaha.”

Everyone burst into laughter because Author Jeong had said “Boris” as *borisu*, “Bodhi tree.” Perhaps embarrassed, Author Jeong explained the Bodhi tree.

“Because the Buddha attained enlightenment beneath the Bodhi tree, the Bodhi tree is a sacred tree. My wife and I personally paid our respects to that tree in Bodh Gaya, India. Its leaves are heart-shaped, and unusually, they say the Bodhi tree releases oxygen twenty-four hours a day. That must be why practitioners preferred to sit beneath a Bodhi tree breathing out sacred energy.”

“Hahaha. A Bodhi tree is growing well in our garden.”

Chairwoman Kwon added that there really was a Bodhi tree in Silvia’s garden. Chairwoman Kwon praised Silvia’s tall husband Boris as a very kind man. Once, when her car broke down in the street, she called Boris, who knew how to repair cars; although it was nighttime, he came at once,

arranged for Chairwoman Kwon to go home first in his own car, then repaired her car there in the street and returned late at night.

Salzburg Concert

To go to the Haus für Mozart, the party stood in front of the passenger car Silvia would drive. Even Silvia's dog Vito came along. On Chairwoman Kwon's advice, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park had changed out of their casual clothes and into formal dress before taking their seats in the back. They were leaving the hotel at 6:15 p.m., and since the concert began at eight, there was no need to hurry too much. But Salzburg's city streets were already packed with cars, one after another.

It was only around seven that the party reached the area near the Haus für Mozart. Police officers were thoroughly controlling the roads around the concert hall. Only cars issued a pass could approach the hall itself. Silvia said,

"The aristocrats attending the concert must already have received their passes."

"We'll walk a little from here. You can let us out here."

Vito whined, as if refusing to get out on a street crowded with people. Silvia warned him,

"Vito, you're not getting out. Be quiet."

Mrs. Park said,

"That is the name of the mafia boss in the film *The Godfather*. The police may get nervous because of Vito's name."

"Hahaha, for Vito's sake too, he's not getting out."

Silvia had no pass, but she used her wits to take Author Jeong and Mrs. Park all the way to the concert hall entrance. She stopped the car beside a police officer. When he approached, Silvia said confidently,

"I have brought important guests from Korea."

At that, the officer glanced at Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, seated in the back in formal clothes, then pointed the traffic baton in his hand toward the concert hall entrance. It was a sign permitting them to pass. Even so, the officer tilted his head with a curious expression. In an instant, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park had become important figures from Korea. As she dropped them at the concert hall entrance, Silvia said,

“Hahaha. I did not lie. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park are honored guests who have come from Korea.”

“Silvia did not lie. We will wait at a nearby café and come back when the concert is nearly over.”

The concert was called the Camerata Salzburg Concert. The seats, going up three floors, were already full. A female concert hall staff member noticed Author Jeong and Mrs. Park hesitating because they could not find their seats, and kindly showed them to their assigned places. Their seats were near the front, close enough to see even the expressions of the performers in detail.

The concert began on time, exactly as printed on the ticket. Part One began with an ensemble made up only of violins and cellos playing Vivaldi's *The Four Seasons*, familiar even to Author Jeong's ear. The performers played the entire work with passion for some forty-five minutes, without the slightest looseness. In particular, the concerto-like exchange between the female violinist in a dress the color of a black rose and the male violinist who also served as conductor was more than enough to hold the eye. The Dutch guest violinist Janine Jansen, after the first part ended, gave an encore with movements full of force and received great applause from the audience. If there was one flaw, it was that women who seemed to be classical-music planners were chatting quietly in the seats directly in front of them. It was only natural that Mrs. Park furrowed her brow. By contrast, the mustached, middle-aged Japanese man seated beside them wore a dazzlingly patterned top, as if he were an avant-garde artist, and when Janine Jansen returned to the stage for her encore, he cried out “Bravo!” again and again.

When Part One and the encore ended, the audience was given an intermission. As the central doors of the concert hall opened wide, people poured out into the square. At that moment, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park thought the concert was over and called Chairwoman Kwon. But Chairwoman Kwon did not answer. Sensing that something about the atmosphere was strange, Mrs. Park said,

“Dear, the audience is not scattering. They are gathered here and there in the square, drinking wine.”

“You're right. Let's ask one of the concert hall staff.”

Mrs. Park asked one of the female staff members,

“Is the performance over?”

“Yes, the one-hour performance has ended.”

The audience was still lingering in the square, talking together. Yet the staff member's answer was not exactly wrong. The first part, lasting one hour, had indeed ended. Just then, a small bell suddenly rang. It was the signal that intermission was over and the audience should reenter the hall.

People surged back inside. Author Jeong and Mrs. Park, still unfamiliar with the location of the concert hall doors, were again guided by a staff member back to their assigned seats.

Part Two, led by conductor Gregory Ahss, had changed into the scale of a small orchestra. The piece for the second part was Mendelssohn's *Italian Symphony*, vivid and alive like brilliant sunlight. The performers played with all their strength, wearing happy expressions as they did. Just seeing the happiness on their faces made Author Jeong feel as though he were being served music. For two and a half hours across Parts One and Two, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park were moved by the performers' playing and by the joy in their expressions. Their minds were perfectly clear, as if purified by the melodies of the music. Author Jeong felt newly grateful to Chairwoman Kwon. She had barely managed to secure two tickets when the concert was nearly sold out; one ticket cost 193 euros, so two came to more than 670,000 Korean won.

Author Jeong thought of his *inyeon* with Chairwoman Kwon. It had been a piece of good fortune for him that she, a Catholic, had been captivated by his Buddhist works. As Chairwoman Kwon had passed in and out of Incheon International Airport, she had bought one of Author Jeong's novels or essay collections at the airport bookstore each time and read it. Once she had even shown him a notebook in which she had packed nearly an entire page with the titles of those books. One day she introduced Author Jeong's literary world to Mr. Willi, and because Mr. Willi then wanted to meet him, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park had traveled twice to Montafon, where Mr. Willi lived.

When they came out of the concert hall, Silvia and Chairwoman Kwon were waving amid the bustling crowd. Silvia's car must have been parked somewhere beside Hohensalzburg Fortress. They would have to walk there. In the square near the concert hall, a large screen had been set up. It was a screen meant to show the live performance to citizens who could not afford tickets. As the party passed by, Mozart's final opera, *The Magic Flute*, completed only two months before his death, was playing on the screen like a film. Silvia said,

"The greatest reason *The Magic Flute* is loved beyond its age is, without question, the music. It is full of famous pieces that even people who know little about classical music recognize as soon as they hear them. Among them, the Queen of the Night aria stands out for its tremendous high notes and technique, as if testing the limits of the human voice. It is a cold, furious song in which she commands her daughter to kill Sarastro."

When they returned to the Romantik Spa Hotel, it was eleven at night. They had planned to see the Mozart Residence that day, but once again they

had postponed it. So the next morning they would have to stop by the Mozart Residence and then leave straight for Vienna. Mrs. Park's flight ticket for Korea had already been booked. Before going to sleep, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park spoke for a while. Author Jeong said,

"Why did Mr. Willi complete Mozart's unfinished score himself and then hope that two hundred years later someone else would complete it in another version?"

"Mr. Willi is remarkable, thinking in units of two hundred years over Mozart's unfinished score."

"I feel as if Mr. Willi meditates within an eternity that transcends time and space. At least one thing is clear: he is an extraordinary genius of a composer."

"The aristocrat who possessed Mozart's unfinished score was no ordinary person either. That aristocrat must have understood Mr. Willi's music. That must be why he gave Mozart's unfinished score to Mr. Willi."

Author Jeong was tired, but he could not fall asleep right away. The afterimage of Hohensalzburg Fortress kept circling in his mind.

"Dear, do you think Mozart knew that Salzburg had been under the sea long ago?"

"Archaeologists would have known such things from sedimentary rock, but Mozart, as a composer, may not have. Still, just as Mr. Willi encountered absolute silence in the primeval forest below Kops Lake and saw music there, Mozart too may have drawn inspiration, without knowing it, from Salzburg's immense primeval sedimentary rock."

"There is reason in your inference. The principal players of the Vienna Philharmonic said there was something common to Willi's music and Mozart's."

From a forest whose distance could not be gauged came the sound of a nightingale. The sound was very clear and ringing. It seemed like the voice of a weather forecaster announcing that the night had deepened.

The next day, at 10:10 in the morning, the party set out for the Mozart Residence. About twenty minutes later, they arrived and went straight in. Silvia could not enter because of her dog, Vito. If the interior had a defining feature, it was that Mozart's life was displayed in pictures. Author Jeong stopped before the portrait of Mozart's father, whose eyes were fierce. Mozart's own eyes, too, resembled his father's and were far from ordinary. According to the exhibition text, Mozart remained in conflict with his father until his early death at a young age; this was the exact opposite of the father-son relationship between Mr. Willi and his father, through which love had passed.

After leaving the Mozart Residence, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park and Chairwoman Kwon hurried out of Salzburg. With Vienna almost before them, they stopped briefly at Silvia's house. It was so she could leave the visibly exhausted Vito at home. Silvia's tall husband Boris came out as far as the garden and welcomed them warmly. When he stretched out both hands to pick peaches, saying he would give them to Chairwoman Kwon as a gift, he needed no ladder.

"Vienna is only about thirty minutes away, so why don't you come in for a drink before you go?"

Chairwoman Kwon laughed again, saying Author Jeong had called Boris a *borisu*, "Bodhi tree." But Silvia's tall husband pointed to the Bodhi tree growing to one side of the yard and said,

"I grow it because its heart-shaped leaves are beautiful."

When Author Jeong and Mrs. Park kept turning their eyes toward the gate, Silvia said as if to reassure them,

"I will take both of you and Sonja to your lodging, then come right back. Author Jeong, if the two of you ever come to Vienna again, I will drive and guide you then as well."

Author Jeong expressed his gratitude to Chairwoman Kwon.

"Thanks to you, Chairwoman Kwon, it seems we have come to know kind Mrs. Silvia."

As if sad to part, Vito circled round and round between Boris's large legs. Boris stood there like an old tree in the garden, impassive, and waved. In saying goodbye, he showed no more emotion than necessary.

No Time Left

After returning from Montafon to Vienna, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park went to the framing shop located by the roadside at the entrance to Beethovengasse. They had visited the shop before departing for Montafon as well, only to find a sign on the door reading “On Vacation.” They had brought a painting from Korea and were looking for a suitable frame. The painting was one of the illustrations from *Montafon Moonlight*, which was already being serialized in Korea’s online Buddhist newspaper *Media Buddha*. It was the work of illustrator Jeong Yungyeong, selected by the artist herself. Rendered in an extremely simplified style, it depicted Chairwoman Kwon visiting Haein-sa with Mr. Willi and his companions to pay their respects.

But the sign reading “On Vacation” was still hanging on the shop door. How long the owner intended to remain away was anyone’s guess, but Author Jeong no longer had the luxury of waiting. He was due to leave Vienna the night after next. There was, however, one expedient solution: give the painting to Chairwoman Kwon now and have it framed later. When Chairwoman Kwon came to their lodging, Author Jeong said,

“Chairwoman Kwon, my daughter asked me to present this painting to you already framed, but since the owner of the framing shop is away on vacation, there seems to be no other way.”

“I know the owner well. He has spent his entire life running that shop, regarding it as his calling. When he returns from vacation, I will have the painting framed there.”

“If he has been running that shop in the same place all his life, then I would be pleased to have someone of his experience do the framing. Let me give you the painting now.”

“What a charming painting. Please convey my thanks to your daughter.”

When they came to Austria in September 2015, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park were accompanied by their daughter, Jeong Yungyeong. Having studied illustration at the graduate level at Kingston University in England, she had come along both to serve as a guide for her parents and to do some

sightseeing herself. During that visit, she and Chairwoman Kwon had developed a mutual fondness for one another. In any event, Author Jeong felt genuinely relieved that the matter of the frame had been resolved, even in this fashion. There were no doubt other framing shops in central Vienna, but he found the owner known to Chairwoman Kwon more trustworthy, having devoted his entire life to the trade as a calling.

The next day.

Author Jeong and Mrs. Park took a walk from their lodging to the birthplace of Franz Schubert. The house was still closed. Perhaps, they thought, it was open only from Friday through Sunday. When they returned to their lodging, Mr. Choi, an employee of Chairwoman Kwon's company, IMK, was waiting to guide them around Vienna for the morning. This, too, was a thoughtful gesture on Chairwoman Kwon's part. As they walked along the street after leaving the lodging, Author Jeong asked the younger Mr. Choi, who felt almost like a son to him,

"What brought you all the way to Austria?"

Mr. Choi answered honestly.

"I majored in trumpet at university, but I gave up the demanding life of a performer and am now learning the work of concert management."

"Does concert planning suit you?"

"I'm not sure yet. IMK presents classical concerts in a number of European cities. I travel with the team and learn as I go. My job is to arrive ahead of time in places like Paris or Prague and make the necessary preparations for the performances."

"It sounds like a good opportunity to experience unfamiliar cultures as well."

"You seem to travel quite a bit yourself, Author Jeong."

"I suppose I end up traveling abroad about once a year, and whenever I do, I invariably serialize a travelogue in a newspaper or magazine. Next month, I'm planning to visit Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan."

"I've been to Kazakhstan once myself, back when I was in the military."

"What took you there?"

"I was a trumpeter in a military band. When the remains of General Hong Beomdo, who had been buried in Kazakhstan, were repatriated to Korea, I traveled to Astana as part of the delegation."

"Are you satisfied with life here, Mr. Choi?"

"No. I'd like to return to Korea. A female employee from IMK's Seoul office has recently come over. Once she has settled in here, I expect to return to Seoul."

Like the young man he was, Mr. Choi spoke candidly, concealing nothing of what was on his mind. IMK undoubtedly hoped that young

employees would master the work of concert management and eventually become pillars of the company, but Mr. Choi seemed to be quietly enduring the loneliness of life in a foreign land. Mrs. Park stopped at a souvenir shop and selected gifts for the members of her ceramics workshop back home.

“Something compact and lightweight, like eco bags, would be ideal.”

Mrs. Park purchased five eco bags printed with Van Gogh’s *The Starry Night*. She briefly considered buying bags featuring Klimt’s *The Kiss* as well, but decided against it, thinking such a design might not appeal to everyone. Author Jeong bought three stylish leather wallets and, in a shop beside the cathedral, selected an emerald-colored portable crucifix for his younger brother, a Catholic. They then returned to their lodging and took a short nap. Having accepted an invitation to dinner from IMK President Kwon, they felt it wise to recover a bit of their energy beforehand. President Kwon, Chairwoman Kwon’s younger brother, appeared to have inherited the business and was expanding its reach through initiatives such as signing MOUs with leading music conservatories in Europe and the United States. The task of recruiting distinguished musicians such as Mr. Willi, however, was said to remain very much Chairwoman Kwon’s domain.

The restaurant to which they had been invited was a Korean establishment. Its name, Babida, struck Author Jeong as pleasantly familiar. It was almost certainly a rendering of the Korean phrase “Bap-ida” (“It’s a meal”). President Kwon ordered bulgogi, kimchi-jjigae, and pajeon. As the meal began, he spoke optimistically about the future.

“After more than forty years of doing business in Europe, it appears that we may finally enter the American market. Europe has traditionally been driven more by music education than by the commercial side of the industry, but now our company is finally preparing to establish a presence in the United States. If we succeed there and the company takes another leap forward, we will be able to provide even greater support for Korea’s young musical talent.”

President Kwon possessed a decidedly entrepreneurial temperament. If Chairwoman Kwon had established IMK’s public-spirited identity, President Kwon seemed determined to build upon that foundation and lead the company to even greater growth. Author Jeong responded with words of encouragement and good wishes.

“I hope IMK becomes a leading force in K-Classical music.”

With K-pop, K-drama, K-film, K-food, K-beauty, K-fashion, and even K-defense industries now widely recognized, it seemed only natural that there might also be such a thing as K-Classical music. Just then, the owner of Babida, a friend of President Kwon, came over, and President Kwon introduced him.

“He originally came abroad to study flute, but gave it up, opened a Korean restaurant, and has done quite well for himself.”

“I am the novelist Jeong Chanju.”

Author Jeong handed the proprietor his business card. The moment he read it, the man looked genuinely surprised and delighted.

“I read your novel *No Time Left*. Isn’t Venerable Subul a kind of sage?”

“These days, rather than calling someone a sage, we would say a ‘person of the Way,’ an ‘awakened one.’”

“When I lived in Korea, I went to temples a few times. But this is the first time I’ve met an awakened person in a novel.”

The owner of Babida went so far as to sit down beside Author Jeong and, in his Gyeongsang-do accent, ask one curious question after another about the novel. Then he called his wife over and introduced Author Jeong to her as well.

“This is the author of *No Time Left*, the book you read too. How amazing to meet him here!”

Author Jeong was equally pleased. Meeting a reader in Vienna, the capital of Austria, was an unexpected delight. During the meal, a group of a dozen or so Korean tourists rushed in, quickly finished their bibimbap, and just as quickly departed. The owner explained that they were hurrying off to secure good viewing spots for the evening city lights, which were the next stop on their itinerary. When the meal was over, President Kwon said,

“It’s not far from here. Let me take you to a quiet country café.”

The café stood amid vineyards spread across the gentle slopes on the outskirts of Vienna. From there, one could look out over both the quietly flowing Danube and the city of Vienna below. Before taking a sip of her coffee, Chairwoman Kwon said,

“I hope your trip to Austria has been a satisfying one. If there were any shortcomings, they were due to my own inadequacies in preparing for your visit. I would be grateful for your understanding.”

“Not at all, Chairwoman Kwon. For me, the opportunity to speak with Mr. Willi each day in Montafon was a genuine joy. I believe it will become a meaningful novel.”

“I hope *Montafon Moonlight* will one day be published in Korean, German, and English editions.”

“When you come to Korea, we will take good care of you. If Mr. Willi comes and stays overnight at Songgwang-sa and listens closely to the sound of the morning worship service, he will surely be inspired.”

Mrs. Park invited Chairwoman Kwon and Mr. Willi to visit Korea. It was an invitation that Author Jeong himself had long hoped to extend. The reason was simple: the scene of Mr. Willi hearing the dawn morning

worship service at Songgwang-sa—a sound like Eastern music, a sound that seemed to summon the light itself—and drawing inspiration from it deserved to bring *Montafon Moonlight* to its close. The majestic meeting, in both description and narrative, of Mr. Willi's Western music, shaped by a Christian worldview, and the Eastern music of the Buddhist morning worship service would embody the metaphorical message that *Montafon Moonlight* had been seeking all along: freedom and peace, consolation and happiness, serenity and joy. Before leaving the country café, Author Jeong spoke to Chairwoman Kwon almost as if making a personal request.

"I sincerely hope that Mr. Willi's *Jeong* will receive its premiere in Hiroshima. Hiroshima is the symbolic city of mercilessness, the place upon which the atomic bomb fell. If people are to recover compassion, then *Jeong* must be performed there."

"Please don't worry. Mr. Willi is already in communication with conductors in Japan. On the day *Jeong* receives its premiere in Hiroshima, I will be sure to invite you and Mrs. Park."

"Chairwoman Kwon, if a Japanese premiere proves difficult, then a city in Iran or Ukraine, where the scars of war remain deep, would also be fitting. It should be premiered in such a place, where it can bring comfort to wounded souls. *Jeong* is that kind of composition."

"Thank you for your advice, Author Jeong. And regarding the matter we have been hoping for, we will meet with Christoph soon and see if we can move it forward in earnest."

By then, the Danube and the city of Vienna seemed to be bowing in the deepest reverence beneath a sky washed with crimson sunset. It was the hour when the light of day willingly yielded its place to the coming night and quietly withdrew. Perhaps moved by the sacred atmosphere that lingered at the edge of the day, Chairwoman Kwon spoke in a low voice.

"For some reason, I find myself wanting to pray. For someone, that is. Author Jeong, I will send a car to your lodging by two o'clock tomorrow afternoon."

"Thank you. Please tell Mr. Willi that I sincerely hope he will come to Korea with you, Chairwoman Kwon."

In order to catch their night flight, Author Jeong and Mrs. Park would have to leave their lodging for Vienna International Airport at two o'clock that afternoon. As on their journey to Austria, the aircraft would avoid the war-torn skies over Ukraine, turn south toward the Black Sea, and then cross the Asian continent through the night. Such was war, the monster capable of altering even the pathways of the sky. Suddenly, Author Jeong found himself praying that Mr. Willi's *Jeong* might be performed somewhere, anywhere, as soon as possible. If the earth were allowed to become a

battlefield, it would be laid waste like a desert. And there was no time left for people to cross over into that Pure Land where all were meant to live together in peace.

The End

NOTES

Chapter 8, Deep Conversations Part 1 - The World Unseen (1). The word *inyeon* (인연) comes up in this passage. It's often rendered as "fate" or "destiny," but in Korean it carries the nuance of connections formed by many causes and conditions. It suggests that meetings are not mere accidents but the result of threads pulling people together. Using it here, we could say that Author Jeong means that this meeting with Teacher Willi is "karmically connected."

Chapter 8, Deep Conversations Part 1 - The World Unseen (2). I've also chosen to render Jeong's address as "Teacher Willi." In Korean, *seonsaeng* (선생) literally means "teacher," but it's also a respectful honorific for artists, professionals, and learned figures. Jeong's form, *Willi Seonsaeng ggyeseo*, shows warmth and esteem. "Teacher Willi" conveys that respect more clearly in English than "Mr. Willi" would.

Chapter 17, The Sound of Warm River Water. Musoyu 무소유 無所有. The name of Master Beopjeong's most famous essay collection and the most inspirational of his teaching concepts, that of non-possession, which meant living as an experience of "enough" rather than always "more."

Chapter 18, A Special Lecture and Recital. Francesca Donner-Rhee was South Korea's first First Lady.

Chapter 41, Montafon's Nature Sounds. Schott Music catalogs Herbert Willi's work under the title *DSONG*; its listing identifies it as an orchestral work.

GLOSSARY

- absolute silence** (절대고요) — Willi's concept - jeokmyeol
- Bae Hoon-a** (배훈아) — Nickname for Dr. Werner
- Beomnyeon-sa** (범련사) — Temple in Seoul
- Beopjeong** (법정) — Venerable Beopjeong - Korean Seon master
- bodhisattva** (보살) — Enlightened being who helps others
- Bulil-am** (불일암) — Hermitage where Beopjeong lived
- cheongsim-hwan** (청심환) — Traditional herbal medicine
- Cheonmaneyo** (천만예요) — You're welcome - Dr. Werner's phrase
- compassion** (자비) — Buddhist non-dualistic love
- Dhammapada** (법구경) — Buddhist scripture
- Francesca Donner** (프란체스카 도너) — Mrs. Francesca, wife of Dr. Rhee
- geobukseon** (거북선) — Turtle ship - ironclad warship
- gomapda** (고맙다) — Thank you
- Haein-sa** (해인사) — Major Korean temple
- hanbok** (한복) — Traditional Korean clothing
- Hangeul** (한글) — Korean alphabet
- Herbert Willi** (헤르베르트 빌리) — Austrian composer, Mr. Willi
- Hong Gisam** (홍기삼) — Professor Hong - former president of Dongguk University
- hwadu** (화두) — Seon meditation question - keep italicized
- Ibuljae** (이불재) — Author Jeong's mountain retreat home
- Ihwajang** (이화장) — Dr. Rhee's residence
- inyeon** (인연) — Karmic connection - keep italicized
- jeokmyeol** (적멸) — Absolute stillness
- Jeollanam-do** (전라남도) — South Jeolla Province
- jeong** (정) — Deep affection/connection - keep italicized

Jeong Chanju (정찬주) — Author - protagonist, Buddhist novelist
jin'gong (진공) — True emptiness
King Sejong (세종대왕) — King Sejong the Great
kong (공) — Emptiness
Kwon Suk-nyeo (권숙녀) — Chairwoman Kwon / Sonja Steindl-Kwon
Montafon (몬타폰) — Alpine valley in Austria, Willi's home
Muryanggwang (무량광) — Mrs. Park's dharma name
Musoyu (무소유) — Non-possession - Beopjeong's philosophy
Muyeon (무염) — Author Jeong's dharma name
nirvana (열반) — Liberation from suffering
Palsangdo (팔상도) — Eight Scenes of the Buddha's Life
panokseon (판옥선) — Main warship type
Park Myeongsuk (박명숙) — Mrs. Park - ceramic artist, Jeong's wife
samadhi (삼매) — Deep meditative concentration
Seon (선) — Korean Seon Buddhism
Seongcheol (성철) — Venerable Seongcheol - famous Seon master
Shinmi (신미) — Monk Shinmi - created Hangeul with Sejong
Ssangbong-sa (쌍봉사) — Temple below Ibuljae
Syngman Rhee (이승만) — Dr. Rhee - Korea's first president
Taegeukgi (태극기) — Korean national flag
Vienna (빈) — Capital of Austria
Werner Stockinger (베르너 슈토킹거) — Dr. Werner / Dr. Bae
Yi Sun-sin (이순신) — Admiral Yi Sun-sin